



INTERNATIONAL OLYMPIC ACADEMY



Olympic Studies



32nd

INTERNATIONAL SEMINAR
ON OLYMPIC STUDIES FOR POSTGRADUATE STUDENTS

ANCIENT OLYMPIA



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Published by the International Olympic Academy

Athens, 2026

International Olympic Academy

52, Dimitrios Vikelas Avenue

152 33 Halandri, Athens

GREECE

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Editor: Konstantinos Georgiadis

Editorial Coordination: Roula Vathi

Photographs: IOA Photographic Archives

ISBN: 978-960-9454-76-6

ISSN: 2654-1343

Printed by:

PRINTFAIR

3, Violettas st. & Andrianou, Acharnes

T.: 210 2469799, 210 2401695

www.printfair.gr | e-mail: offers@printfair.gr

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19 SEPTEMBER–11 OCTOBER 2025

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KONSTANTINOS GEORGIADIS
Professor, University of the Peloponnese
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32ND INTERNATIONAL SEMINAR
ON OLYMPIC STUDIES FOR
POSTGRADUATE STUDENTS

18 September - 11 October

MIE IN
OLYMPIC

FOREWORD

The International Olympic Academy, since its establishment and up to the present day, has served as the leading international institution for the study, research, and dissemination of the principles and values of Olympism. Through its educational and academic programmes, it seeks to create a global network of young scholars, researchers, and sport administrators who will actively contribute to the promotion of Olympic ideals within their respective societies.

Within the framework of this mission, the 32nd International Seminar on Olympic Studies for Postgraduate Students was held in Ancient Olympia from 19 September to 11 October 2025. The Seminar focused on the main theme, *“The Olympic Games and the Olympic Movement: Past, Present and Future – An Analysis from Historical, Philosophical and Social Perspectives”*, while its special theme was *“The Olympic Movement and Artificial Intelligence: Opportunities and Challenges.”* These two thematic axes provided participants with the opportunity to explore both the enduring values of Olympism and the emerging issues arising within the contemporary technological and social environment.

The Seminar brought together 16 participants from 10 countries, representing diverse academic disciplines and cultural backgrounds. Their presence once again confirmed the international character of the International Olympic Academy and the enduring appeal of Olympic education among the new generation of researchers and academics. Throughout the three-week programme, a meaningful dialogue developed around the history, philosophy, sociology, and contemporary realities of the Olympic Movement within an environment that encourages the free exchange of ideas, mutual respect, and international cooperation.

Particular emphasis was placed on the study of Olympism as a living humanistic philosophy that continues to offer valuable responses to contemporary challenges. Participants had the opportunity to examine the role of sport in promoting peace, solidarity, and intercultural understanding, while also reflecting on the ways in which technological developments, and particularly artificial

intelligence, may influence the future of sport and Olympic education. Through lectures, discussions, and the exchange of experiences, the need to preserve the human-centred character of the Olympic Movement in an era of rapid change was clearly highlighted.

At the same time, residence in Ancient Olympia offered participants a unique experiential learning opportunity. Contact with the birthplace of the Olympic Games, visits to the archaeological sites, and daily life within the premises of the International Olympic Academy contributed significantly to a deeper understanding of the historical continuity of the Olympic ideal. The integration of theoretical knowledge with the symbolism and cultural heritage of Olympia has long been one of the defining characteristics of the Academy's educational programmes.

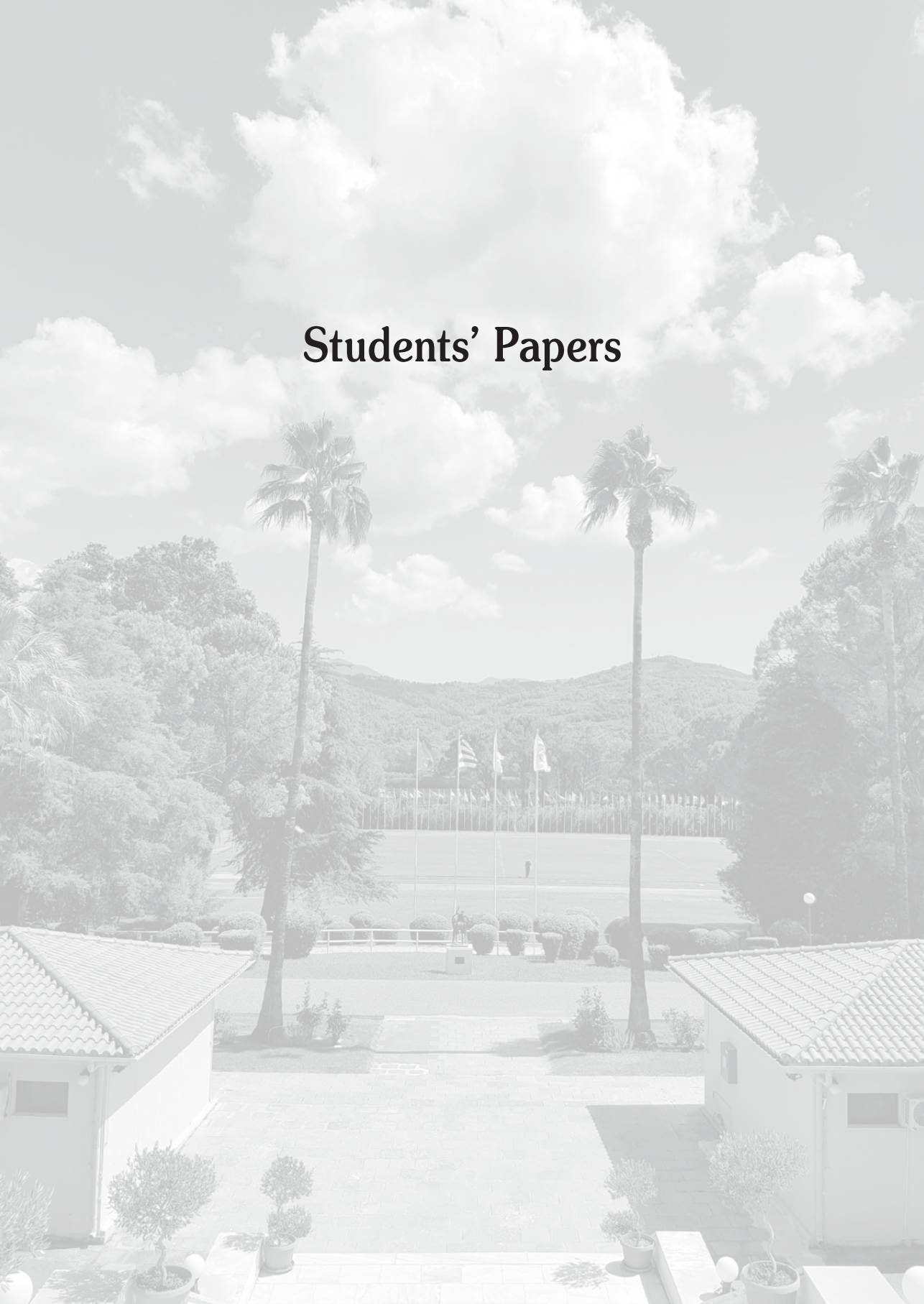
This publication presents the content, activities, and principal outcomes of the 32nd International Seminar on Olympic Studies for Postgraduate Students. At the same time, it records the contribution of the distinguished lecturers and participants to the creation of a stimulating academic environment that enhanced scientific knowledge and promoted international dialogue on contemporary issues related to Olympism.

The International Olympic Academy extends its sincere gratitude to all those who contributed to the success of the Seminar: the participants, lecturers, collaborators, and members of staff. Their dedication, academic excellence, and spirit of cooperation reaffirm that Olympic education continues to serve as a powerful means of fostering values, knowledge, and international understanding.

With the conviction that the experiences and knowledge gained in Ancient Olympia will continue to inspire participants throughout their academic and professional journeys, we dedicate this publication to all those who believe that sport can make a meaningful contribution to the creation of a more just, peaceful, and humane world.

Prof. Konstantinos GEORGIADIS
University of the Peloponnese
IOA Dean

Students' Papers



Excerpt from Pierre de Coubertin Writings

"It is not just internationalism and democracy, the foundations of the new human society now being constructed in civilized nations, but science as well that is involved in this sentiment. Through its constant progress, science has given man new ways to cultivate his body, to guide and strengthen nature, and to snatch the body from the constraints of unbridled passions to which it had become subject in the name of individual freedom."

"The philosophic foundation of modern Olympism", in *Le Sport Suisse*, vol. 31, August 7, 1935, p. 1 (*Pierre de Coubertin (1863-1937), Olympism, Selected Writings*, Norbert Müller (ed.), Lausanne, IOC, 2000, p. 580)



«Ce ne sont pas seulement l'Internationalisme et la Démocratie, assises de la nouvelle société humaine en voie d'édification chez les nations civilisées, c'est aussi la Science qui est intéressée en cela. Par ses progrès continus, elle a fourni à l'homme de nouveaux moyens de cultiver son corps, de guider, de redresser la nature, et d'arracher ce corps à l'étreinte de passions déréglées auxquelles, sous prétexte de liberté individuelle, on le laissait s'abandonner.»

«Les assises philosophiques de l'Olympisme moderne», dans *Le Sport Suisse*, vol. 31, 7 août 1935, p. 1.

The opinions of the students do not necessarily reflect those of the International Olympic Academy. Out of respect for multiculturalism and diversity of scientific research, we do not intervene in each student's way of presenting his/her bibliography and footnotes.

ANALYSING ENVIRONMENTAL LESSONS FROM PARIS OLYMPIC GAMES TO PROMOTE SUSTAINABLE SPORT SPONSORSHIP FOR SOUTH AFRICAN SPORT FEDERATIONS¹

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ABSTRACT

The world is faced with environmental issues such as high greenhouse gas which is expected to increase between 2.1 °C and 3.9 °C by the year 2100. Human activities are the primary cause of greenhouse gas emissions and if these activities are not efficiently managed, they will pose a threat to sport environment.

Sport plays a pivotal role in sustainable development by creating a balance between peoples' well-being, economic benefits for sport federations and safeguarding the planet by promoting environmental awareness. However, sport simultaneously suffers from and also contributes to environmental issues. International sporting events impact the natural environment the most through deforestation creating plastic and food waste, as well as high use of transport that releases carbon emissions. Lastly, sport also has direct and indirect high-water consumption.

Therefore, sport must manage and mitigate its environmental impact. If the environmental impact of sport is not managed effectively, it will pose a threat to

1. Mini-Thesis Research Proposal.

human health and environmental sustainability, which are the main elements that sport requires to survive. To mitigate this crisis, the International Olympic Committee (IOC) is using sport as a tool to build a better world that protects the natural environment for future generations. Hence, this study aims to analyse environmental lessons from the Paris Olympic Games in order to promote sustainable sport sponsorship for South African Sport Federations.

In South Africa there is a lack of a sustainable sport sponsorship model that helps sport federations to reduce their environmental impact. This leads to the research question: How can sport federations use sustainable sport sponsorship to reduce environmental impact? The research aim is to investigate how sport federations can use sustainable sport sponsorship to reduce environmental impact. A qualitative research method will be adopted to analyse the Paris Olympic Games secondary data and to conduct interviews with IOC sponsorship experts. The desired goal is to encourage sport federations to protect the natural environment and to create environmental awareness in sponsors and spectators.

RESEARCH BACKGROUND

The world is in a climate emergency crisis; countries are faced with climate related disasters due to the growth of greenhouse gas which continues to be a threat to the environment and sport. To respond to this challenge, the IOC is leveraging sport to promote and safeguard the natural environment for future generations (IOC, 2017). Hence, this study aims to draw environmental lessons on how sustainable sport sponsorship was used to reduce the carbon footprint of the Paris Olympics Games in 2024.

PROBLEM STATEMENT

Climate change is one of the most pressing global issues to date, with the current level of greenhouse gas (GHG) expected to rise between 2.1°C and 3.9°C by the year 2100 (Kemp et al. 2022 Lyon et al, 2022). The above rise of GHG is higher than the target that was set at the Paris Treaty which aimed to keep GHG below 1.5°C. Several studies have mentioned that human activities are the primary cause of greenhouse gas emissions and if these activities are not efficiently managed this will pose a threat to sport.

The United Nations (UN) has recognised sports as a promoter of sustainable development (United Nations, 2015). Cain and Callan (2025) cited that sport is the driver of sustainable development by creating a balance between well-being of people, financial benefits through sport and protection of the natural environment as people are playing sport. However, the sporting industry is simultaneously experiencing environmental challenges and also contributes to the existing environmental problems. Mega sporting events contribute the most to environmental challenges through activities such as deforestation when building stadiums and producing sporting equipment, staging sporting events with high plastic packaging and food waste, and depending heavily on air transportation with its high carbon emissions and sporting facilities with high water and energy consumption (Cain & Callan, 2025). Thus, sport federations must be able to measure and manage their environmental impact effectively. Failing to do so will pose a threat to human health and environmental sustainability, which are the essential components for the sustainability of sport. To address this challenge, IOC is using sport as a vehicle for environmental protection and to enhance international awareness to create a better world for the next generations. Therefore, this study aims to evaluate the environmental lessons that can be adopted from Paris Olympic Games to encourage sustainable sport sponsorship for South African Sport Federations.

Sport federations play a role in tackling their environmental footprints. However, in South Africa, there is a lack of a sustainable sport sponsorship model that will help sport federations to reduce their environmental impact.

RESEARCH QUESTION

How can sport federations use sustainable sport sponsorship to reduce environmental impact in South Africa?

RESEARCH AIM

To investigate how sport federations can use sustainable sport sponsorship to reduce environmental impact in South Africa.

METHODOLOGY

The study will use a qualitative method where secondary data about the

environmental impact of the Paris Olympic Games will be analysed. Interviews will be conducted with IOC sponsorship experts to gain knowledge.

RESEARCH SIGNIFICANCE

This research study aims to contribute to the body of knowledge and help South African sports federations to be environmentally sustainable. Also, it aims to help to raise awareness amongst sponsors so they can engage in sustainable sponsorship deals.

RESEARCH THEORY

This study will use a stakeholder theory, as it highlights that sport federations should not harm the natural environment in pursuit of profit. This theory further advocates that sport federations should create a positive outcome for all stakeholders.

POTENTIAL OUTCOME

This research study will expose how sport federations and sponsors can use sustainable sport sponsorship to reduce their environmental impact.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Definition of Concepts

- Sustainable Development

Sustainable development is defined as development which serves the current needs of the society without jeopardising the needs of the future generation (England 1993; WCED 1987). According to the World Commission on Environment and Development (WCED, 1987), commonly known as the Brundtland Report, sports federations should not be profit-orientated at the expense of people and the environment, and hence it is essential for sports federations to understand the limitations to resources.

- Natural Environment

Natural environment is defined as the physical world that exist around individuals and consists of living and non-living spheres that provide people with the resources to enjoy life and sport (McIsaac & Brün 1999).

- Sustainable Sponsorship

The study conducted by Grunwald & Spillan (2025) defined sustainable sponsorship as activities that are targeted towards making a contribution to sustainable development within a society by solving social, economic and environmental issues while ensuring that both the sponsor and the rightsholders get value from the deal.

- IOC

The International Olympic Committee, which is famously known by the acronym IOC, is the governing body of the Olympic Movement that is vital in promoting peace, sustainable development through sport, and speaks to the advancement of Olympism (olympics.com 2025)

- Definition of Climate Change

According to Pielke (2004), conflicting definitions of climate change between the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) and the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) result in delays to the development of climate policy. The UNFCCC (1992: p. 7), defines climate change as “a change of climate which is attributed directly or indirectly to human activity that alters the composition of the global atmosphere and which is in addition to natural climate variability observed over comparable time periods.” However, the IPCC (2011: p. 1) defines climate change as “the change in the state of the climate that can be identified and quantified (e.g. using statistical tests) by changes in the mean and/or the variability of its properties, and that persists for an extended period, typically decades or longer. It refers to any change in climate over time, whether due to natural variability or because of human activity.”

Impact of Climate Change on the Environment

There is enough scientific evidence demonstrating the impact of the increase in temperatures on oceans between the 20th and the 21st century (Allison,

Bindoff, Cox, Noblet, England & Weaver, 2009; Thompson, Mosley-Thompson, Davis, and Brecher, 2017; Singer, Legates, Lupo & Happer, 2021). In 2024, the world surpassed the global warming limit of 1.5 degrees Celsius set in the Paris Climate Agreement for the first time since the limit was established in 2015 (Steiger & Scott, 2024). International temperatures have been increasing at an unprecedented rate. High global temperatures harm the land and the ocean as sea levels are increasing due to thermal expansion and melting ice in Greenland and Antarctica (NCCS, 2025). According to the IPCC report (2019), the average mountain temperatures have increased by 0.3 degrees Celsius per decade in Western North America, Mountain Asia and the European Alps. These Northern Hemisphere temperature rates have surpassed the average international global warming rate of 0.2 degrees Celsius since the beginning of the twentieth century (IPCC, 2019).

Effects of Sport on the Natural Environment

Sport promotes sustainable development by enhancing communities' well-being, supporting federations' financial growth, and promoting environmental awareness. However, global sporting events affect the environment the most through human activities such as deforestation, plastic food waste that contributes to GHG emission, overuse of air travel transportation when travelling to and from the Games, releasing carbon emissions that negatively affect the natural environment. Also, sport has facilities that require a lot of water and energy to keep open for sporting events (Wilby et al 2023). Ross and Orr (2022) and Hollander, Steyn & Roux (2012) mentioned that a skills deficiency in strategic and contingency planning within sports federations results in a lack of ability to address environmental issues. Saayman (2004) stated that it is imperative to educate and train sport administrators to ensure that sporting events are organised in a strategic manner that enhances environmental sustainability.

Failure to manage the environmental impact of sport is detrimental to health and the natural environment at large. If no action is taken, this will threaten the sustainability of humanity and the natural environment. The IOC is intentional in using sport as catalyst to promote environmental awareness due to the viewership that it generates during these international events.

IOC's Role in Environmental Sustainability

The IOC is embarking on a journey of building a better world through sport by supporting sustainability programmes that solve these life issues. Aligning with the Olympic Agenda 2020+5, the IOC's mission is to reduce its environmental impact while creating a positive social, economic and environmental impact (Olympics.com).

The IOC's Olympism365 Strategy

The IOC is also applying the Olympism365 strategy to enhance its strategy of using sport as an enabler of the sustainable development goals (SDGs). The following are the objectives of the Olympism365 strategy;

- Ensuring more people, from more diverse backgrounds, benefit from community sport programmes
 - Improving sport-related collaboration between sport movements and social development sectors
- (Olympics.com 2025).

Paris 2024 Environmental Goals

According to Olympics.com (2025), the Paris Olympics Games were the first event to be aligned with the Olympic Agenda 2020 which advocates for the integration of sustainability into all Olympics Games, maximising environmental sustainability and encouraging host cities to use existing sports facilities. The Paris Olympics has managed to reduce its environmental impact as follows:

• Emissions Reduction

According to the IOC annual report (2024) and Olympics.com (2025), the Paris Olympics Games reduced its direct and indirect carbon emissions by 54% compared to London 2012, and Rio 2016. This feat was achieved through smart traveling as 87% of spectators used public or active transport. This was the first Olympic Games to be committed to the Paris Agreement on climate change.

• Transport

The venues were located within a 10km radius of the Olympic Village, which promoted active transport such as cycling or walking. The event used electric,

hydrogen-powered and hybrid vehicles supplied by the Olympic partner Toyota. This resulted in a 37% fleet reduction (IOC annual report 2024; Olympic.com 2025).

- Venues

The Paris 2024 Games managed to reduce its carbon emissions by implementing the IOC's recommendation to use existing or temporary facilities, which made up 95% of the venues used (Olympics.com). The Aquatics Centre had a renewable energy roof, supplying 20% of the electricity needs, seats were made from recycled bottle caps, the roof frame was made from bio-sourced material. This resulted in saving 60% of water due to smart design (IOC annual report 2024). There were 102 trees planted to reduce the impact of deforestation.

- The Olympic Village

The Olympic Village was built with 30% carbon emission, which is the minimum emission when compared to construction standards, while 94% of the material used was from deconstruction. The energy used was sourced from solar panels and, using geothermal cooling, the walls had insulated facades which keep the apartment cooler in summer and warmer in winter (Olympics.com).

- Energy

The Paris Olympic Games used 100% renewable energy that was sourced locally.

- Food

Olympic.com (2025) mentioned that the carbon footprint on meals was reduced by half by supplying spectators with plant-based foods. Foods that contained single use plastic were reduced by 52%, while the catering equipment was 100% reusable after the games. This resulted in food waste being reduced by 60% (IOC Annual Report 2024).

- Beverages

Coca-Cola installed refillable water stations to reduce the impact of plastic packaging (IOC Annual Report 2024; Olympics.com).

IOC Climate Action

The IOC and its partner Deloitte launched the Climate Action Awards to motivate its direct stakeholders, being athletes, International Federations and the National Olympic Committees, to host environmentally friendly events to mitigate climate change issues (IOC Annual Report 2024).

The IOC is dedicated to using sport as a tool for social change.

Stakeholder Theory

According to Mahajan et al (2023), stakeholder theory was first derived from business ethics. Stakeholder theory states that an organisation's purpose is not only to generate profit but to generate multiple benefits for each different stakeholder. Goodpaster (1991) further mentions that organisations should not endeavour to make profit by harming another stakeholder.

This theory is relevant to this study because sport federations should not try to make profit or achieve their goals at the expense of the natural environment as it is a stakeholder. Therefore, in order for sport federations to align themselves with the principles of stakeholder theory, they must engage in sustainable sport sponsorship.

Sustainable Sport Sponsorships

Sustainable sport sponsorship encourages brands and sport federations to cover the three sustainability pillars: social, environmental and economic.

- Social sustainability

Sponsorship deals should support or solve community social issues, for instance by promoting the well-being of societies to promote the health of community members.

- Environmental sustainability

Sport federations must consider taking care of the natural environment that sport is dependent on to promote sustainability for the next generation.

- Economic sustainability

After these two sustainability factors, sport federations can then endeavour to

generate profit as this will mean the profit is not generated at the expense of the other stakeholder.

Use of Artificial Intelligence

Artificial intelligence (AI) can play a pivotal role in sport sponsorship by monitoring how sponsorship is performing in real time and suggesting strategies to mitigate such campaigns.

During live games, AI can be used to detect ambush marketers in real time and this will help stop them before they gain traction on social media, which is the end goal of an ambusher.

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HARNESSING ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE TO EMPOWER THE PARALYMPIC MOVEMENT: A PATHWAY TO INCLUSION, TALENT DISCOVERY, AND PERFORMANCE ADVANCEMENT

J. Lahiru WIJAYANTHA (SRI)

University of Colombo – Faculty of Arts

Abstract

Artificial intelligence (AI) is fundamentally reshaping the landscape of human performance, offering paradigm-shifting tools for identification, optimisation, and support. This study investigates the application of AI within the Paralympic Movement, positing that it holds unique potential to expand inclusion, mitigate bias, enhance athletic performance, and fortify long-term athlete development. Employing a qualitative methodology, semi-structured interviews were conducted with key stakeholders – Paralympic athletes, coaches, administrators, and technology experts – to capture lived experiences and professional insights. The findings reveal that AI is perceived as a transformative force in three key areas: (1) democratising talent discovery by identifying potential in underrepresented and rural populations; (2) personalising training and injury prevention through advanced biomechanical analysis; and (3) refining athlete classification systems for greater fairness. However, this potential is contingent upon the responsible navigation of significant ethical and social challenges, including the digital divide, algorithmic bias, and data privacy. The study concludes that for AI to truly empower the Paralympic Movement, its implementation must be guided by the core values of equity, fairness, and human-centric design, ensuring technology acts as a servant to, and not a master of, the Movement's humanitarian ethos.

Keywords: Artificial Intelligence, Paralympic Sport, Inclusion, Talent Identification, Ethics, Athlete Classification, Qualitative Research

1. Introduction

The Paralympic Movement stands as a powerful global force, championing the rights, capabilities, and sporting excellence of athletes with disabilities. From its foundational ethos at Stoke Mandeville, where sport was recognised as a profound medium for rehabilitation and social integration, the Movement has evolved into a world-class spectacle that challenges perceptions and inspires millions (Brittain, 2016). However, despite its remarkable growth, the Movement continues to grapple with persistent challenges, including inequitable access to resources, geographical and economic barriers to talent discovery, and the perpetual need to ensure classification systems are both fair and transparent.

In this context, the emergence of artificial intelligence (AI) presents a unique and timely opportunity. As Burkett (2010) notes, technology in Paralympic sport has always occupied a dual role, often being essential for performance rather than merely enhancing it. AI, as the defining technology of the 21st century, extends this principle beyond physical aids like prosthetic limbs and racing chairs. It encompasses sophisticated systems capable of pattern recognition, predictive analytics, and personalised optimisation. As Baca and Kornfeind (2012) demonstrated in elite able-bodied sport with rapid feedback systems, AI can process vast datasets from video, wearable sensors, and biomechanical tools to provide insights previously inaccessible to coaches and athletes.

This paper argues that AI can be strategically harnessed to address core challenges within the Paralympic ecosystem. It can widen the talent net by analysing video footage from local competitions in underserved regions, personalising training regimens to account for an athlete's specific impairment, and providing data-driven insights to support robust and objective classification. The International Paralympic Committee (IPC) itself has begun to explore this frontier, considering the role of AI in the future of athlete classification (IPC, 2023).

However, the integration of such a powerful technology is not without its perils. The potential for algorithmic bias, where AI systems inadvertently discriminate against certain types of impairments or demographic groups, poses a significant threat to the Movement's commitment to fairness. Furthermore, the "digital divide" could exacerbate existing inequalities if advanced AI tools become the exclusive domain of wealthy nations and well-funded programmes. Data privacy, particularly concerning sensitive health and physiological information about athletes with disabilities, is another critical concern.

Therefore, this research seeks to answer the central question: How can artificial intelligence be responsibly and effectively leveraged to foster inclusion, enhance talent discovery, and advance performance within the Paralympic Movement? Through qualitative engagement with the very stakeholders at the heart of this potential transformation, this study maps the opportunities, identifies the pitfalls, and proposes a pathway for an ethical and empowering AI integration aligned with the fundamental values of the Paralympics.

2. Methodology

This study employed a qualitative research design, utilising semi-structured interviews as the primary method of data collection. This approach was selected for its capacity to elicit rich, detailed, and nuanced insights into the perceptions, experiences, and anticipations of diverse stakeholders regarding the complex and emergent topic of AI in Paralympic sport (Creswell & Poth, 2018). The flexible nature of semi-structured interviews allowed for the exploration of predetermined themes while permitting participants to introduce new, unanticipated ideas.

2.1 Participant Recruitment and Profile

A purposive sampling strategy was used to identify and recruit participants from four key stakeholder groups central to the Paralympic ecosystem:

1. Paralympic Athletes (n=5): Representing a range of sports and impairment types.
2. Coaches and Trainers (n=4): With direct experience in developing Paralympic talent.
3. Administrators/Policy Makers (n=3): From national and international sporting bodies.
4. Technology Experts (n=3): Including AI developers and sport scientists with an interest in disability sport.

In total, 15 participants were interviewed. All participants provided informed consent and the study was conducted in accordance with standard ethical principles for research with human subjects.

2.2 Data Collection

The interview protocol was designed based on the research questions, leading to the creation of a tailored questionnaire for each stakeholder group (as outlined in the initial draft). Key thematic areas included:

- Perceptions of AI's role in talent discovery and performance.
- Envisioned benefits and practical challenges.
- Ethical, social, and policy considerations.
- Visions for inclusive development.

Interviews were conducted virtually via video conference, each lasting approximately 30–45 minutes. They were audio-recorded with permission and subsequently transcribed verbatim for analysis.

2.3 Data Analysis

The transcribed data were analysed using thematic analysis, following the process outlined by Braun and Clarke (2006). This involved familiarisation with the data, generating initial codes, searching for themes, reviewing themes, defining and naming themes, and producing the report. This iterative process ensured that the findings were deeply grounded in the participants' own words and perspectives.

3. Results

The analysis of the interview data revealed several prominent themes, which are organised below into the key areas of investigation.

3.1 Theme 1: AI in Talent Discovery – Democratising and De-biasing Identification

A strong consensus emerged across all groups that AI holds immense promise for revolutionising talent identification. Coaches and administrators highlighted the current reliance on “traditional scouting networks” which often overlook athletes in rural or less-developed regions. A coach noted, “We miss so much potential because we simply don't have the eyes on the ground in every community.”

Participants envisioned AI-powered tools that could analyse publicly available or locally recorded video footage from school competitions or community events. A technology expert suggested that computer vision algorithms could be trained to

identify key biomechanical or physiological attributes correlated with potential in specific sports, regardless of the athlete's current level of coaching or equipment.

Furthermore, administrators and athletes alike pointed to AI's potential to reduce human bias in initial evaluations. An athlete stated, "Sometimes, a scout might have a preconceived notion about what an athlete with my type of impairment can do. An AI, if designed correctly, could look purely at the physical data and see raw potential." However, a technology expert crucially warned of the risk of "algorithmic bias", where an AI trained predominantly on data from one demographic or impairment group could perform poorly when assessing others, thus perpetuating existing inequalities.

3.2 Theme 2: AI in Performance Optimisation and Injury Prevention

This was the most frequently discussed benefit among athletes and coaches. The potential for AI to personalise training was a recurring topic. Coaches described how AI could synthesise data from wearables (heart rate, power output, movement patterns) with video analysis to create highly individualised training programmes. "Two athletes with the same classification can have very different physiological responses", explained a coach. "AI could help me tailor every session to maximise each athlete's adaptation while minimising fatigue and injury risk."

The link between personalised monitoring and injury prevention was strongly emphasised. AI systems could identify subtle deviations in an athlete's movement patterns that precede overuse injuries, allowing for pre-emptive intervention. An athlete shared, "As a wheelchair racer, the slightest change in my pushing technique can lead to a shoulder injury that sets me back for months. If AI could flag that early, it would be a game-changer."

Regarding the role of the coach, there was universal agreement that AI would act as a support tool, not a replacement. "AI gives me the data, but I provide the context, the motivation, the human understanding", one coach summarised. The synergy between human expertise and machine intelligence was seen as the ideal model.

3.3 Theme 3: Ethical and Social Considerations – The Preconditions for Success

While excited about the potential, all participants voiced significant ethical concerns. The digital divide was the most prominent. Administrators questioned

how to ensure equitable access, fearing that AI could “create a two-tiered system where only the wealthiest programmes can afford the competitive edge.” Suggestions included developing open-source AI tools and fostering international collaborations to subsidise technology transfer.

Data privacy was a paramount concern for athletes. They expressed unease about who would own their sensitive biomechanical and health data, how it would be stored, and for what other purposes it might be used. “My body data is my identity”, one athlete asserted. “I need guarantees that it’s protected and used only for my benefit.”

Finally, the issue of algorithmic bias and fairness was deeply explored. Technology experts stressed that “garbage in, garbage out” is a fundamental principle of AI. If the data used to train systems for classification or talent ID is not representative of the full spectrum of global Paralympic athletes, the AI’s decisions will be inherently biased. This requires deliberate, inclusive data collection and continuous auditing of AI systems.

3.4 Theme 4: AI and Inclusive Sport Development – The Future of Classification

Participants, especially administrators and technology experts, saw a transformative role for AI in athlete classification. The current system, while refined over decades, relies on human judgment and can be subject to controversy. AI was proposed as a tool to provide an objective, data-driven layer of support. By analysing quantitative biomechanical data (e.g., range of motion, force production, coordination metrics) against competitive performance, AI could help validate and refine classification categories, making them more evidence-based and transparent.

This, in turn, was seen as strengthening the integrity of competition and fostering greater inclusion by ensuring that athletes compete against others with a similar level of activity limitation. As one administrator put it, “The goal is fair competition. If AI can help us get closer to that ideal by providing unbiased data, it strengthens the entire Movement.”

4. Discussion

The findings of this study align with and extend the existing literature on technology in sport while foregrounding the unique imperatives of the Paralympic

context. The enthusiasm for AI in talent discovery echoes the “standard model of talent development” critique by Bailey and Collins (2013), who argue for more inclusive and systematic approaches to finding potential. AI offers a practical mechanism to realise this, moving beyond traditional, often exclusive, scouting pathways.

The emphasis on personalised performance optimisation directly builds upon the work of Baca and Kornfeind (2012) on rapid feedback systems. However, in Paralympic sport, this personalisation is not just about optimising performance but is often about adapting training to the specific physiological and biomechanical realities of an impairment, underscoring Burkett’s (2010) assertion that technology can be essential for performance.

The significant ethical concerns raised by participants are a critical contribution to the field. They serve as a stark reminder that technological advancement must be coupled with robust ethical frameworks. The digital divide threat resonates with broader critiques of technology and global inequality. The solution, as suggested by participants, lies in proactive policy, as hinted at by the IOC’s (2022) focus on values-based technology integration. This requires the IPC and national bodies to establish clear guidelines on data ownership, privacy, and mandatory bias auditing for any approved AI systems.

The potential of AI in classification is perhaps the most paradigm-shifting finding. It addresses a core, and often contentious, aspect of Paralympic sport. By contributing objective data, AI can help depersonalise and legitimise the classification process, protecting the integrity of sport and the rights of athletes, a concern central to the IPC’s own future-looking agenda (IPC, 2023).

Ultimately, this study suggests that the successful integration of AI into the Paralympic Movement depends on viewing it not as a silver bullet, but as a powerful tool that must be subordinated to the Movement’s human-centric values. The goal is not to create a technologically determined sport but to use technology to enhance human potential and deepen the commitment to inclusion and fair play, principles that have been the bedrock of the Movement since its inception at Stoke Mandeville.

5. Conclusion

This research demonstrates that artificial intelligence possesses transformative potential for the Paralympic Movement, offering innovative pathways to overcome

long-standing challenges in talent discovery, performance enhancement, and inclusive classification. The insights from athletes, coaches, administrators, and technologists paint a picture of a future where AI acts as a powerful ally, widening the net for potential champions, personalising training with unprecedented precision, and bolstering the fairness of competition.

However, this promising future is not guaranteed. It is contingent upon a committed, collaborative, and ethically grounded approach to implementation. The risks of the digital divide, algorithmic bias, and data privacy breaches are real and could, if left unaddressed, undermine the very values of inclusion and fairness that the Movement seeks to promote.

Therefore, the pathway forward must be navigated with caution and principle. International sporting bodies, national Paralympic committees, technology developers, and athlete representatives must collaborate to establish:

1. Equitable Access Frameworks to prevent a technological arms race and ensure global benefit.
2. Robust Ethical Charters governing data privacy, ownership, and usage.
3. Transparent Processes for the auditing and validation of AI systems to mitigate bias.

In conclusion, when harnessed with wisdom and a steadfast commitment to the Paralympic Movement's core values, AI can be a profoundly empowering force for the Movement. It can help build a future where every athlete with disability, regardless of origin or background, has a fair and supported opportunity to reach their full potential, both in sport and in life. The task ahead is to ensure that this powerful technology serves humanity, and in doing so, strengthens the inspirational power of the Paralympic spirit.

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A ROADMAP FOR ETHICAL AI IN SPORT

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Abstract

Artificial intelligence (AI) is increasingly being used in sport, from training and performance to coaching, injury prevention, referee support, fan engagement, and integrity measures such as anti-doping and match-fixing detection. As its adoption spreads, ethical issues remain largely unexamined. Creating effective guidelines requires striking a balance between general principles and stakeholder protection. This article proposes a multidisciplinary approach, drawing on philosophical traditions such as virtue ethics and deontology, applying a human rights perspective to stakeholders, and categorising AI applications according to risk.

Introduction

To frame the ethical debate on AI in sport, it is essential to define what constitutes artificial intelligence. The European Commission (2018) describes AI as systems capable of displaying intelligent behaviour by analysing their environment and taking action, often with a degree of autonomy, to achieve specific goals. These AI systems can exist solely in software form, operating in virtual domains such as voice assistants, image analysis tools, search engines, or facial recognition systems, or they can be integrated into physical hardware, including robots, autonomous vehicles, drones, and Internet of Things (IoT) applications.

The rapid development of AI is highlighting the shortcomings of regulatory and ethical frameworks in sport with increasing clarity. AI's use has expanded from early applications in training, performance, and coaching to supporting fan engagement and protecting game integrity by detecting banned substances or preventing match-fixing. While these systems offer efficiency and novel insights, their adoption also introduces significant risks, such as privacy violations, biased decision-making, and unequal access. For instance, according to the SHARE 2.0 Community of Practice on innovation members (2025), AI tools designed for performance improvement or officiating assistance require significant customisation to be effective for athletes in each specific sport. As a result, widely practised sports, such as football, tend to have greater access to tailored AI tools, while niche sports may face challenges in finding software suited to their needs. SHARE 2.0 also highlights that applying AI solutions developed for one sport to another can risk delivering suboptimal recommendations for individual athletes, emphasising the importance of context-specific adaptation when integrating AI into sports practice.

While some ethicists have started to look into these issues (Fierens & De Bruyne, 2020; Carrio, 2021), there isn't a lot of literature available. The limited discussion about the ethics of AI in sports is due to its recent emergence. Many believe that areas like warfare, healthcare, education, and democracy present more urgent ethical challenges. Nonetheless, given the significant social importance of sports and their dependence on integrity, a detailed examination of the ethical implications of AI in this area is necessary.

Despite frequent mentions of sports values in academic and organisational talks, these principles are often applied inconsistently. Governance in sports has long been criticised for lacking transparency, democracy, and accountability (Henry & Lee, 2004; Chappelet & Mrkonjic, 2013). Without clear ethical guidelines for AI, current governance issues may worsen. The autonomy of sports governing bodies adds to the problem, increasing fears that AI could deepen power imbalances by concentrating control among organisations, teams, and corporations at the cost of individual athletes.

Another trend that highlights the need for ethical reflection on AI in sports is the rising presence of "arms race" narratives in both Olympic competition and AI development (Allen & Husain, 2017). Cave and Óhéigeartaigh point out that such narratives can normalise the neglect of ethical safeguards in the quest for technological dominance. Similarly, Hagendorff (2020) argues that AI research

often resembles a competitive race rather than global cooperation, promoting carelessness, oppression, and hierarchies. These dynamics echo the nationalistic and competitive narratives that have historically characterised sports (De Bosscher, 2008). In this context, widespread AI use in sports may exacerbate nationalist rivalries and amplify existing pressures for technological superiority.

Concrete AI applications in sports also threaten fundamental rights and core values like fairness and humanity. For instance, AI-enabled body sensors provide immediate feedback to help prevent injuries and improve skill development. They process data more efficiently than humans. However, the benefits of these tools often overshadow the urgent ethical concerns they raise.

AI has the potential to analyse millions of data points generated by each athlete. Performers might become continually aware of how algorithms assess their training, which could shift their behaviour and decision-making (SHARE 2.0 Community of Practice on Innovation, 2025). Predictive modelling is one of the most common applications of AI. Such predictive analytics in sports raise critical fairness issues, as players may be evaluated based on projections that do not materialise. The accuracy of these models is uncertain, as they cannot account for unmeasurable factors like emotions, relationships, or performance context.

It is essential to acknowledge not only the violation of individual rights but also that sport is fundamentally a human activity grounded in the assessment of physical skills. Formula 1 illustrates this well. Bell et al. (2016) reveal that a driver's impact on results dropped from about 30% in the early 1980s to around 10% by the mid-2010s. This shift illustrates the increasing dominance of technology over human skill. This trend could lead to a future with driverless cars, eliminating the human element altogether. Other sports follow a similar path, where AI increasingly takes over human decision-making, risking the loss of intuition, creativity, and instinct development.

The integration of AI in sports raises serious ethical concerns. These range from governance problems to the danger of reinforcing nationalist “technological warfare” narratives, along with specific applications that threaten fairness, privacy, and the human aspect of athletic performance. Addressing these challenges requires ethical frameworks that reflect the essential values of sport while building public trust in the use of technology. This paper presents a roadmap for creating ethical guidelines for AI in sports. It draws on philosophical traditions, includes diverse stakeholder perspectives, and applies a risk-based model to assess emerging technologies.

Roadmap for Ethical Guidelines

1. Philosophical Traditions in Sport:

No single philosophical tradition dominates sports, but deontology and virtue ethics have played important roles in sport philosophy (Aggerholm, 2017). Kantian-inspired approaches, seen in formalism and interpretivism, stress athletes' moral and practical duties to uphold rules, regulations, and principles of good conduct. These ideals support codes of ethics developed by organisations like WADA, the IOC, and FIFA, along with systems promoting governance, sportsmanship, and fair play.

AI ethics often uses a similar deontological framework, relying on general principles to guide the design and use of technologies (Mittelstadt, 2019). For AI in sports, ethical guidelines should unite shared principles from both areas, such as fairness, accountability, and transparency (Floridi et al., 2018; Geeraert & Groll, 2014). These common values create a foundation for context-sensitive ethical guidance. However, abstract principles alone are insufficient. They need to be translated into specific, practical norms to tackle the unique challenges of AI in sports.

Deontological approaches are central in both AI ethics and sports governance, but they receive criticism for their shortcomings. In sports, Fraleigh (1984) exemplifies this stance by highlighting the benefits of universal moral principles. Critics argue these approaches can be overly rationalistic, overlooking athlete individuality, cultural context, and institutional influence (McNamee, 2015). Nevertheless, deontology provides a structured method for evaluating conduct while maintaining context sensitivity.

Similar concerns arise in AI ethics. Hagendorff (2020) argues that rule-based methods alone are inadequate, calling for the integration of virtue ethics, which centres on moral character and ethical capacities. Vallor (2016) extends this concept to “techno-moral virtues” guiding responsible interaction with AI. Scholars emphasise the role of sports in nurturing moral virtues (McNamee and Parry, 2002; Reid, 2007). However, organisational governance has largely focused on general deontological principles instead of applying virtues situationally. This reveals a shared neglect of personal ethical development in both AI and sport governance.

The lack of emphasis on personal virtues in both AI and sport governance

indicates that ethical frameworks would be improved by incorporating real-world, context-specific scenarios. While principles like accountability, privacy, and fairness are vital, their practical application must be viewed through specific decision-making examples. In sports, relevant scenarios include contract decisions based on algorithmic performance predictions, accountability for anti-doping sanctions informed by AI analyses, and privacy issues related to collecting and storing sensitive performance data. Supporting educational programmes can encourage ethical decision-making and moral growth, balancing the limitations of mainly deontological systems.

Ethical guidelines for AI in sports should align with general AI governance principles while reflecting sport-specific values. Just as healthcare applies principles like beneficence, non-maleficence, autonomy, and justice to AI, sport values can guide the ethical framework for AI use in this field. Additionally, the extensive discourse on virtue ethics in sports allows for consideration of moral character in decision-making and practical scenarios where AI could harm different stakeholders.

2. Stakeholder Engagement:

Current approaches to ethical AI have proven largely ineffective. This highlights the need for a stronger model grounded in human rights, subjected to independent oversight, and allowing genuine stakeholder engagement (Yeung et al., 2020). In the context of sport governance, it is crucial to emphasise the human rights foundation and participatory mechanisms, as these closely connect with stakeholder theory and the safeguarding of individual rights within sports (Bietti, 2021).

Voluntary commitments and self-regulation in AI are often unreliable, yet establishing ethical principles is crucial. Even though human rights face enforcement challenges, they provide a normative foundation. Human rights focus on protecting vulnerable individuals and preventing harm to essential values (Yeung et al., 2020; Munro, 2019; Smuha, 2020; Latonero, 2018). Evidence shows that harm to athletes – psychological, physical, or sexual – is well-documented, prompting calls for stronger human rights protections and ethical oversight (Grell, 2018; Horne, 2018; Ross & McDougall, 2022; Rook & Heerdt, 2023). While international organisations like the IOC and FIFA have implemented human rights policies, enforcement is often inconsistent. These

challenges have increased stakeholder visibility through mechanisms such as athlete commissions. A stakeholder approach acknowledges that organisations impact and are influenced by many constituents, whose interests must be represented for effective governance (Blount, 2015; Morales & Schubert, 2022). Including stakeholder participation and diversity policies reinforces ethical and human-rights-aligned practices in both AI governance and sports.

Given the potential risks of AI in sports, including breaches of privacy, biased decision-making, and unequal access, it is vital to involve stakeholders in crafting ethical guidelines. In particular, athletes should play a central role in designing data collection protocols, especially regarding biological information. At the same time, other groups such as coaches, spectators, sponsors, media, and local communities must be considered to ensure inclusivity and responsiveness to various interests (Stark et al., 2019). Viewing governance through a human rights lens emphasises preventing harm and strengthens accountability (Stark et al., 2021). Though practical implementation challenges exist, human rights principles provide a strong basis for balancing technological progress with fairness and stakeholder protection (Henderson, 2016; Spalding, 2022). However, even after identifying common ethical principles and clarifying stakeholder roles, the wide variety of AI technologies used in sports complicates the creation of clear, context-sensitive guidelines applicable across different use cases and risk levels.

3. Risk-Based Classification:

The use of AI in sports covers a broad range, from performance enhancement and coaching decisions to injury prevention and athlete safety, each bringing unique ethical issues. Ethical considerations vary depending on the technology's purpose. Performance-enhancing AI raises concerns about fairness and access, while injury-prevention technologies relate to safety, medical responsibility, and privacy, often borrowing from healthcare ethics. Addressing these issues requires identifying AI applications and classifying them by risk, principles, and affected stakeholders. Carrio (2022) highlights the need to distinguish between AI uses that may or may not infringe on human rights, suggesting a risk-based approach aligned with the European Union's AI Act. Applications involving children or athletes with disabilities, especially those that aim to change behaviour or take advantage of vulnerabilities, should be categorised as unacceptable due to

potential physical and mental harm. Ethical guidelines must balance technological advantages with the protection of individual rights and well-being.

High-risk AI applications in sports, particularly those affecting athletes' health or fundamental rights, demand specific ethical attention, especially concerning privacy and the handling of sensitive biological and performance data (Karkazis & Fishman, 2017; Osborne, 2017). Anti-doping is a key area for such technologies. Current laboratory-based testing methods are expensive and require specialised skills. This has led to the creation of AI-driven algorithms that analyse blood parameters for detecting substances like recombinant human erythropoietin (rhEPO) more efficiently (Rahman et al., 2022). While these tools offer operational advantages, they create ethical issues, including the expansion of personal data collection and the need to protect athletes' privacy and procedural fairness, even under strict liability rules. Ethical governance must take into account general AI principles, sport-specific values, vulnerable groups, algorithmic bias, data management, and clear communication of results. Lower-risk AI tools, while less likely to breach human rights, still require careful attention to fairness, equal access, and maintaining the integrity of sports (Carrio, 2022).

Conclusions

This paper emphasises the urgent need for ethical guidelines governing AI in sports. It is motivated by shared governance challenges in technology and sports, the risk of nationalistic or competitive “technological warfare” narratives, and potential harms to athletes and other stakeholders. The variety and rapid development of AI technologies complicate this task and demand flexible strategies.

The roadmap for ethical AI in sports, founded on philosophical principles, stakeholder engagement, and risk assessment, can lead to tangible results such as clear moral principles, sport-specific ethical standards, participatory governance structures, and classification of AI applications based on risk to inform oversight and mitigation strategies. Philosophical foundations provide practical guidelines for balancing performance enhancement with privacy concerns. Meanwhile, stakeholder input ensures inclusive decision-making that respects athletes' rights and interests regarding fair AI technology use. Risk assessment enables organisations to recognise high-risk AI applications, implement safeguards,

and monitor unintended outcomes. Collectively, these steps can strengthen governance, safeguard fundamental rights, and build trust in AI systems. However, putting this roadmap into practice will require further research to assess its effectiveness across various sports, technologies, and cultural settings while refining guidelines for evolving AI applications.

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OLYMPIC NATIONALISM BY THE REFUGEE OLYMPIC TEAM. REPRESENTATION IN JAPANESE NEWSPAPERS

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Abstract

The research theme of this article is "Olympic nationalism by the Refugee Olympic Team" using the concepts of internationalism and cosmopolitanism. The Refugee Olympic Team (ROT) has been in existence since the Rio 2016 Games. This is a different way to participate in the Olympics from the National Olympic Committees (NOCs) formed by countries or regions. Olympic nationalism refers to the totality of ideas, movements, and institutions toward nations in the Olympics. The research question is how Japanese newspapers represent the ROT in the Olympic system and its promotion and publicity process. The reason why this article focuses on Japanese newspapers is that they are an important outlet for discussing the Olympic impact in recently held games. Using critical discourse analysis of three newspapers in Japan, *Asahi*, *Yomiuri*, and *Mainichi*, as sources, this article focuses on the impact of the ROT on internationalism, which is one of the basic ideas in the Olympics.

Three categories and their meanings are analysed: (1) Regarding the keyword "country", the athletes spoke of three different belongings depending on their circumstances: 1.1) home or country of origin; 1.2) ROT is a team like those formed by countries or regions; and 1.3) country of settlement through citizenship acquisition. (2) The keyword "sport" refers to the power of change, and as identity. (3) The keyword "refugee" indicates two things: 3.1) being a role model of refugee hope; 3.2) announcement of refugee situation to the refugee-accepted

societies. Although NOCs based on countries and regions are assumed in the system, it became clear that athletes not only change their attribution regarding "country" but also that "sport" and "refugee" can be one of their identities. This is why internationalism in the Olympics is emphasised based on institutions, but athletes make representations that can be seen as cosmopolitanism.

1. Introduction

The Refugee Olympic Team (ROT) represents a new Olympic initiative that began in 2016 and was continued for the Tokyo 2020 and Paris 2024 Olympic Games. The formation of this team is situated against a backdrop of rising global concern for refugees amid the refugee crisis and reflects the Olympic Games' valuation of concrete actions to embody its philosophy as a festival of peace. Within the Olympic structure, where participation is exclusively enabled through National Olympic Committees (NOCs) organised by country or region, refugees were previously excluded. The Olympic Charter had already anticipated scenarios where a National Federation (NF) might not exist, allowing athletes to participate with the approval of the IOC Executive Board and the relevant International Federation (IF). This provision also applies when an NF is not functioning correctly (*The Yomiuri Shimbun*, June 18, 2016). However, the charter had not accounted for the absence of an NOC itself. The exclusion of athletes on this basis was considered contrary to Olympism, which advocates for providing equal participation opportunities to all, leading to the establishment of the ROT.

Members of the ROT receive the same treatment as other athletes and are considered Olympians. Nevertheless, the selection criteria that enable their participation differ from those for other athletes. According to the IOC (2021), the selection criteria for the ROT are twofold. First, an athlete must have official refugee status confirmed by the United Nations. Second, the athlete must demonstrate athletic potential at a national or international level, be recommended by a host NOC, and pass a review conducted by Olympic Solidarity in conjunction with the relevant IF. The existence of special selection criteria suggests these measures are deemed necessary.

The research question of this article is: how have Japanese newspapers represented the ROT within the institutional framework of the Olympics and its promotional and publicity processes? The analysis will cover Japan's three

major newspapers: the *Asahi Shimbun*, the *Yomiuri Shimbun*, and the *Mainichi Shimbun*. The rationale for focusing on Japanese newspapers is the significance of analysing media in a recent host country in discussing the influence of the Olympic Games. The research methodology employed is Critical Discourse Analysis. By examining the ROT, this article aims to clarify the transforming state of Olympic nationalism and discuss its influence on the internationalism that underpins the institution and ideals of the Olympic Games.

2. Literature Review

A review of existing literature concerning the ROT reveals that research on this topic is not yet extensive in Japan. Ishii (2020) suggested that the existence of the ROT has, through media coverage and related programmes, contributed to the elimination of intolerance. Similarly, Onuma (2018), who historically analysed the relationship between regions in conflict and the Olympics through events like boycotts, concluded that the ROT has had a positive impact. This is attributed to its role as a new system connecting the Games with conflict zones and the implementation of sports programmes within these areas. While these two studies approach the ROT from different perspectives, they are limited to a one-dimensional view of the team as a "positive entity". Furthermore, they do not sufficiently analyse the specific ways in which this positive perception is constructed, nor how the ROT is perceived by audiences through media and related programmes. As the host nation of the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games, which saw the ROT delegation's participation, it is imperative to analyse the full significance of the ROT, including its portrayal in the media where information was widely disseminated. Such analysis is also crucial for legacy studies.

Internationally, a greater number of studies exist. These include a descriptive study by Elizabeth Cheung-Gaffney (2018) that followed a soccer project in a refugee camp, and research by Baidruel Hairiel Abd Rahim (2018) that analysed the sports personalities of the 11 refugee athletes who participated in the Rio 2016 Olympic Games using secondary data. These studies provide concrete descriptions of the changes accompanying the implementation of the ROT. The literature review also identified several studies on the ROT that employ discourse analysis and present theoretical frameworks.

Annabel Burdsey et al. (2022) conducted a discourse analysis of IOC press

releases concerning the ROT. Their analysis identified four prominent themes: 1) the transformative power of Western sport; 2) the ROT as a symbol of the Global North's inclusivity and benevolence; 3) the refugee as a figure of hope; and 4) the neoliberal ideal that hard work pays off. The authors argue that by disseminating these "official" discourses, the IOC ignores the challenging structural realities that refugees face upon arrival. Ariyo (2022) analysed the representation of the ROT in international news media from 2015 to 2021 and identified three frames: 1) a "flat frame" that does not mention the refugee crisis; 2) an "Olympic celebrity humanitarian frame" that focuses on the IOC's humanitarian activities; and 3) a "crisis-breaking frame" for their stories. Although not focused exclusively on the ROT, Enrico Michellini (2021) analysed German newspaper coverage of sports and the refugee crisis. Interpreting the data based on Foucault's theory of discourse, Michellini identified six themes: 1) the construction of the refugee athlete; 2) the refugee as a threat or victim; 3) the involvement of the sports system; 4) the sports system as a sanctuary; 5) refugee integration through sport; and 6) charity. The three above studies present analytical frameworks which demonstrate the importance of discourse and representation analysis in ROT research. They reveal that while different frameworks emerge depending on the subject of analysis, commonalities can also be found, such as the portrayal of the initiative as an act of charity or humanitarian aid.

This review indicates that the body of literature focusing specifically on the ROT remains limited. The primary methodology employed in existing research is critical discourse analysis, with the IOC often being the main subject of this analysis.

3. Research Question and Method

The research question of this article is: how is the ROT represented in the public relations and promotional processes of the Olympic Games in Japan?

The Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) is adopted as the research methodology. In CDA, it is crucial to define what aspect of a discourse is being critiqued. Previous studies (Burdsey et al., 2022; Ariyo, 2022; Michellini, 2021) commonly targeted the IOC for criticism, specifically targeting its arrogant and Olympic-utopian discourse that conceals the hardships faced by refugees. This article, however, analyses Japanese newspapers with the aim of examining theories of nationalism within the Olympics. Therefore, CDA will be conducted by critiquing

"discourses in which Olympic internationalism fails to address or respond to changing and diversifying national identities, or discourses that maintain inherent contradictions".

The primary materials for analysis are the Japanese newspapers: the *Yomiuri Shimbun* (172 articles), the *Asahi Shimbun* (101 articles), and the *Mainichi Shimbun* (110 articles). These three major newspapers were selected based on accessibility and the heightened importance of Japanese-language media due to Japan's role as the host of the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games.

However, the validity of using Japanese newspapers as a data source presents a potential issue. As Moritsu (2022) points out, this issue stems from their status as official sponsors of the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games. For the Tokyo event, six companies from the newspaper sector – the *Asahi Shimbun*, *Mainichi Shimbun*, *Yomiuri Shimbun*, *Nihon Keizai Shimbun*, *Sankei Shimbun*, and *Hokkaido Shimbun* – were sponsors.

All articles and press releases were collected using an online search engine with the keyword "ROT". The material collection was conducted in December 2024. As the newspapers are domestic Japanese media, the original language of the articles is Japanese; these were translated into English by the author. Furthermore, to maintain a clear focus on the Olympics, articles and information concerning the refugee team in the Paralympics were excluded.

4. Analysis

From the analysis of three Japanese newspaper companies, three keywords became clear: "nation", "sport", and "refugee". The meaning of each of these keywords was examined.

4.1 Refugee Athletes Who Cannot Be Separated from Their Country of Origin/Host "NOC"

What does "nation" mean for the ROT? When the ROT was discussed in relation to a country, it mainly pointed to three types of "nations".

4.1.1 A Sense of Belonging to Their Homeland or Mother Country

The first is a sense of belonging to their homeland or mother country. Rami Anis stated, "Someday I want to return to my country and compete in the Olympics

as a representative of my country" (*Asahi Shimbun*, August 22, 2016). Rose Nathike Lokonyen also remarked, "At the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Game, we might be able to compete as representatives of our homeland. Refugees don't live as refugees forever" (*Asahi Shimbun*, May 6, 2020). This shows that athletes who hold aspirations of becoming representatives for their country of origin are competing as part of the ROT.

4.1.2 *The ROT as a "Nation"*

The second is the case where the ROT is compared to and positioned as a nation. Masomah Ali Zada stated, "The ROT does not represent a specific country, but over 100 million people who share the same experience" (*Mainichi Shimbun*, May 26, 2024). Yusra Mardini also said, "It doesn't matter if it's the Syrian flag or the Olympic flag. As a representative of refugees, I want to show that we can move forward" (*Asahi Shimbun*, July 25, 2016). Additionally, an article was published in a newspaper where Jamal Barizadehe was quoted as saying, "For me, to be able to compete in the Olympics in my second homeland is a special feeling" and "I want to fight representing refugees in the next Olympics. They are my family" (*Asahi Shimbun*, August 7, 2024). From this, it can be understood that although the ROT is not a nation, it is perceived as a community that shares common experiences and as an organisation with a nation-like sense of solidarity.

4.1.3 *The Country of Settlement Through Citizenship Acquisition*

The third is about the country of settlement through the acquisition of citizenship. ROT athlete Yonas Kinde said, "Being a refugee is not something you choose... For now, I'm focused on aiming for the Olympics. If I could one day run as a representative of Luxembourg..." (*Asahi Shimbun*, May 6, 2020), speaking of becoming a representative for the country he currently resides in.

From the above, it is understood that athletes who participated in the ROT experience a shift in their sense of belonging to three different groups – ① a sense of belonging to their homeland or mother country, ② representing the ROT, and ③ the country of settlement through citizenship acquisition – in accordance with their changing circumstances, at times making their own choices and emphasising them.

4.2 "Sport" as a Guiding Principle That Helps All

For those experiencing the harsh circumstances of being a refugee, sport taught them everything, saved them, and gave them a path to live as an athlete. Popole Misenga stated, "Thanks to judo, I was able to walk the right path" (*Asahi Shimbun*, July 25, 2016). Cindy Ngamba said, "Through boxing, I became able to accomplish things and to believe in myself" and "Winning or losing doesn't matter. What's important is to believe in yourself and to push yourself" (*Mainichi Shimbun*, August 6, 2024). Aker Al-Obaidi remarked, "Wrestling is a pure sport. Who is stronger. That's all there is... I am strong. I am okay... Every day, my goal is in my sight. Every time I see it, it reminds me of what I have to do... On the mat, nationality and the gap between rich and poor doesn't matter. If you wish for it from the bottom of your heart, your dream will come true. Whether in Iraq, in Austria, or anywhere else in the world" (*Mainichi Shimbun*, June 21, 2021, Tokyo Morning Edition). ROT athletes are conscious of what they have learned from sport, and being an athlete is one of their core identities.

4.3 "The Hope of Refugees" as Shown by the ROT

Being a refugee is the most important keyword for the ROT. The athletes on the team inspire dreams in fellow refugees and communicate the situation of refugees to those who are not.

4.3.1 *Becoming the Hope of Refugees*

Yusra Mardini has repeatedly spoken of her motivation to be a source of hope for refugees. "The Olympics are the biggest dream. I will fight as a representative of refugees and hope for the entire world." "I am proud to be here. I have received support from so many people. I hope our challenge will make everyone more positive and give them the strength to continue chasing their own dreams" (*Mainichi Shimbun*, August 1, 2016, Tokyo Morning Edition). "When I couldn't swim because of the civil war, I realised how much I truly loved swimming." "If refugees receive an education, they can become doctors, lawyers, or engineers. We want to earn our own money, pay taxes, and study the language to fit into the local community. I want people to first understand this side of refugees" (*Asahi Shimbun*, November 22, 2019). Furthermore, Tegla Loroupe stated, "We want to prove that we are not inferior to national representatives and give

hope to refugees all over the world" (*Mainichi Shimbun*, August 28, 2019, Tokyo Morning Edition). Yiech Pur Biel said, "Refugees are not just beings to be pitied as 'poor things.' If we just have a chance, we can do it too." They aim for medals to become "role models" for other refugees. "I was moved. My life up to that point had been nothing but giving up. I couldn't even stand at the starting line" (*Mainichi Shimbun*, October 8, 2019, Tokyo Morning Edition). Yonas Kinde also shared these words: "I want to be a beacon of hope for the 66 million refugees in the world" and "By running today, I was able to convey the existence of refugees" (*Asahi Shimbun*, August 23, 2016).

4.3.2 Sounding a Warning to Society Through the Existence of Refugees

Alongside her athletic competitions, Yusra Mardini has also been engaged in public speaking for the past two years as a Goodwill Ambassador for the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR). Lesbos is not the only island where refugees are placed in tragic situations. At a refugee camp she inspected in Italy, medicine and food were also insufficient. "My goal is to let people know what is happening in the refugee camps and what people need", she said (*Mainichi Shimbun*, September 30, 2019, Tokyo Morning Edition). This ambassador position is also a role anticipated by the IOC. President Bach stated, "This is a historic event, forming a refugee team for the first time. Through the refugee athletes, we can communicate the difficult problem of refugees to the world" (*Asahi Shimbun*, June 4, 2016).

5. Discussion and Conclusion

Based on the analysis, the influence on nationalism within the Olympics is considered from the perspective of the ROT. First, the definitions are confirmed. For the definition of nationalism, this paper relies on Gellner, who takes a constructivist stance of modernism and focuses on industrial structure. Nationalism is "the ideology, movement, or system which holds that we are a unique community with our own historical and cultural characteristics that are different from others", and is a form of patriotism that becomes prevalent and dominant only under the specific social conditions that are effectively unique to the modern world. Then, in discussing theories of nationalism in the Olympics, internationalism and cosmopolitanism are used as the main analytical concepts. Internationalism

is "the consideration of an international society based on cooperation and mutual understanding between different nations". Cosmopolitanism, relying on Harvey who emphasised Kant, is defined as "a political and methodological framework based on active dialogue with individuals rooted in a place".

The analysis revealed three keywords. The first keyword is "nation." As the athletes' own situations change – becoming refugees, migrating, and becoming athletes for the ROT – their feelings toward the concept of a nation also change. It was found that there is a shift in identity that encompasses three different ways of perceiving a "nation": 1.1) the country of origin or homeland; 1.2) the community of athletes or refugees; and 1.3) the country where citizenship was acquired. The second keyword is "sport." The IOC emphasised that sport teaches everything and has the power to bring about transformation. The third keyword is "refugee". The ROT sent a message of: 3.1) being a source of hope for refugees, and 3.2) communicating their situation to non-refugees.

The modern Olympics, through the initiative of the ROT, carries on the Olympic tradition of aiming to build peace through internationalism. However, the statements from ROT athletes reveal that, through the experience of becoming refugees and participating in the ROT, their own identities fluctuate, centred around the keywords of nation, sport, and refugee. Furthermore, "nation" comes to signify not only a country within the nation-state system but also regions and places of migration, while "refugee" and "sport" create solidarity and become identities. In this way, by demonstrating identities that can substitute for the "nation" – such as sport and refugee – and transcend the framework of internationalism, the ROT has suggested the potential for cosmopolitanism within the Olympic Games.

This article has several limitations that should be acknowledged. First, the scope of this research was confined to an analysis of Japanese newspapers. A more significant constraint is that the three major newspapers examined in this paper were all official sponsors of the Tokyo Olympic Games. Furthermore, due to limitations in the analytical methods employed, this article was unable to conduct a detailed comparative analysis to clarify the distinct characteristics of each newspaper. To build upon the findings of this paper, further comparative studies in the future are essential.

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ETHICAL DILEMMAS ARISING FROM THE COMMERCIALISATION OF THE OLYMPIC GAMES IN THE CONTEXT OF THE AI ERA

Zhang SHI-CHAO (CHN)

1. Background

Before addressing the core issue, it is necessary to first delineate the three major systems that shape the Olympic Games (see Figure 1). The first is the International Olympic Committee (IOC). According to the Olympic Charter—the foundational document of the Olympic Movement—the IOC’s fundamental mission is:

to contribute to building a peaceful and better world by educating youth through sport practiced without discrimination of any kind and in the Olympic spirit, which requires mutual understanding with a spirit of friendship, solidarity, and fair play.

The IOC is primarily oriented toward public interest and non-profit goals. The Charter further emphasises the need to guard against the excessive commercialisation of the Olympic Games.

The second system is the host city. Host cities aim to leverage the Olympic Games as a catalyst for urban governance and regeneration. However, such efforts are often heavily reliant on commercial sponsorship and financial support from the private sector.

The third system consists of corporate sponsors and enterprises, whose primary objective is profit-seeking. Within this tripartite structure, a fundamental tension arises: while the IOC is guided by public-interest principles, sponsors are driven by commercial imperatives. This divergence in core objectives inevitably gives rise to conflict between the two actors.

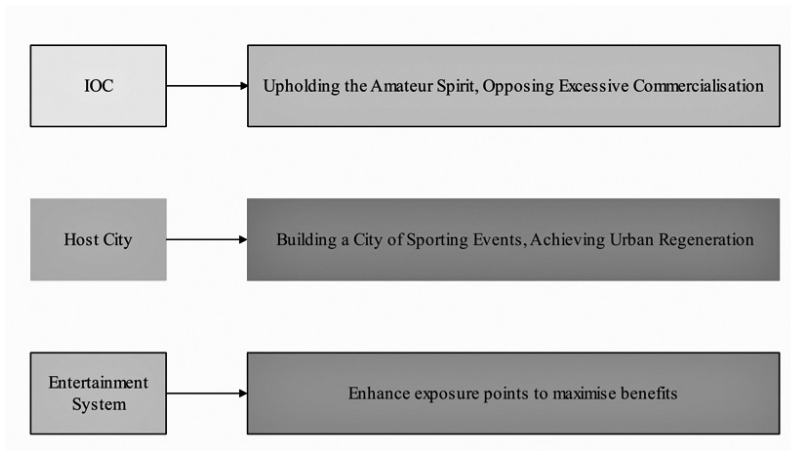


Figure 1. Three Principal Systems of the Olympic Games

2. Research Methods

This study employs theoretical analysis as its primary method, aiming to examine the ethical dilemmas arising from the commercialisation of the Olympics. Two specific methods are utilised: first, historical research, which involves organising historical records of both ancient and modern Olympics (Siljak 2007). The other is semi-structured interviews to supplement the textual content, further understanding different perspectives on ethical and moral issues in the context of commercialisation, as well as views on Olympic athletic performance under the influence of commercialisation. The primary interview subjects were athletes, coaches, and sponsors. A total of five individuals were interviewed, including two athletes, one coach, one event organiser, and one corporate sponsor, with interview durations ranging from 5 to 20 minutes.

3. Historical Reasons for the Commercialisation of the Olympic Games

Ancient Olympic Games Period

During the Roman Empire, Philostratus criticised the Olympic Games in his work *On Sports* for encouraging athletes to buy and sell victories for money.

He mentioned:

A boy won the Isthmian wrestling competition after agreeing with one of his opponents on a victory price of three thousand drachmas. The next day, when they arrived at the stadium, the defeated athlete demanded his money, but the other athlete claimed he owed nothing, as he had won by defeating an opponent who refused to lose. Since their dispute remained unresolved, they turned to an oath for resolution, going to the temple of the Isthmian god. The athlete who had sold the victory publicly swore that he had indeed sold the divine contest, and someone had promised him three thousand drachmas. He admitted these things with a clear and unreserved voice. (Philostratus 1871, 45).

Not only athletes but also coaches can be influenced by financial interests. Some coaches began lending money to athletes and no longer focused on teaching them technical skills, but instead sought to profit from them (Philostratus 1871), a behaviour that contradicted the sacred qualities of Olympia. It is evident that when competitions become overly commercialised, athletes, coaches, referees, and even merchants seeking to sponsor athletes are all tempted by money, leading them to engage in various acts of selling out the competition for personal gain.

Before the 1984 Los Angeles Olympics

The modern Olympic Games have been susceptible to commercialisation since their inception. Coubertin sought to establish the Olympic Movement as an amateur, apolitical, and non-commercial event. In his 1928 speech at the University of Lausanne, he firmly opposed all tendencies toward professionalisation, commercialisation, and politicisation (Coubertin 2000, 184). He predicted that commercialisation would erode the amateur spirit and lead to corruption within the Olympic Movement (Coubertin 2000, 184). However, he also recognised that the Olympics needed to attract sponsors and must accept commercial forms he was reluctant to embrace (Tomlinson 2005). At this time, the Olympic Movement was caught in a debate between professional and amateur sports,

as well as between commercialised and non-commercialised events. In the era of strict amateurism, the rewards athletes received for their achievements were incomparable to the compensation future athletes would receive through commercial sponsorship. The four records set by the outstanding African American athlete Jesse Owens in 1936 remained unbroken until after the 1952 Helsinki Olympics. When he returned home, he was hailed as a hero in ticker tape parades on Broadway in New York and in Cleveland, becoming a celebrity known throughout the nation and even the world. However, this fame brought him little economic benefit, and he had to take a low-paying job (earning \$130 a month) as a playground coach, even competing in races against horses, dogs, and motorcycles. He once endorsed a failed cleaning products company, but later transitioned into public relations work, delivering speeches on topics such as religion, patriotism, and marketing for corporate sponsors, which finally provided him with financial security (Tomlinson 2005).

Following that, at the first Olympics held after World War II, Avery Brundage, the American right-wing businessman who served as President of the International Olympic Committee, adopted a fiercely messianic stance, opposing any initiatives aimed at commercialising the Olympics (Tomlinson 2005). Even at the time of his retirement during the 1972 Munich Olympics, Brundage declared that the IOC “should have no connection with money”. At the 1976 Montreal Olympics, the city of Montreal pledged to “self-fund the Olympics”, but the official financial loss was reported to be 1 billion dollars. While this Olympics did invite advertising sponsors, the event ultimately became an “economic trap” nearly bankrupting the city due to an unaffordable extravaganza.

After the 1984 Los Angeles Olympics

Following the Montreal Olympics, the bidding process for the 1984 Olympic Games faced an awkward situation, with only Los Angeles willing to host the 23rd Olympic Games. North American capital began to dominate the economic aspects of the Olympics, altering the fundamental economic model of media-driven sports. Adhering to the principle that “everything is for sale”, they began to transfer Olympic broadcast rights, sell torch relay qualifications and equipment, package

and sell tickets and souvenirs for various events, and widely introduce sponsors to help them expand their brand recognition. According to the audit results in March 1985, the broadcasting rights revenue for the Los Angeles Olympics reached USD 28.679 million, ticket sales amounted to USD 13.992 million, sponsorship and licensing revenue reached USD 12.673 million, the commemorative coin programme generated 3.598 million USD, interest income totalled USD 7.631 million, and other sources, such as non-monetary donations, ticket handling fees, and accommodation revenue, amounted to USD 10.288 million. Operating expenses amounted to USD 39.839 million, venue and facility usage fees totalled USD 9.738 million, and payments to the International Olympic Committee (IOC) amounted to USD 5.014 million. By the 2020 Tokyo Olympics, broadcasting rights revenue accounted for 73% of total Olympic revenue (US Code). It was precisely the commercialisation of the Los Angeles Olympics that turned the event profitable, reigniting interest in bidding for the Olympics.

Although the Olympics became profitable, more cities are now willing to bid for the Olympics, build new sports venues, and create city IP. However, the commercialisation has also brought about issues such as match-fixing, doping, refereeing errors, which have become increasingly common. For example, the Salt Lake City bid committee bribed International Olympic Committee members to secure votes, the Rio Olympics in Brazil involved large-scale corruption in venue construction, athletes and coaches took performance-enhancing drugs on a large scale to win competitions, and so on. The enormous profits generated by the commercialisation of the Olympics have caused various parties to overlook the ethical standards set by the Olympics, posing a significant challenge to the “fairness” of Olympic competitions.

4. Issues Arising from Commercialisation

In fact, I contend that any largescale sports event, in the contemporary contexts of globalisation and media saturation, is almost inevitably forced toward commercialisation. To clarify this tendency, I have sketched a schematic in Figure 2 (left branch). The idea is that if the Olympics – or any major event – develops successfully, corporate actors and sponsors will almost certainly invest. The larger the event, the greater its influence and media exposure; this draws in increasing amounts of capital.

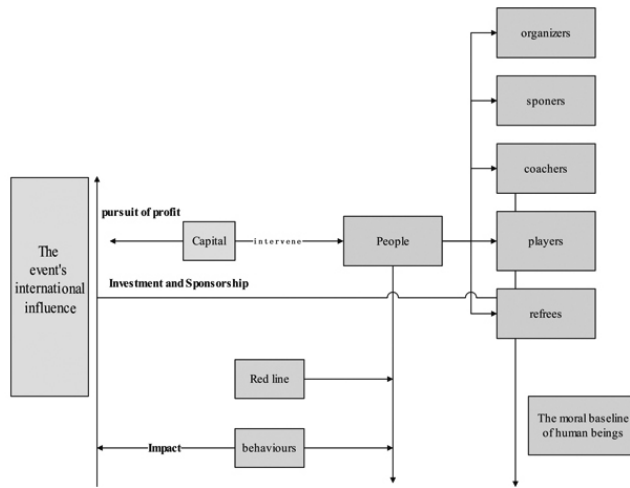


Figure 2. Conflicts between the IOC and its sponsors

In particular, against the backdrop of the AI era, one can imagine that future Olympic competitions may leverage AI technologies to allow spectators, even from a distance of thousands of kilometres, to feel the atmosphere on site and to observe athlete performances as though they were present. This technological revolution will surely magnify the event's influence. As you all know, once an event becomes sufficiently attractive, capital will naturally attempt to infiltrate every link of it. We can explain this phenomenon through the lens of Herbert A. Simon's "attention economy" theory.

Additionally, organisers of Olympic events require financial backing. On the one hand, a host city hopes to use the Olympics as a branding tool, to upgrade infrastructure and enhance its external prestige; on the other hand, the city also seeks to attract more sponsors and investors to its urban development. Inevitably, a variety of vested interests and quid pro quos emerge behind the scenes, making the commercialisation process extremely difficult to restrain. Otherwise, the Olympic family would risk repeating the embarrassment of 1978, when only Los Angeles was willing to bid to host, jeopardising the sustainability of the Games.

When capital is too dominant and the temptations too great, can we always resist? Consequently, today we confront an ethical dilemma in commercialisation: one side (the institutions, host cities, organisers) must depend on capital for operational survival, but the other side (capital) is driven by the profit motive and may be willing to sacrifice anything to maximise returns.

Karl Marx once observed in *Capital* that:

If there is 10 % profit, capital is guaranteed to be employed everywhere; 20 % profit activates capital; 50 % profit pushes capital to take risks; for 100 % profit, capital dares to trample upon all human laws; at 300 % profit, capital dares to commit any crime, even risking execution.

Thus, as the influence of the Olympics continues to rise, capital will penetrate all domains—from a referee accepting bribes in a single match to manipulation of qualification criteria for certain events, even extending to decision making within the IOC itself.

I argue that to explain this phenomenon, our attention must ultimately turn to human actors. No matter how AI develops or technology transforms, it is people who employ the technology and make decisions in sport. When individuals engage in norm-violating behaviour in the context of the Olympics or other major events, they typically undergo a psychological gametheoretic internal struggle.

I believe that every decision—whether it is matchfixing, biased officiating (“black whistles”), doping, or manipulation of official selections—involves such an internal psychological game. Initially, most individuals (athletes, judges, administrators) start from a standpoint of fairness and integrity, but as capital continues to raise the stakes, inner doubts inevitably arise. When the financial incentives cross a certain line, people begin to contemplate violations of rules. Therefore, once AI magnifies the spectacle of sports, Olympic stakeholders will face increasingly intense psychological struggles between honour (prestige, ideal) and money (profit, private gain).

5. Proposed Framework: Guiding Ethical Governance in the Era of AI and Commercialisation

Given the increasing recognition of the ethical risks posed by unchecked commercialisation and capital intrusion into the Olympic Games, a fundamental question arises: How can these risks be mitigated? While the International Olympic Committee may have limited direct regulatory power, it nonetheless plays a critical role in guiding, facilitating, and coordinating a multi-level response. In particular, the IOC can leverage artificial intelligence (AI) technologies to mediate the relationship between public interest and commercial interest, ensuring that

the humanitarian spirit of the Games remains at the core of Olympic governance.

To this end, I propose a three-tiered feedback-loop framework (see Figure 3), through which the IOC can institutionalise ethical oversight and reinforce Olympic values at multiple levels of the system.

The First Feedback Loop: Sport Federations and Corporate Actors

The first loop focuses on International Federations (IFs), National Governing Bodies (NGBs), and corporate sponsors as the key operational stakeholders. This layer is critical for reinvigorating the Olympic humanistic tradition and cultural identity. The IOC should mandate that each federation establish independent ethical oversight mechanisms, including background checks, compliance training, and regular audits – not only for athletes, but also for coaches, referees, corporate sponsors, and affiliated third parties.

This feedback loop emphasises decentralised moral regulation: embedding ethical accountability within everyday organisational routines, rather than relying solely on top-down punitive enforcement. By promoting responsibility and honour as intrinsic values – through education programmes rooted in Olympic philosophy – the IOC can foster a culture where commercial actors internalise ethical behaviour as part of their social legitimacy.

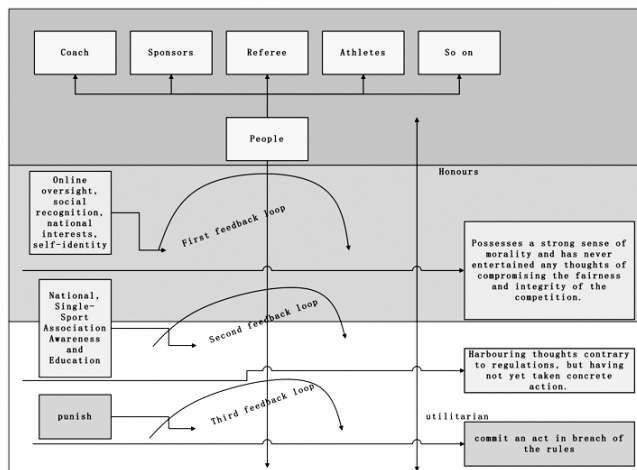


Figure 3. Adaptation Map for the Commercial Development of the Olympic Games in the Context of the AI Era

The Second Feedback Loop: Host Cities and Collaborative Governance

The second loop involves host cities and national governments, with a focus on deliberative governance and value-based selection criteria. At present, much of the host city selection process centres on logistical, financial, and infrastructural capabilities. However, an additional layer should be introduced: evaluating the city's and its stakeholders' understanding of Olympic values, including Olympic history, Olympism, and public service ethics.

To operationalise this, the IOC could develop an Olympic Values Assessment Scale (OVAS) – a psychometric instrument designed to measure the ethical commitment and honour orientation of bidding cities and their key stakeholders. Such a scale could become part of the city evaluation rubric, helping ensure that future Olympic hosts are not only economically capable but also ethically aligned with the spirit of the Games.

The Third Feedback Loop: Media, Society, and Public Discourse

The third feedback mechanism concerns mass media, social media platforms, and the general public. In the AI era, the boundaries between producers and consumers of media have blurred, making public discourse an important site of ethical accountability. During Olympic events, AI tools can be deployed to monitor and analyse real-time public commentary – including livestream chats, social media reactions, short-form video content, and online journalism.

By using natural language processing (NLP) and sentiment analysis, the IOC can detect recurring ethical concerns, instances of bias, or suspicious behaviour patterns reflected in the public sphere. This “bottom-up” data stream can then be fed back to the relevant governing bodies, enriching oversight and enabling responsive, transparent governance.

As we enter an era defined by algorithmic decision-making and technological spectacle, the Olympic Movement must remain grounded in humanist values. AI is not merely a threat to ethical governance – it is also a tool that, if properly used, can amplify transparency, promote ethical reflection, and engage diverse voices in holding Olympic institutions accountable.

Ultimately, the core of ethical reform lies in the moral agency of individuals. The IOC should prioritise efforts to enhance moral awareness, a sense of honour, and social responsibility among all participants in the Olympic ecosystem – from athletes and officials to sponsors, media practitioners, and fans. Only through

this multi-tiered, human-centred approach can the Olympics continue to uphold their role as a global symbol of peace, integrity, and excellence.

6. Conclusion

Our research indicates that, ever since the ancient Olympics, if the commercialisation of the Olympics is not regulated, match-fixing, corrupt refereeing, and corrupt gambling on matches will occur frequently. These incidents are fundamentally linked to the commercialisation process, which reinforces individual tendencies toward utilitarianism. On one hand, advancing commercialisation is an inevitable choice for the sustainable development of the Olympics; on the other hand, the high bonuses, high returns, media exposure, and endorsement fees introduced by commercialisation will become a chain that binds athletes, coaches, referees, and related organisers. Especially under the influence of artificial intelligence, will there be more hackers, drug technologies, high-tech sports products, and powerful companies influencing the fairness of the Olympics in the future. Therefore, Olympic organisers must currently seek a balance between “economic challenges” and “moral dilemmas”, and, through proactive measures such as regulation, education, and punishment, reduce future ethical and moral lapses resulting from the pursuit of economic interests.

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THE OLYMPIC MOVEMENT, POLICY EVOLUTION, AND POLITICAL EMPOWERMENT: THE TRAJECTORY OF DISABILITY SPORTS IN CHINA

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Abstract

The Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities establishes the equal right of persons with disabilities to participate in sport. This study examines the unique trajectory of elite sports for athletes with disabilities in China, analysing its three-phase policy evolution and profound impact on rights. Findings reveal that since the 1970s, policy has progressed from initial recovery (1970s–early 2000s), to rapid ascendance driven by the Beijing Olympics window (2001–2008), and finally to integrated, standardised development within national strategies (2008–present). China’s “sports-politics” model successfully harnessed a “medal-driven” impetus, building a systematic policy framework by integrating with national strategies like “Building a Leading Sporting Nation” and “Healthy China”. A key innovation is the creative channelling of elite athletic success into political empowerment (e.g., athletes entering legislatures, political advisory bodies, and disability federations), and transforming elite influence into a force for grassroots inclusive policies (e.g., facilities, talent development, mass sports). This has mitigated risks of uneven resource distribution and marginalisation, fostering a virtuous cycle of parallel development between elite and mass sports, and mutual reinforcement between athletic achievement and political empowerment. This model offers a distinctive “Chinese path” perspective for developing countries balancing elite success with inclusive rights.

Keywords: Disability, Elite Sports, Policy Change, Political Participation

Introduction

The rise of elite sports for athletes with disabilities in China signifies not only improved rights but also a unique “sports-politics” developmental interplay. As a signatory to the UN Convention, China’s policy has evolved significantly: from stagnation (1970s) to initial recovery (post-reform), then to leapfrog development around the 2008 Beijing Paralympics, and finally integration into the national Building a Leading Sporting Nation strategy. This process reveals Paralympic success as a core driver for policy upgrading, reshaping social perceptions and opening avenues for political empowerment.

However, international scholarship offers a critique, warning that “medal-driven” models may prioritise elite sports over grassroots facilities (Brooke & Khoo, 2021; Nagata et al., 2023), coaching, and participation, potentially creating a “supercrip” narrative that raises unrealistic expectations and further marginalises the broader disability community (Silva & Howe, 2012). China’s practice presents a notable case. The government has historically viewed the Paralympics as a vital platform for showcasing spirit and athleticism (Neža Šubic & Delia Ferri, 2022). Consequently, elite success has granted athletes social prestige, influenced public attitudes, and crucially, provided access to political channels within the administrative system. This political empowerment allows elite athletes to advocate for broader disability rights, influencing policy optimisation. Their achievements also inspire participation and social integration, creating a synergy between top-down elite leadership and bottom-up public engagement, fostering a cycle of integrated development for disability sports in China. This study analyses how China’s “medal-driven” model, within its socio-political structure, has not only built a Paralympic powerhouse but also forged a breakthrough path for elite political empowerment and institutional improvement of inclusive sports rights, offering a valuable “Chinese path” perspective for policy governance in developing nations.

Research Methodology

This study employs a historical policy analysis methodology. It systematically examines government documents, official policy texts, historical records, and

academic publications to trace the evolution of China's policies regarding elite sports for athletes with disabilities from the 1970s to the present. The analysis focuses on identifying key policy phases, core drivers of change (particularly the catalytic role of Paralympic achievement), and the ensuing impact on the rights and interests of persons with disabilities. This documentary approach allows for the reconstruction of the policy trajectory and the elucidation of the underlying "sports-politics" interconnection mechanism characterising the Chinese context.

The Three-Stage Policy Evolution of Elite Disability Sports in China

Phase 1: Preliminary Recovery (1970s–early 2000s): Legislative Exploration and Identity Reshaping

Until the 1980s, elite disability sports were virtually non-conceptualised in China, often subsumed under negligible mass sports activities. The community faced discrimination, neglect, and a lack of structured opportunities. Economic constraints post-reform further limited infrastructure development. A shift began as national rehabilitation policies emerged alongside China's re-engagement with the world (Guan & Hong, 2016).

The restoration of China's IOC membership in 1979 ('Nagoya Resolution') opened new avenues. In 1984, China debuted at the Paralympic Games, marking its first step onto the international stage. The founding of the China Disabled Persons' Federation (CDPF) in 1988 provided an essential organisational foundation. The landmark Law of the People's Republic of China on the Protection of Persons with Disabilities (1990) was revolutionary, legally mandating support for disability sports, hosting games, and international exchanges. (Zhao & Zhang, 2018). Subsequent State Council directives, like the Outline of the National Fitness Program (1995) and the Ninth Five-Year Plan for Disability Work (1996), encouraged sports participation, fitness methods, and organisational building at local levels.

This phase was problem-oriented, focused on filling a policy vacuum and reshaping the marginalised identity of the disability community through basic citizenship recognition and legal guarantees. However, implementation gaps persisted, with tangible benefits for the average person with a disability remaining limited compared to policy ambitions.

Phase 2: Rapid Ascendancy (2001–2008): The Beijing Olympics Catalyst

Beijing's successful 2001 bid for the 2008 Olympics/Paralympics became a paramount national priority, offering a chance to showcase China's progress. This catalysed an unprecedented focus on disability sports. The China Sports Association for the Disabled was renamed the China Paralympic Committee (2004) to align with international standards.

The government's political imperative to host successful Games drove a flurry of policies aimed at medal success. The Second Phase of the National Fitness Program (2001–2010) emphasised community-based sports and facilities. The Tenth Five-Year Plan for Disability Work (2001) called for a multi-tier training system, professional teams, training bases, and international participation. The Opinions on Strengthening Disability Sports (2007) directly leveraged the Beijing Paralympics to promote mass activities, team building, and a supportive social environment. The revised Law on the Protection of Persons with Disabilities (2008) further emphasised equal participation and government responsibility.

The Paralympics challenged pervasive stereotypes, offering a global platform that reshaped public perception from pity or heroism towards recognising capability and diversity. The Games acted as a powerful accelerator, funneling massive resources into elite training, specialised teams, and accessibility modifications. Athletes gained significant social visibility and dignity. However, this development was intensely “event-driven”, raising questions about its sustainability and trickle-down benefits post-2008.

Phase 3: Integrated Development (2008–Present): Standardisation and Political Empowerment

Post-2008, policy successfully transitioned beyond the event-driven model, integrating disability sports into broader national strategies like Building a Leading Sporting Nation, Healthy China, and Equalization of Basic Public Services. The policy system became more standardised, systematic, and long-term.

A primary breakthrough was elevating disability sports to a national strategic level, ensuring sustained policy support and institutionalised resource allocation through plans like the Five-Year Plans for Disability Protection and Development and the National Fitness Plan (2021–2025). Legal guarantees were upgraded further through subsequent revisions of the Law on the Protection of Persons with Disabilities (2008, 2018) and notably the Sports Law (2022), which for the

first time explicitly mandates “special protection” for persons with disabilities in its general principles.

Critically, the policy focus shifted markedly toward grassroots and inclusive services. State Council directives, such as those in the 2011–2015 National Fitness Plan and the 2012 12th Five-Year Plan for the National Basic Public Service System, mandated large-scale construction of “demonstration sites for disability fitness”, installation of adapted equipment, promotion of mass sports and integrated activities, and inclusion of disability categories in national fitness games. The Regulation on the Construction of Barrier-Free Environments (2012) required prioritising accessibility renovations in sports venues, expanding beyond arenas into community spaces.

China’s innovative “elite-to-grassroots empowerment” mechanism is a defining feature. Elite athletic success is creatively channelled into political empowerment. Prominent athletes like Zhang Haidi (former shooter, Chairperson of the CDPF, CPPCC Standing Committee member), Wen Xiaoyan (5-time Paralympic gold medallist, NPC representative), and Sun Pengxiang (elite athlete, local CPPCC member) have attained positions in legislatures, political advisory bodies, and disability federations. From these roles, they leverage their influence to advocate for policies benefiting the broader community, such as increased rural facility investment, national coaching certification systems, professional academic programmes, and post-retirement athlete placement. This represents an institutional innovation that converts “medal dividends” into policy thrust for inclusive development.

Conclusion and Discussion

China’s journey in elite disability sports, from obscurity to global prominence, reflects a difficult yet transformative process. Policy evolution has been distinctly shaped by political factors, with the government as the dominant agenda-setter. The development mirrors changing governmental and societal attitudes toward the disability community.

The Chinese model demonstrates a distinctive approach to balancing elite excellence and inclusive development within a state-led framework. The core of the “Chinese path” lies in the sports-politics interconnection and the elite-empowerment mechanism. Paralympic success acted as a lever for policy upgrade and resource investment. Conversely, the state institutionalised this success by

creating channels for elite athletes' political participation. These empowered elites now actively advocate for broader community interests, pushing policies toward inclusivity and helping mitigate critiques of resource concentration and "supercrip" narratives.

Post-2008 integration into national strategies has facilitated the construction of a relatively comprehensive, standardised system safeguard for disability sports rights, shifting from mere medal pursuit to the "twin-wheel drive" of elite and mass sports. The synergy is evident: elite achievements inspire participation; the talent system (e.g., Zhang Haidi's "four-tier" system) supports grassroots activity; and elite policy advocacy drives resource distribution downward.

This "Chinese path" offers a valuable case study for state-dominated societies, showing how medal-driven outcomes can be partially converted into a force for inclusive sharing through top-level design, institutional building, and elite empowerment. It provides a governance perspective for developing nations facing similar challenges.

Nevertheless, challenges persist. Ensuring effective grassroots implementation, eliminating urban-rural disparities, meeting the diverse needs of individuals with severe disabilities or non-Paralympic sports interests, and broadening direct policy participation beyond elite representation remain crucial tasks for future policy optimisation and research. The continued development of disability sports in China relies on deepening systemic reform and strengthening grassroots execution based on the existing path, ultimately serving the fundamental goal of comprehensive development and social integration for all persons with disabilities.

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THE CONFLICT AND INTEGRATION OF VALUES IN THE INCLUSION OF ESPORTS IN THE OLYMPICS – A SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS BASED ON SYMBOLIC INTERACTION THEORY

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Abstract

The rapid development of esports around the world has attracted widespread attention from all walks of life by virtue of esports' globalisation, youthfulness and fashionability. In recent years, whether esports can be included in the Olympic Games has become a controversial topic in the field of international sports. This study explores the integration of esports into the Olympic Games through theoretical analyses of symbolic interaction, including the “referential function of symbols”, the “dynamic process of interaction” and the “logic of constructing meaning”. The study examines the value conflict and integration of esports into the Olympic Games. The study concludes that the value conflict of esports in the Olympic Games is related to the conflict of body view, governance view and cultural view. Constructing the integration of esports and Olympic values is a key factor in achieving the inclusion of esports in the Olympic Games. The integration of esports and Olympic values should be promoted by systematically constructing the symbolic meaning of esports, emphasising the “sportiness” of esports, strengthening the “stability” of esports, and enhancing the “positivity” of esports elements. This process will provide a theoretical foundation and practical path for esports to follow Olympic values and the Olympic spirit and integrate into the Olympic Games harmoniously.

Keywords: esports, esports in the Olympics, Olympics, values, symbolic interactionism

1. Introduction

In recent years, esports has rapidly become an emerging force in the global sports industry and cannot be ignored by virtue of its globalised tournament system, youthful participant groups and fashionable cultural expression (Cranmer, 2021). However, the controversy over its inclusion in the Olympic Games has always existed, with the cautious attitude of the IOC, the scepticism of the traditional sports community and the esports industry's demand for inclusion in the Olympics forming a stark difference. The essence of this controversy is not simply a matter of programme selection, but rather a difference in the symbolic perception of the "value of sport" and the "connotation of competition" among different groups.

The theory of symbolic interaction provides a unique perspective for analysing this controversy, and its core idea of emphasising the dynamic construction of social meaning through symbolic interaction can reveal the collision and integration of values between Olympic sports and esports in terms of physical, governance and cultural views. Based on the theory of symbolic interaction, this paper systematically analyses the conflict of values between esports and the Olympic Games, and explores the path of integration of the two sets of values, with a view to providing theoretical references for understanding the construction of virtual sports values in the digital era and their integration with Olympic values.

2. A Framework for Analysing the Values of Esports in the Olympic Games within the Framework of Symbolic Interaction Theory

2.1 Symbolic Interaction Theory

Symbolic interactionism is an important school of social theory that emerged in the early twentieth century, with the University of Chicago at its centre. Its philosophical roots are in pragmatism, and most sociologists either have a background in pragmatist thinking or have been strongly influenced by it. The theory asserts that social reality is an ongoing process shaped by the interactions of actors, and focuses on the critical role of symbolic interaction in the construction of meaning, the formation of self-consciousness, and the establishment of identity. It is committed to exploring the mechanisms by which social norms and forms of social organisation are established from the immediate source of social life,

arguing that this immediate source is the nodes of actor interaction in social life rather than the functional structure of society (Mead, 1934).

The basic premises of the theory were made explicit by Blumer in *The Theory of Symbolic Interaction: Perspectives and Methods* (Blumer, 1986). These premises may seem simple, but they are crucial. The core ideas are: human actions have meaning, and this meaning is not only related to the thing as an object, but also closely linked to the life of the person using the sign; the understanding of meaning arises from the person's relationship with the thing being dealt with as well as from the person's interactions with his or her peers; and there is a socio-historical process of development of the understanding of meaning, and the process of dealing with the thing is itself an interpretive process in which the meaning is interpreted.

2.2 The Applicability of the Symbolic Interactionist Framework in Analysing the Entry of Esports into Olympic Values

The theory of symbolic interaction highlights that the meaning of social phenomena is not fixed and objective, but is gradually generated through continuous symbolic exchange and interactive negotiation between individuals and groups. The core essence of the concept lies in the in-depth analysis of the intrinsic correlation between the "referential function of symbols", "the dynamic process of interaction" and "the logic of constructing meaning" (Turner, 1988). In the issue of the inclusion of esports in the Olympics, "Olympics" and "esports" are undoubtedly the two core symbols carrying specific values, and their respective symbolic systems have distinctive uniqueness, but also continue to collide and merge in the interaction.

In the issue of the inclusion of esports in the Olympics, "Olympics" and "esports" themselves are core symbols carrying specific values. The former constructs stable symbolic meanings such as "sportsmanship", "fair competition" and "common values of mankind" through the slogan of "Higher, Faster, Stronger – Together", the symbols of the five rings and the flow of ceremonies. Esports constructs stable symbolic meanings through game symbols (e.g., the Summoner's Canyon of League of Legends, the hero characters of DOTA2), tournament symbols (professional team badges, live streaming pop-up culture), and group symbols (the identities of "e-campaigners" and "gamer communities"). These symbols form the emerging symbolic meanings of "digital competition",

“intergenerational culture”, “technological innovation”, etc. The interaction between the two types of symbols is essentially a struggle for the right to define “sport”, “competition” and “value” among different groups (the IOC, esports industry practitioners, the public, the media, etc.). The theory of symbolic interaction sees this as a dynamic process of “negotiation of meaning” rather than a static confrontation of values, which provides a micro-macro connection to the controversy over the inclusion of esports in the Olympic Games.

3. Manifestations of Value Conflict in the Inclusion of Esports in the Olympics

3.1 Conflicting Views of the Body: Cognitive Divergence from “Physical Limits” to “Digital Manipulation”

The Olympic Movement’s view of the body is founded on the worship of human physical potential; the ancient Greek Olympic Games had the “display of a fit body” as its central purpose, and the modern Olympic Games have used athletics and swimming as benchmarks to test the limits of the body. This view of the body has been repeatedly reinforced in the official discourse of the International Olympic Committee (IOC), creating a consensus on the value of “the need for sport to be centred on direct physical confrontation” (The Fundamentals of Olympic Values Education, 2017).

Physical participation in esports, on the other hand, is to some extent characterised by “de-physicalisation” – the core competence of the players is embodied in the speed of finger manipulation, the precision of brain reaction, etc., and the range of movement of the body is confined by being in front of the computer. This difference has sparked questions from the traditional sports community: former IOC President Bach has stated that “there is a conflict between esports and Olympic values”, behind which lies a symbolic rejection of esports’ “non-physicality”. However, the esports community has countered this perception through interactions such as citing medical research that proves that “professional esports players have hand-eye coordination as well as perceptual abilities that are far superior to those of normal people” (Kim, 2022). Attempting to reconstruct the symbolic connotations of “physical ability”, this cognitive divergence constitutes the underlying logic of the value conflict.

3.2 Conflicting Views of Governance: the Collision of the Olympic Organisational System and the Esports Governance Model

The Olympic Movement has a highly unified global governance system, with the IOC as the core, the International Federations as the support, and the National Olympic Committees as the foundation, forming a “pyramid” organisational structure whereby the entry of all sports into the Olympic Games is subject to the standard processes set out in the Olympic Charter, including hard indicators such as the popularity of the sport, anti-doping norms, gender equality implementation, etc. (Olympic Charter, 2025). Such organisational rules emphasise “standardisation” and “authority”, and require that programmes are fully integrated into the established governance framework.

The governance model of esports, on the other hand, is “polycentric”, with game manufacturers, third-party tournament operators, regional esports associations, and other entities holding some of the power. For example, League of Legends tournament rules are set by Riot Games, and DOTA2 international tournaments are led by Valve Corporation, lacking a unified global governance body. Such decentralised governance is in direct conflict with the Olympic value system of “centralisation”, but it is still difficult to establish a unified global official governing body for esports, given the current situation of the industry, where distributing commercial interests in a reasonable manner poses difficulties. In addition, the Olympic requirement of “depoliticisation” of Olympic sports is in conflict with the issues of geographical copyright division and commercial competition between manufacturers of some esports, which is essentially a difference in values between the two types of organisations in terms of their “logic of governance”.

3.3 Conflicting Cultural Perspectives: the Interface Between Intergenerational Subcultures and Global Mainstream Culture

Pursuing educational value, the Olympics attempts to transcend ethnic, religious and generational differences and construct an imaginary “human community” through symbols such as the five rings and the common rules of the games. This view of culture stresses stability and inheritance. For example, the opening ceremony of the Olympic Games, through the carefully choreographed flow of ceremonies—from the entry of delegations in national costumes to show cultural diversity, to the passing of the sacred fire to symbolise mankind’s common quest

for peace, to the singing of the theme song to convey the concept of unity and love – systematically demonstrates that different countries and nationalities can be united in the Olympic Games. By systematically displaying the core values of different countries and nationalities, and leveraging the potential of global live broadcasting, the event has engraved a collective memory in the hearts of billions of viewers that transcends regions and cultures, and has become a spiritual bond that unites the consensus of mankind (The Fundamentals of Olympic Values Education, 2017).

On the other hand, esports culture is characterised by a distinct inter-generational subculture, with its symbolic system (e.g., gaming terminology, pop-up culture, and team fan culture) spreading mainly among Generation Z. The older generation has a deeper understanding of traditional sports competitions and its perception of esports often remains at the level of “playing games”, making it difficult for them to understand its cultural value as a “competitive sport”. The younger generation see esports as a “label of self-identity” and feel alienated from the “seriousness” of traditional sports competitions. This intergenerational cultural gap has led to the question of whether esports would be in line with Olympic values if they were integrated into Olympic culture.

4. Path of Integration Between Esports and Olympic Values

4.1 Systematically Constructing Symbolism and Emphasising the “Sportiness” of Esports

Starting from the meaning construction logic of symbolic interaction theory, it is necessary to strengthen the symbolic meaning of the “sportiness” of esports through multi-dimensional initiatives and to break the single symbolic definition of “sport” in traditional sports. We need to clarify the physical indicators of cardiorespiratory function and muscular endurance that professional esports players need to achieve, incorporate “physical training” into the daily training system of esports players, and demonstrate the intensity of their training through documentaries and broadcasts of tournaments—for example, by filming the players doing long-distance running, strength training, and so on. This visually echoes the training scenes of traditional athletes, and the symbolic perception that “esports” is also equal to “sports” can be reshaped in the public interaction.

At the same time, the core elements of sports, such as the penalty standards of

Olympic sports, must be integrated into the rules of the event, and fair competition norms for esports, such as strictly prohibiting any form of cheating software and setting up uniform standards for venues and equipment, should be established. Through these institutional symbols which are similar to those of traditional sports, the IOC, the public and other groups can gradually bind esports to the meaning of “sports competition” in their interactions, and eliminate rejection due to its “non-sports nature”.

4.2 Improve the Industry Normative System and Strengthen the “Stability” of Esports

The lack of “stability” in the esports industry is an important obstacle to its integration into the Olympics, and a standardised system is needed to enhance predictability in symbolic interactions. First, a cross-regional industry alliance should be established to integrate the resources of global esports associations, game manufacturers, and clubs, and formulate a unified registration system, transfer rules, and salary system for professional players—similar to FIFA’s management model for football players—so as to reduce disputes due to confusing rules, and to enable the IOC to recognise its attributes as a “regulated sport” in interaction. The IOC will recognise the attributes of “regulated sports” (Regulations governing international matches, 2019).

Second, the institutionalisation of the esports education system should be promoted. The opening of esports training and event management majors in institutions of higher learning should be encouraged, esports should be incorporated into the academic education system, and coaches, referees, and operational talents with professional qualities should be cultivated. Such educational symbols can convey the meaning that “esports is a formal industry for sustainable development” to society, echoing the “educational value” emphasised by the Olympics. In addition, a long-term event cycle system should be established, with reference to the four-year model of the Olympic Games, to fix the frequency and time of the world’s top esports events, and to enhance its symbol of stability in public perception.

4.3 Tapping into Positive Value Connotations to Enhance the “Positivity” of Esports Elements

In response to the negative symbolic labelling of esports in terms of violence and

addition, it is necessary to enhance the “positivity” of its elements through value reconstruction, so as to form a meaningful resonance with the Olympic values. Game manufacturers can optimise the content of existing esports projects by reducing the bloody images in projects such as *Counter-Strike* and increasing the plot guidance of “team mutual aid” and “fair competition”, for example, by setting the victory condition as “cooperation to crack the puzzle” instead of “eliminating the opponent”. Olympic elements can be incorporated into the design of game symbols – for example, embedding the five rings logo in the map and adding the slogan “Friendship First” to the characters’ costumes, so as to convey positive meanings through the interaction of visual symbols.

At the same time, a linkage mechanism between esports and social welfare can be created. We can organise esports players to participate in public welfare activities such as “Sports Poverty Alleviation” and “esports training for the disabled”. Through media coverage of their public welfare behaviours, the identity symbols of “esports players” are bound to “social responsibility” and “positive energy idols”. Drawing on the role model effect of Olympic athletes, esports players can become positive role models for young people. For example, esports players can be invited to talk on campus about their experiences of growing up with “perseverance and hard work”, so that the symbolic meaning of “esports”, which is also equal to the “spirit of hard work”, can be spread through intergenerational interactions, and the prejudice of the older group that esports are the dregs of a subculture can be dispelled.

5. Conclusion

Based on the theory of symbolic interaction, this study reveals that the essence of the value conflict behind the inclusion of esports in the Olympics is the process of negotiating the meanings of different symbolic systems. The values of esports and the Olympics are not irreconcilable opposites, but can be integrated through symbolic reconstruction, situational adaptation, and identity integration. In the future, as the interaction between the two groups deepens, the symbolic definition of “sport” will be further expanded, and the inclusion of esports in the Olympics will not only become a reality, but will also push the Olympic Movement to realise its own innovation in the digital era.

From a practical point of view, it is necessary to be wary of the integration

model of “complete one-way compromise” — esports should not completely abandon its own characteristics for the sake of Olympic integration, and the Olympics should recognise the value of the new form of competition. Only by maintaining equality and negotiation in the interaction can we realise a true integration of values and make esports a new element to enrich the Olympic connotation.

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THE EFFECT OF ATHLETES' BODY NARRATIVES IN OLYMPIC DOCUMENTARIES ON AUDIENCES

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Abstract

Olympic documentaries, as visual narratives of the global premier sporting event, embody unique communicative value within the framework of sports media. Athlete body narratives, a central thematic element in these documentaries, encapsulate both personal development and collective national ethos. Consequently, audiences' perceptions of athletes' physicality critically shape viewing experiences. Based on body narratology theory, this study categorises body narratives in Olympic documentaries into two types: physical behaviour and difficulty element. A 2×2 between-subjects factorial design was employed to examine the differential impacts of body narrative types on distinct audience groups. The study further explores how Olympic documentaries, as visual media, strategically deploy athlete body narratives to visually articulate Olympism and foster the conceptualisation of a global sports civilization community.

1. Introduction

The Olympic Movement originated from the Olympic Games in ancient Greece. During its modernisation process, many artistic and literary works have been created about the Olympics. Documentaries, which combine factual and artistic elements, use the body as a key visual tool. This is especially important in

documentaries about the Olympics. In Olympic documentaries, the bodies of athletes play a significant role in awakening the audiences' senses and strength, as well as promoting the dissemination of Olympic culture.

However, issues such as how athletes' bodies in Olympic documentaries affect audiences, what effects they have, and whether these effects vary among different audience groups remain understudied. Most current research on sports documentaries and body narratology uses qualitative methods and focuses on audio-visual language. Few studies use sports documentaries as experimental materials or classify the body types of athletes for research. Therefore, a 2×2 between-subjects factorial design was employed to examine the differential impacts of body narrative types on distinct audience groups. The study further explores how Olympic documentaries, as visual media, use body narratives to express Olympism and support the concept of a global sports community.

2. The Conceptualisation of Athletes' Bodies

The concept of body narratology was first proposed by the American scholar Daniel Punday in his article "A Corporeal Narratology?". He found that the body has been neglected in important ways in narratology, and his discussion on this point has revealed it as a perfectly narratological object. In 2003, his book *Narrative Bodies: Toward a Corporeal Narratology* officially introduced the body into narratology.

Another leading figure in body narratology is the American scholar Peter Brooks. In his 1993 work *Body Work: Objects of Desire in Modern Narrative*, he examines how the body, viewed through the lens of desire, functions as a mechanism of narrative dynamic.

In addition, Daniel Punday mentioned in his construction of the concept of "body narratology" that the body is shaped not merely by thematic or cultural influences, but also by the specifically narrative terms in which the writer is representing the body. That is to say, authors' choices in the representation of body are delimited by typically narrative concerns like the need to present a narrator, to describe a setting, and to make action meaningful. Thus, each narrative type defines body types within a certain range, allowing the body and actions to create meaning through personalisation.

As body narratology has been applied more widely, definitions based on

physical traits have become more common. For example, scholars defined muscle shape as a key factor. A lean body with low fat and a healthy look was called the “athletic ideal”, while a thin body with clear muscle development and definition in the legs, arms, and abdomen was called the “muscular ideal”.

Based on the above viewpoints, in the selected samples of Olympic documentaries, this study classified athletes’ bodies into “physical behaviour” and “difficulty element” from visual and content perspectives, and conceptualised them.

Physical Behaviour:

The visual content conveyed by athletes’ bodies, by presenting the plot and process of the body completing movements, focusing on the process to evoke audience feelings and embodied cognition. It emphasises storytelling.

The main subjects are diverse (e.g., athletes, coaches or spectators). The content refers to the process by which athletes complete movements during training or competitions and perform action transformation in multiple scenarios. Using zoom and real-time tracking, the camera captures full technical movements with stable shots.

Difficulty Element:

This highlights the visual effect of athletes’ bodies during high-difficulty moments, like explosive moves, to show visual impact and aesthetic appeal. It emphasises visual attraction.

The main subjects are athletes themselves. The content concentrates on showcasing the explosive points, challenging moves, and muscle curves during jumps or turns. In the same scene, similar or repeated actions are shown. Clarity and dynamic sense are maintained by focusing or quickly switching the focal length.

Besides body types, audiences were also grouped. Students with a sports background have long-term training and deeper understanding of their bodies, so their viewing experience may differ from that of general viewers. Thus, audiences are classified into athletes and ordinary viewers.

3. Research Hypothesis

Body Image

Body image is a multi-dimensional structure that represents an individual's cognition, behaviour, perception and emotional response to their own body. Human evaluation of body image is summarised as "accepting and holding a favourable impression of the body while rejecting the stereotypical beauty of mainstream ideals". Positive body image can be defined as having love, confidence, respect, appreciation and acceptance of one's own body. Negative body image often involves dissatisfaction and can harm self-esteem or self-concept in extreme cases.

Social Comparison Theory suggests that individuals frequently assess their success and levels of ability by comparing themselves to others. The central proposition is "similarity comparison", that is, individuals prefer to compare themselves with similar people. Research confirms that social comparison is related to high levels of physical dissatisfaction.

Applying this to visuals, compared with ordinary viewers, athletes are more similar to those in documentaries in terms of identity, fitness, and psychology. Thus, they have more conditions for "similarity comparison". The "difficulty element" type has stronger visual impact than "physical behaviour". Therefore, when watching Olympic documentaries, athletes are more inclined to make comparisons when seeing ideal bodies than ordinary viewers. Accordingly, this study posits the following hypothesis:

H1: Regarding the "difficulty element" of athletes in Olympic documentaries, athletes develop a more negative body image than ordinary viewers.

The body, as the experiential subject for perceiving the world, is the focus of people's attention. Visual body sensations create a close link between the image and audiences' bodies, reducing psychological distance and extending emotions.

"Physical behaviour" tends to show the process of actions, with a documentary style. Compared with this type, "difficulty element" has a stronger visual effect, impacting the audiences' senses more directly and emotionally. This creates visual identity and embodied perception. Therefore, visual impact has a greater advantage in strengthening audiences' positive image of the body. The following hypothesis is proposed:

H2: Compared with "physical behaviour", ordinary viewers develop a more positive body image towards "difficulty element".

Documentary Evaluation

In the social comparison theory, Festinger also proposed that when the desire to compare with similar people is combined, the drive for upward comparison will enable an individual to reach a slightly better level than usual. Therefore, when there is a difference between oneself and the comparative standard, one will have the motivation to improve oneself in order to get closer to the comparative standard. When compared with “physical behaviour”, “difficulty element” presents a stronger visual impact. For athletes, this may increase training motivation and body appreciation, leading to higher appeal and more positive evaluations. Therefore, the hypothesis is proposed:

H3: Compared with “physical behaviour”, athletes have a more positive evaluation of “difficulty element”.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty proposed the concept of “embodied subjectivity”, regarding the body as a natural self and perceptual subject. As an intermediary, the body helps people examine the world in practice, and it is shaped by social factors.

People’s perceptions of their bodies are socialised, and influenced by culture, society, and personal experiences. Athletes have unique backgrounds, training, and social images. Their physical expression is technical and competitive. They are more similar to athletes in documentaries than ordinary viewers. Thus, when evaluating “physical behaviour”, athletes pay more attention to technical details and professionalism and less on the story. Ordinary viewers, with different life experiences, may be more likely to immerse themselves in the narrative presented by the athletes’ bodies. Therefore, the hypothesis is proposed:

H4: Regarding the “physical behaviour” in Olympic documentaries, athletes give a more negative evaluation than ordinary viewers.

4. Method

An experimental study was conducted to test the hypotheses. This experiment adopts a 2 (body type: physical behaviour vs. difficulty element) $\times$ 2 (audience: athletes vs. ordinary viewers) between-subject design.

Stimuli

The study selected six 60-episode Olympic documentaries produced by China Media Group during the cycles of the Rio Olympics, Tokyo Olympics and Paris

Olympics, which focused on Chinese athletes' preparation or competition in Olympic events. Some clips from these six documentaries were edited into two experimental videos.

Name	Theme	Broadcasting Time	Broadcasting Platform	Number of Episode	The duration of each episode
《Prepare for Rio》 《备战里约》	The preparations of Chinese athletes for the Rio Olympics	Aug 2016	CCTV9	5	25min
《Chinese sports set out again》 《中国体育再出发》	The preparations of Chinese athletes for the Rio Olympics	Aug 2016	Olympic Channel	5	45min
《Starlight on the Journey: The Chinese Women's Volleyball Team's Championship Win in Rio》 《星耀征途：中国女排里约夺冠记》	The story of the Chinese women's volleyball team winning the championship at the Rio Olympics	May 2018	CCTV5	3	50min
《Expeditions》 《出征》	The preparations of Chinese athletes for the Tokyo Olympics	July 2021	CCTV5	21	25-48min
《Blossom in Paris》 《绽放巴黎》	The preparations of Chinese athletes for the Paris Olympics	July 2024	CCTV5、CCTV16	25	30-45min
《The Way to Paris》 《巴黎之路》	A Review of the Performance of Chinese Athletes at the Paris Olympics	December 2024	CCTV5	1	1h10min

Figure 1 Selection of Samples

Participants and Procedure

Participants, 100 athletes and 100 ordinary viewers, were recruited in Beijing. Athletes came from four universities (Beijing Sport University, Capital University of Physical Education and Sports, Beijing Normal University, and Minzu University of China) and professional training bases. Ordinary viewers were selected from undergraduate or postgraduate students, as well as faculty members of universities in Beijing.

The 200 participants were divided into four groups. 50 athletes and 50 spectators watched “experiment 1”(physical behaviour), while the other 50 athletes and 50 spectators watched “experiment 2” (difficulty element). After viewing, the participants were asked to finish two questionnaires, which took approximately 5 to 10 minutes. After completing, each participant received 30 yuan as compensation.

Measures

Body Image: The revised physical self-perception profile, Body Appreciation Scale, and Body Mass Anxiety Scale were adopted. For PSPP-R, 8 items from 24 across four subscales (physical attractiveness, strength, ability, condition) were selected. For BAS, 5 items relevant to this study were chosen from 10. The BMAS consists of 20 items and 7 questions are selected. A total of 20 items were selected from the three scales, and the above items were integrated into a scale of body image. Participants were rated on the 5-point Likert Scale (1 = strongly disagree; 5 = strongly agree), and items 14 to 20 were given reverse scores to calculate the total score of each item.

Documentary evaluation was based on five items rated on a 5-point Likert scale: “How attractive is this video?”, “Does the athletes’ story touch you?”, “How do you evaluate the athletes’ bodies?”, “How many points would you give to the athlete’s body image?”, “How do you evaluate the athletes’ physical attractiveness?” The total score of the five items was calculated.

5. Results

Validity and Reliability

Reliability analysis showed Cronbach’s Alpha values of 0.815 and 0.802 for the two scales, both above the standard of 0.7. The validity was tested by factor analysis. KMO values were 0.712 and 0.771 respectively. The Bartlett sphericity test values were 902.462(df=190, $p<0.001$) and 257.073(df=6, $p<0.001$). Therefore, the scales had high reliability and validity.

Hypothesis Testing

Table 1 The difference between athletes and viewers for difficult element				
	Types(M±SD)		t	p
	Athletes(n=50)	Ordinary Viewers(n=50)		
Body Image	73.86±4.932	76.82±6.675	-2.522	0.013

$$p<0.05$$

Table 2 The differences after watching the two types by ordinary audiences				
	Types(M±SD)		t	p
	physical behavior	difficulty element		
	(n=50)	(n=50)	-2.160	0.034

$$p < 0.05$$

To test the four hypotheses, a set of t tests were conducted. As Table 1 shows, there is a significant difference in body image ($t = -2.522$, $p < 0.05$) between athletes and ordinary viewers after watching “difficult element” clips. Table 2 shows that after watching both body types, the body image ($t = -2.160$, $p < 0.05$) of ordinary viewers is significantly different. Therefore, H1 and H2 are largely supported.

Table 3 The different evaluations of the two types by athletes				
Documentary evaluation	physical behavior	difficulty element	(z)	p
	(n=50)	(n=50)		
	17.5(16, 19)	18(16, 20)	-0.529	0.597

Table 4 The different evaluations of physical behavior by athletes and viewers				
Documentary evaluation	Athletes(n=50)	Ordinary Viewers(n=50)	(z)	p
	17.5(16, 19)	18(16, 19)	-0.070	0.944

For H3 and H4, normality tests showed that the data were not normally distributed, so the Mann–Whitney U test was used instead. As shown in Table 3, there is no significant difference between the two types in athletes’ evaluation ($U = 1174.5$, $Z = -0.529$, $p > 0.05$). Meanwhile, Table 4 shows no significant difference between athletes and ordinary viewers in evaluating “physical behaviour” ($U = 1240$, $Z = -0.070$, $p > 0.05$). Therefore, H3 and H4 are not supported.

Based on the above experiment, when watching Olympic documentaries with two different body types, different types of audiences will have differences

in body image, but there is no significant difference in documentary evaluation. In the following discussion, we will explore how the bodies of athletes composed of these two types generate propagation effects on audiences.

6. Discussion: The Propagation Effects of Athletes' Body Narratives

Enhance Audiences' Emotional Cognition and Sports Awareness

“Physical behaviour” narratives in Olympic documentaries visually show athletes' training and competition processes. This approach not only displays sports achievements but also explores personal stories, struggles, mental states, and family support. Audiences have the chance to see athletes' growth, and this humanised storytelling brings them closer to athletes, making emotional connection easier.

Body narratives also broaden how audiences think about the Olympics, extending from focusing on athletes and events to reflection on the significance of sports. For instance, when presenting physical behaviour, some classic Olympic moments (such as breaking a world record or a country's first gold medal) help audiences understand these historic moments and enhance their knowledge of the Olympics. In addition, Olympic documentaries showcase the extreme physical pressures that athletes endure, thereby helping audiences to better comprehend the challenges and difficulties inherent in sports. This in-depth representation serves to dispel common misconceptions about competitive sports and fosters a deeper respect and understanding of athletic endeavour.

Showcase the Sport Aesthetics and Humanities Concern

As a fundamental part of sport aesthetics, the body is particularly important in the audio-visual language of Olympic documentaries. The “difficulty element” type highlights explosive sports moments. It shows athletes performing difficult moves, letting audiences experience these actions visually, and creating an immersive effect. Each aerial phase, rotation, and landing embodies the athlete's continuous exploration and transcendence of physical limits. The improvement during preparation, intense competition, and physical collisions are presented creatively, showing not only the beauty of athletes' poses but also the visual appeal of sports and the Olympic spirit.

Through the portrayal of athletes' bodies, audiences can see the common pursuits and values of humanity among athletes from different countries and races. This kind of body narrative promotes cross-cultural understanding and exchange. Despite differences in nationality, skin colour or experience, the sports spirit shown through their bodies connects them as "a community of shared future", enabling the sports cultures of various ethnic groups and countries to achieve emotional integration and value resonance.

Pass on the Vitality of the Olympic Spirit

The Olympic Movement advocates that "sports serve the harmonious development of humankind", aiming to establish a peaceful society that upholds human dignity. The reason why the Olympics have a lasting vitality is that generations of athletes kept practising the Olympic spirit of "mutual understanding, friendship, unity and fair play" in the Olympic Games.

Whether "physical behaviour" or "difficult movements", they are all part of athletes' body performances. Olympic documentaries use detailed visual language to capture every aspect of athletes' bodies in competition: muscle tension, fast breathing, tired expressions and breakthrough moments. Each frame conveys the vitality of the Olympic spirit to the audience. This way of conveying the spirit through the body breaks down language and culture barriers, enabling the Olympic spirit to cross borders and generations, and making the Olympics a shared emotional bond for the world.

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THE STRATEGIC ADAPTATION OF IFSC COMPETITION RULES IN THE OLYMPIC ERA: EVOLUTION, DRIVERS, AND GLOBAL IMPACT

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Abstract

The inclusion of sport climbing in the Tokyo 2020 Olympic programme accelerated the sport's globalisation, institutionalisation, and professionalisation, prompting comprehensive reforms in its competition rules. This paper examines the evolutionary trajectory of the International Federation of Sport Climbing (IFSC) competition rules, analysing the drivers, developmental phases, and global implications of these changes. Using a mixed-methods approach – including documentary analysis of IFSC rulebooks (2007–2025), interviews with officials, athletes, and coaches, and participatory observation at international events – this study identifies four evolutionary phases: initial development, progressive refinement, Olympic-driven acceleration, and adaptive innovation. The research highlights how internal factors (e.g., technological progress, safety, integrity) and external forces (e.g., Olympic integration, commercial pressure, globalisation) have interactively shaped a dynamic regulatory framework. The findings underscore the importance of strategic rule adaptation in balancing athletic integrity, safety, spectator engagement, and sustainable development. This study offers theoretical and practical insights for the global climbing community and serves as a reference for other emerging sports undergoing Olympic integration.

Keywords: sport climbing; International Federation of Sport Climbing (IFSC); rule evolution; Olympic Games; sports governance; technical standardisation; globalisation

Introduction

Sport climbing's inclusion in the Tokyo 2020 Olympics marked a turning point, accelerating its globalisation and professionalisation. As a composite sport featuring boulder, lead, and speed disciplines, it faced unique regulatory challenges in standardisation across diverse cultural and competitive contexts. The IFSC has continually revised its rules to enhance fairness, safety, spectator appeal, and alignment with International Olympic Committee (IOC) standards. This paper argues that the evolution of IFSC rules represents a strategic, Olympic-driven adaptation process aimed at balancing traditional values with innovation, commercial appeal, and global accessibility. Despite these changes, academic research on the patterns and drivers of this evolution remains limited. This study aims to fill this gap by tracing the historical development of IFSC rules, identifying key drivers, analysing implementation challenges, and discussing implications for the future of sport climbing.

Literature Review and Theoretical Framework

Sports competition rules serve as the foundation of competitive sports, ensuring order and enabling diverse social values. Liu Shuying (2008) highlighted the role of rules as “the law on the field of play”, while Liu Zhuo (1998) explored the philosophical tension between constraint and freedom in rule design. Suits (1988) and Loland (2002) offered frameworks for understanding how rules balance subjective and objective elements in hybrid sports like climbing.

Chen Yan (2004) proposed an internal-external cause model for rule evolution, which this study adopts. Internal factors include project development needs, while external factors encompass economic, political, and cultural influences. Trends such as enhanced parity, judgment standardisation, and commercialisation (Sheng Qi, 1989; Liu Jian, 2002) are evident in IFSC rule changes. Guttmann's (1978) theory of rationalisation further explains the shift from experiential to standardised rule systems.

Specialised research on competitive climbing has grown recently. Li Yuan and Zhu Beifeng (2020) traced the sport's evolution from mountaineering to an Olympic discipline, emphasising the role of organisational independence. Robinson & Batuev (2019) and Lutter et al. (2019) analysed Olympic-induced

organisational and anti-doping changes. Gao Fengming and Zhang Wenrou (2022) and Wang Junjie and Long Bin (2021) examined the technical and competitive impacts of rule changes.

However, existing studies lack systematic periodisation, integrated mechanism analysis, and interdisciplinary perspectives. This study introduces a “strategic adaptation” framework integrating institutional theory (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983) and resource dependence theory (Pfeffer & Salancik, 1978), viewing rule evolution as a strategic response to environmental pressures and organisational autonomy.

Methodology

This study employs a mixed-methods case study design, primarily qualitative. Data sources include IFSC rulebooks (2007–2025), academic publications, policy documents, and semi-structured interviews with key stakeholders (IFSC officials, judges, coaches, athletes). Comparative analysis of rule books identified modification patterns. Interviews provided insights into decision-making and implementation challenges. Participatory observation at international events enriched contextual understanding.

Document Analysis

Systematic searches of CNKI and Web of Science yielded 126 articles on competitive climbing rules. Ten IFSC rulebook editions (2007–2025) were analysed diachronically.

In-depth Interviews

Twelve experts were interviewed (average duration: 90 minutes). Interviews were recorded and transcribed. Interviewees included IFSC officials, judges, route-setters, broadcasters, coaches, and athletes.

Participatory Observation

The author, as an IFSC judge, participated in 12 international events (2019–2024), collecting firsthand data through field notes and reflective journals.

Data Analysis

Triangulation of documents, interviews, and observations ensured credibility. Data were structured from first-order concepts to aggregate dimensions.

Evolution of IFSC Rules: Four Distinct Developmental Phases

1. Initial Development and Foundation Phase (Pre-2010)

Early rules were fragmented, regionally influenced, and empirically based. European traditions dominated, with varying safety and scoring standards. The UIAA initiated standardisation in 1985, but progress was slow due to internal conflicts. This phase laid the groundwork for future centralisation.

2. Progressive Refinement and Standardisation Phase (2010–2016)

IFSC's establishment (2007) centralised rule-making. Key advances included technical specifications (wall angles, hold spacing), judging innovations (Zone + Top scoring, Video Replay System), and safety improvements (equipment certification, medical protocols). Rules shifted from descriptive to prescriptive.

3. Olympic-Driven Acceleration and Transformation Phase (2016–2020)

Olympic inclusion triggered intense changes: the combined format integrated three disciplines; competition times were compressed for broadcasting; electronic timing and instant replay were mandated; anti-doping protocols were strengthened; and commercial norms (sponsor logos, scoring displays) were introduced. These changes sparked debate over tradition versus commercialisation.

4. Adaptive Innovation and Consolidation Phase (2020–Present)

Post-Tokyo adjustments included discipline separation (speed, boulder, lead), technical refinements (dynamic starts, four-lane speed races), gender equality (prize money, route-setter inclusion), and sustainability standards (recycling, carbon footprint). This stage demonstrates a maturation of the regulatory approach, with the IFSC beginning to seek a more refined balance between competitive requirements and social responsibility. Rule revisions now place greater emphasis on multi-stakeholder participation, with significantly increased

transparency in the decision-making process.

Core Dimensions of Rule Evolution: A Strategic Focus on the Spectator Experience

Based on long-term field observation and interviews with IFSC management, technical officials, and committee members, this study finds that IFSC rule adjustments peaked at several key points: 2012 (shortlisted for Tokyo 2020 candidate), 2016 (official inclusion), and the anticipated 2025 (new post-Paris Olympics cycle). These strategic adjustments are specifically reflected in four dimensions aimed at enhancing global engagement.

1. Shortening Competition Duration

The reasonableness of duration directly affects the physical and mental comfort of spectators. Excessively long competitions lead to fatigue and diminished interest. The IFSC optimised the competition rhythm through several rule adjustments:

Bouldering final running order changed from single climbers sequentially to a maximum of two climbers on site, creating an alternating "climbing-observation" rhythm; climbing time changed from "4 minutes+" to a strict 4-minute cutoff. These adjustments reduced the average duration of a single bouldering final from about 105 minutes for 6 climbers in 2010 to about 85 minutes for 8 climbers in 2024, improving audience attention retention. However, some coaches believe strict time limits hinder athletes from demonstrating their full technical capabilities, necessitating a balance between competitiveness and spectacle.

2. Increasing Competition Density

A slow or frequently interrupted rhythm can make events seem dull and drawn-out. The IFSC significantly increased competition density through speed rule innovations:

False start tolerance reduced from 2 to 1, speeding up round transitions; start signals simplified from "ready-beep" two-stage to immediate start; electronic timing replaced manual timing, reducing interruptions caused by human error disputes; introduction of the "four-lane" parallel race mode doubled the number of head-to-head matches per unit time. These changes have continuously

increased the spectator emotional fluctuation index for speed, indicating that the dense format effectively enhances viewing tension and immersion.

3. Simplifying Rule Calculations

The complexity of rules significantly affects the perception and engagement of diverse audience groups. The IFSC lowered the cognitive threshold through the following improvements: Bouldering ranking changed from a complex calculation based on weighted attempts to an intuitive "Tops over Zones" ordering, making scoring easier to understand. Audience surveys show rule simplification significantly increased the proportion of viewers who "completely understand the competition", effectively expanding the potential viewer base.

4. Facilitating Information Access

The accessibility of real-time information directly impacts spectator engagement and comprehension. The IFSC made important improvements in information transparency:

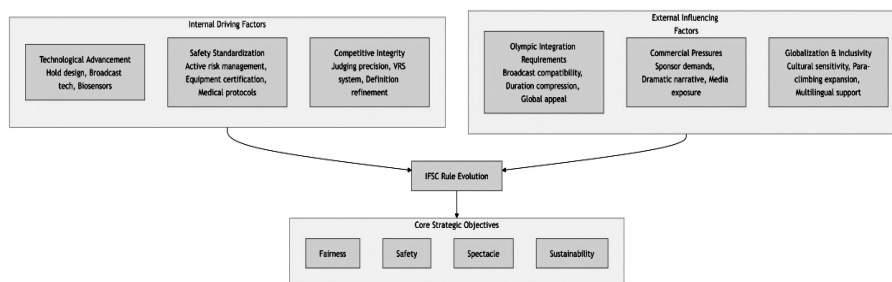
Since 2019, publishing preview images of lead routes, allowing audiences to understand technical difficulties in advance; 2022 rules stipulated that published route maps cannot be changed, eliminating audience confusion caused by last-minute adjustments; developed an AR visualisation system to display biomechanical data such as athlete heart rate, force points, and movement trajectory in real-time; established a multi-language commentary platform supporting synchronous interpretation services in multiple languages. These measures contributed to a rapid rise in global broadcast ratings, validating the role of information accessibility in promoting the sport's globalisation.

The IFSC's rule revisions reflect its conscious effort to balance competitive integrity with a spectator-oriented narrative. By optimising duration, density, clarity, and transparency, the federation has enhanced the sport's watchability and supports its continued development as a sport with global relevance and accessibility.

Multifaceted Factors Influencing Rule Changes

The evolution of competition climbing rules is driven by a complex interplay

of internal and external factors that collectively shape the sport's regulatory framework, as illustrated in the following diagram.



Internal Driving Factors

1. Technological Advancement

Revolutionary improvements in wall and hold design/production, video-assisted judging systems, TV signal production, and wearable sensors for para-climbing necessitate continuous rule updates. The use of carbon fibre holds in 2015 prompted the IFSC to revise hold size standards; 4K-HD broadcast technology in 2018 drove the unification of route colour specifications; the application of biometric technology in 2022 led to athlete health monitoring clauses. These technologies push the IFSC to create rules that maintain competitive integrity while embracing innovation.

2. Safety Standardisation

Increased awareness of athlete welfare within the IFSC drove stricter safety regulations, equipment certification, and medical health standards. A fall incident involving a Russian athlete in 2014 directly led to increased crash pad thickness standards from 30cm to 40cm; a 2019 study on elbow injuries in youth athletes prompted revised hold spacing rules for youth categories. The safety philosophy shifted from passive response to active risk management, with the 2023 rules incorporating a comprehensive risk assessment framework.

3. Maintaining Competitive Integrity

To reduce interference from referees' subjective judgments, the IFSC pursued more detailed and transparent scoring rules. The evolution of the "control" definition in lead climbing is particularly typical: from early "touch" (2010) to "stable control" (2016), to "demonstrably static control" (2023), definitions became increasingly precise. The introduction of the Video Replay System (VRS) increased referee accuracy to nearly 100%, significantly enhancing event credibility.

External Influencing Factors

1. Olympic Integration Requirements

IOC standards regarding broadcast compatibility, event duration, and global spectator appeal directly influenced the rule structure. To meet Olympic demands, the IFSC had to compress traditional multi-day formats into single-day finals (2017); simplify scoring systems for TV broadcast (2019); introduce the combined format to control participant numbers (2016). Although controversial, these changes significantly increased the sport's international exposure. The need to provide transparency for non-expert audiences also influenced route setting, scoring, and commentary methods.

2. Commercial Pressures

Growing influence from sponsors and media broadcasters shaped the rules. The "flash" attempt rule in bouldering finals (2020) enhanced drama; reverse order of appearance in lead climbing based on ranking (2021) created more comeback narratives; standardisation of wall advertising spaces (2018) met sponsor demands. These commercial adjustments enhanced the project's sustainability while also leading to alienation among some traditional climbers.

3. Globalisation and Inclusivity Demands

As climbing developed globally, rule-making emphasised cultural sensitivity and international applicability. The IFSC gradually expanded para-climbing categories (from 2 in 2018 to 6 in 2024); the youth competition system covered multiple age groups from U13 to U19; rule publications supported multiple language versions. Cross-continental, cross-cultural judge training programmes aimed to reduce the impact of cultural bias on judgments. These measures reflect the sport's evolving global identity.

The evolution of IFSC rules is a strategic response to a changing sports ecosystem. Internal driving factors (technology, safety, fairness) and external forces (Olympic integration, commerce, globalisation) interact to shape a dynamic yet principled regulatory framework. This interaction validates the perspective of resource dependence theory, which posits that organisations must adapt to environmental demands to acquire resources necessary for survival, while maintaining autonomy through professional expertise (Pfeffer & Salancik, 1978).

Broader Implications and Future Developmental Trends

The systematic evolution of IFSC rules reflects the broader professionalisation and globalisation of sport climbing. Based on an analysis of current trends, this study predicts that future rule development will focus on the following directions:

Key Areas Requiring Improvement Include

1. Standardisation of Technical Judgments

Judgments regarding handhold identification and "+" control in lead, zone and control recognition in boulder, and fall detection in speed remain prone to misinterpretation. Clearer, more intuitive standards for a global audience are needed. AI-assisted judging systems have the potential to significantly reduce disputed calls.

2. Optimisation of Event Flow

Significant progress is still needed in controlling the duration and density of rounds—especially in lead and bouldering—by reducing non-climbing time and increasing opportunities for athlete-audience interaction to maintain global broadcast appeal. Based on spectator eye-tracking research, the IFSC is experimenting with new "interactive observation" models allowing athletes brief communication with the audience during observation periods.

3. Information Technology Integration

Improving access to competition information through enhanced sport presentation, media dissemination, and live broadcast methods is crucial for

elevating the spectator experience and fostering deeper global fan engagement. The application of AR technology could revolutionise the remote viewing experience, giving online audiences perspectives and interaction opportunities similar to being on-site.

Future Trends May Include

1. Deep Application of AI and Biometric Technology

Artificial intelligence will play a greater role in areas such as route setting (automatically adjusting difficulty based on athlete data), judging and scoring (real-time movement analysis), and performance evaluation (personalised training advice). Biomechanical data from athlete wearables may become a new basis for rule-making.

2. Institutionalisation of Sustainable Development

Environmental standards for event organisation, such as carbon footprint calculations, requirements for wall material recycling rates, and green travel policies, will be further strengthened. It is expected that by 2028, all IFSC events will achieve carbon neutrality, positioning climbing as a model for sustainable sport.

3. Inclusive Development

Para-climbing categories will continue to expand, potentially adding visual impairment classifications; youth development programmes will become more systematic, forming a complete pathway from entry level to professional; gender equality will develop from prize money equality towards deeper participation equality, such as increasing the proportion of female route-setters.

4. Marketing Model Innovation

Esports climbing may become an official competition discipline, attracting a new generation of viewers; dynamic sponsorship systems could adjust advertising placement based on real-time viewership data. These innovations will help climbing remain competitive in the digital economy era.

Conclusion and Theoretical Contribution

The evolution of IFSC rules demonstrates strategic innovation in response to globalisation, commercialisation, and technologisation. The Olympics acted as a catalyst, but the IFSC's balance of tradition and modernity was key to successful integration.

Theoretical contributions include:

(1) an “institutional entrepreneurship” framework showing how IFSC merged traditional and modern logics; (2) validation of “techno-governance” in sports rule evolution; and (3) a “strategic adaptation” model responding to multiple environmental demands.

Practical implications suggest:

(1) stakeholder consultation in rule revision; (2) balancing technology with humanistic values; and (3) respecting regional differences in globalisation.

Future rules should further objective judgment, enhance spectator experience, and integrate digital technology to ensure an inclusive, sustainable, and attractive future for climbing.

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SONIC·SEMIOTIC·CULTURAL: OLYMPIC DIMENSIONS IN URBAN SPORTS—A CASE STUDY OF THE SHANGHAI JIUSHI SHARKS IN THE CBA

Binxin CAO (CHN)

1. Research Background

Amidst the accelerating pace of globalisation and modern urbanisation, professional sports events within cities have evolved beyond mere athletic competitions for citizens. They have become crucial platforms for showcasing urban culture, enhancing city branding, and amplifying urban influence. Leveraging solid fan bases and extensive media exposure, these events project the unique charismatic image of a city. Concurrently, the Olympic spirit (excellence, friendship, respect), as the core value system of international sports, subtly becomes part of the cultural DNA of a city through its sporting events. This paper analyses the construction of Olympic culture within the urban sports image by examining the cultural initiatives embedded in the promotional activities of the Shanghai Jiushi Sharks, a team competing in the Chinese Basketball Association (CBA) league.

Founded in 1996 based on the Shanghai men's basketball team, the Shanghai Jiushi Sharks (formerly known as the Shanghai Oriental Sharks) have cultivated CBA legends such as Yao Ming, Liu Wei, and Zhang Wenqi over their 28-year history. Under the leadership of Yao Ming and Liu Wei, the team secured its sole championship title in 2001. Acquired by the Shanghai Jiushi Group in 2019, the club entered a new era. In recent years, the Sharks' league performance has steadily improved, solidifying their status as one of Shanghai's sporting icons.

Employing theoretical frameworks from sports communication and urban

branding, this study utilises the Shanghai team case to elucidate the mechanisms through which CBA team branding impacts urban image construction and explores its interaction with the Olympic spirit. While substantial research exists on sports communication, primarily focusing on event dissemination and fan behaviour, few studies delve into the dynamic interplay between urban sports events and Olympic culture. This paper addresses this gap, demonstrating how sports events serve as novel conduits for urban branding and the dissemination of Olympism. Furthermore, it provides a practical context for the localised application of the Olympic spirit.

2. Research Questions

2.1 How do the Shanghai Sharks' event cultural communication pathways shape the urban image of Shanghai?

2.2 How does event culture influence urban identity and sense of belonging?

2.3 How does urban sports, specifically through brand communication, embody the Olympic spirit?

3. Research Methodology

3.1 Theoretical Framework:

3.1.1 Charles Sanders Peirce's Semiotics

Peirce's semiotic theory provides a profound framework for dissecting the nature and meaning of signs. He categorised signs into icons (based on resemblance), indices (based on causal or spatiotemporal connection), and symbols (based on social convention), defining the relationship between the signifier and the signified.¹ Peirce emphasised the "interpretant"—the meaning generated in the interpreter's mind, shaped by their cultural background, experience, and cognition. Furthermore, he highlighted the dynamic nature of signs, arguing that meaning is formed through an ongoing process of interpretation and reinterpretation, evolving with time and context. Consequently, Peirce's semiotics offers a unique lens for understanding the diversity and flexibility of signs, exerting significant influence across fields like event communication.

3.1.2 Keller's Brand Knowledge Structure Model

Proposed by Kevin Lane Keller, this model posits that the core objective of brand communication is to build strong brand associations and awareness in consumers' minds, thereby enhancing brand equity and competitiveness. In his seminal work *Strategic Brand Management*, Keller elaborates on how brand communication shapes brand image and elevates brand value through diverse communication channels, brand experience, and emotional connections.² He argues that brand building extends beyond advertising and visual identity to encompass intangible elements like consumers' emotional experiences with the brand and their identification with brand values, all of which impact brand loyalty and perception.

3.1.3 Construction and Reproduction of Cultural Meaning

Stuart Hall's encoding/decoding theory posits that cultural communication is not linear but a multi-layered process. Information producers (e.g., event organisers) "encode" specific cultural meanings into content, while audiences "decode" this content based on their cultural backgrounds and personal experiences.³ Consequently, the cultural dissemination of the same event can be interpreted differently by various audience groups, yielding multiple potential responses. This theory underscores the construction and reproduction of meaning in cultural communication, where audience interpretation, contingent on socio-cultural context, shapes how event culture influences and transmits the urban image. Hall further contends that cultural communication involves not merely information transfer, but the active construction and reproduction of meaning. This implies that media and communicators imbue information with specific meanings during dissemination, which audiences subsequently reinterpret and recreate within their own socio-cultural milieus. In sports event communication, media channels (match reports, advertisements, social media) convey event content, urban image, and team culture to audiences. However, audience reception of this cultural content is not solely dependent on the event itself but is profoundly influenced by their social background, cultural identity, and individual experiences.

3.2 *Empirical Methods*

3.2.1 Literature Analysis: Systematically reviewed theories linking sports event communication with urban image construction and integrated case studies of Olympic spirit implementation within sports culture.

3.2.2 Case Study Analysis: Examined the Shanghai Sharks' official promotional videos, home court design, and foreign player strategy to deconstruct the integration of cultural symbols with urban characteristics and identify alignments with the Olympic spirit.

3.2.3 In-depth Interviews: Conducted semi-structured interviews with 6 fans to explore the impact of team culture on urban identity from the fan perspective, while also investigating their perception of Olympic values.

4. Research Findings

4.1 Urban Sound: Shanghainese Dialect Reinforcing Cultural Identity

A 2012 report by the Shanghai Academy of Social Sciences (Latest Survey Report on the Development of Shanghai Primary and Secondary School Students) revealed a decline in the Shanghainese dialect: Mandarin dominated daily usage, with only about 60% of locally-born students fully understanding or speaking Shanghainese.⁴ Twelve years later, this cohort facing a "dialect crisis" has entered society as potential cultural carriers, yet their limited early exposure challenges their role in dialect revitalisation.

Within the basketball sphere, the Shanghai Jiushi Sharks have assumed the mantle of "Shanghainese revival". At their home venue, the Shanghai Indoor Stadium, prominent displays of Shanghainese slang—such as "挺刮" (ting gua, meaning sharp/impressive), "结棍" (jie gun, meaning strong/tough), "模子" (mu zi, meaning role model/tough guy), and "来塞" (lai sai, meaning capable)—adorn the spectator areas. Live commentary incorporates Shanghainese cheers, e.g., "Li Tianrong, mu zi!" (Li Tianrong, good job!) and "吾刚上海，拿刚赞" (We say Shanghai, you say awesome!), fostering audience engagement and immersing younger spectators in a linguistically authentic Shanghainese environment.⁵

The inherent affinity, dynamism, and high communicability of sports events render them effective, permeable, and subtly influential tools for regional image promotion. They enable fans, tourists, and residents to recognise, understand, and ultimately embrace a city, often unconsciously or through a cultivated awareness.⁶ The Sharks' new season promotional video prominently features the voice and image of commentator Wang Yanning. Having called over 400 Sharks games, Wang witnessed the team's founding, promotion, and championship triumph, his voice narrating its growth and resonating with fans' emotional journeys.⁷

Drawing on Mead's Symbolic Interactionism, Shanghainese functions as a potent cultural symbol. Within this framework, it transcends mere language, embodying facets of both Shanghai culture and team identity. During matches, amidst the essential sounds of player communication, ball dribbles, and fan cheers, the recurring Shanghainese dialect triggers potent memories for fans who experienced the championship era, fostering confidence in the current team. For younger fans, the familiar intonation evokes support for their shared local identity ("insiders"), strengthening emotional resonance and allegiance to the team. A core tenet of Symbolic Interactionism is identity formation through interaction.⁸ Players hailing from other regions, seeking identity within Shanghai, experience collective belonging when hearing Shanghainese cheers and encouragement. This fosters a positive emotional interaction rooted in the dialect, motivating them to perform more vigorously for the team and its supporters.

Within the context of globalisation, Olympic culture emphasises "respect for cultural diversity" and promotes mutual learning. The use of Shanghainese in CBA events constitutes a creative response to this ideal. Fans chanting in dialect affirm athletes' pursuit of "excellence", while the intimacy of the vernacular demystifies abstract international values. The dialect's regionally emotive tone embellishes the game, transforming Olympic principles like "fair play" and "teamwork" into tangible emotional narratives that inspire audiences. This "dialect-universal" dual encoding fosters an emotional community in urban sports, transcending language's functional role to become a nexus for constructing urban sports cultural identity. It facilitates the translation of the Olympic spirit from "global consensus" into "local action" offering a vibrant model for the localised innovation of international sports culture.⁹

4.2 Urban Symbols: Visual Design and International Expression

The Sharks' primary colours are orange and blue (navy). The navy blue symbolises the oceanic habitat of sharks, directly referencing the dominant colour scheme of their 2001–2002 championship season. It represents vastness, depth, and power, signifying the team's inclusive and profound nature, bearing a glorious history and honour. The vibrant orange, drawn from the current jersey scheme, symbolises struggle and rejuvenation. It represents energy, passion, and hope, embodying the team's fighting spirit and relentless pursuit of progress and victory on the court.

"What I love most about the arena decor is the home court floor. It's beautiful and distinctly Shanghai" (Interviewee NTH). Respondents highlighted the distinctive home court floor, featuring a shark-tooth pattern demarcating navy blue and vibrant orange halves. This design not only energises players but also creates an intense competitive atmosphere, delivering visual impact and emotional resonance to spectators.¹⁰ This contrasts sharply with earlier CBA courts featuring monotonous colours and simple logos, lacking visual dynamism.¹¹

Beyond court elements reflecting Shanghai-style culture (Haipai Wenhua),¹² off-court events like the team's departure ceremony utilise slogans such as "In the Name of the City, Sharks Towards the Future." This embodies the concept of a shared destiny between the team and the city, showcasing the team's enterprising spirit while reflecting Shanghai's openness, inclusiveness, and innovation as a global metropolis. The new season's promotional video further captures Shanghai's urban essence—its height, speed, and warmth—featuring iconic landmarks, bustling streets, and vibrant citizens as key vectors for disseminating Shanghai-style culture.

Influenced by Shanghai's global stature, the Sharks' "Shark" culture ascends as a bridge for the globalisation and localisation of the Olympic spirit. The orange-blue palette resonates with the dual Olympic cores of inclusive depth and the pursuit of transcendent excellence. The team's cultural narrative, juxtaposing the modernity of Lujiazui with the traditional warmth of alleyways (longtang), showcases urban achievements while conveying Olympic ideals of equality through local charm.

4.3 Urban Culture: Core Spirit and Value Praxis

Shanghai-style culture (Haipai Wenhua), originating in Shanghai, synthesises traditional Chinese elements with modern Western influences, forming a distinctive urban culture with strong regional and contemporary characteristics. Centred on openness, inclusiveness, innovation, and integration, it spans art, literature, fashion, commerce, and more, reflecting Shanghai's unique allure and vitality as a global city. It serves as a vital conduit for Chinese culture on the world stage. Naturally, the shaping and dissemination of urban image and culture necessitate the distillation and presentation of tangible cultural symbols.¹³

The concept of "city image" traces back to Kevin Lynch's 1960 work *The Image of the City*, where "city image" or "public image" denotes the shared

mental impression held by most residents.¹⁴ It possesses objective and subjective dimensions: the objective encompasses a city's historical depth and external manifestations, the latter discernible through the operational decisions of entities like Shanghai Jiushi management.

The team's strategy exemplifies this: Player #14 Li Hongquan was sent to the NBL's (Australia) South East Melbourne Phoenix for training in his rookie CBA year; #1 Li Tianrong was developed at the NBA Global Academy in Australia; Rookie #10 Xie Yongwei spent the previous year at NCAA Division II's Cal Poly Humboldt; #32 Liu Lijia received treatment and training in Spain post-injury. Virtually all young players possess overseas experience. When former Shark Guo Haowen pursued the NBA draft, management demonstrated support rather than fearing talent drain, even covering his medical expenses after an injury setback in the US.

Therefore, Shanghai's policy of "international cultivation + local cultural integration" constructs cultural identity for Generation Z while perpetuating the Olympic pursuit of "excellence". Management's departure from traditional talent-hoarding mentality by supporting overseas training aligns with Gen Z's demand for multicultural exposure and personal development, epitomising Shanghai's "all-embracing" spirit.¹⁵ Narratives of young players' transnational growth concretise Olympic "excellence", resonating emotionally with Gen Z. Secondly, through platforms like Douyin (TikTok), young players share training routines and lifestyles, integrating Olympic values like "perseverance" and "breakthrough" into the digital lives of youth. This fosters intergenerational recognition, reinforcing the universal Olympic value of "transcending oneself". Utilising Shanghai-style culture as a symbol enhances local belonging, transforming sportsmanship into a cultural bridge across generations.¹⁶

5. Discussion and Recommendations

5.1 Lack of Distinctiveness on Neutral Platforms

Interviews revealed that fans primarily consume CBA content via Migu (for live streams) and Hupu (for news). However, as neutral platforms, they suffer from content homogenisation and rigid filtering mechanisms.¹⁷ For instance, the Sharks' charity event for Tibetan children received no Hupu push due to being "non-trending", limiting positive narrative dissemination. Migu broadcasts frequently

feature dead air or ads during breaks, squandering cultural communication opportunities. "Like, NBA broadcasts during timeouts, quarter breaks, or halftime, they skilfully utilise the time for fun mini-games or performances. These segments effectively propagate team culture." (Interviewee YYD). YYD pointed out CBA broadcasts' deficiency compared to the NBA's use of breaks for player stories and fan interaction, resulting in superficial team culture coverage and weakened fan emotional bonds.¹⁸

5.2 Balancing Competitive Performance and Cultural Development

"More people follow the Sharks now because they are winning consistently. Attendance is up. During that phase with almost all losses early on, hardly anyone came to the games." (Interviewee LY). Competitive performance emerged repeatedly as a critical factor influencing cultural communication efficacy. Underperforming teams often deliver less compelling games, diminishing the spectator experience. The CBA's primary focus remains enhancing league competitiveness, expanding commercial sponsorship, and diversifying its product line. Strengthening competition levels and officiating rigor constitutes the core strategy for overall league quality improvement. Teams must undoubtedly enhance their competitiveness, game quality, and player standards to attract viewership.

Conversely, the strategic communication of team culture is equally vital.¹⁹ Relying solely on sporting performance makes sustaining a stable fanbase challenging in the long term. Fan loyalty stems more profoundly from unique team culture, history, and emotional bonds. Therefore, CBA teams should prioritise enhancing fan interaction and communication beyond on-court results. By cultivating relatable, locally resonant team cultures, they can heighten fans' sense of identification and belonging, attracting broader support.

5.3 Strengthening the Praxis of Olympic Values

As a vehicle for urban sports culture, the Shanghai Jiushi Sharks must deepen the localised implementation of Olympic values, realising Olympism's core mission of "promoting the transmission of societal values and the mutual appreciation of global civilizations through sport". The team can collaborate with schools and communities on sports outreach programmes, integrating concepts like "fair play" into youth education. Basketball clinics and rules workshops can instil

Olympic "respect" and "rules awareness". Symbolic interactionism suggests such activities, using concrete symbols (e.g., referee signals, teamwork scenarios), strengthen youth understanding of fair competition, fostering cultural habits across generations. Secondly, leveraging Shanghai's global status and Yao Ming's NBA legacy, the Sharks possess exceptional resources to establish international exchange platforms.²⁰ Hosting transnational friendlies or cultural forums can facilitate bidirectional dialogue between global Olympic values (friendship, excellence) and Shanghai-style culture (openness, inclusivity), achieving cultural fusion and reproduction. Thirdly, promoting pluralism and inclusivity aligns perfectly, as the East-West fusion inherent in Shanghai-style culture resonates strongly with the Olympic ideal of "diversity and inclusion". Keller's model indicates such narratives strengthen fan identification with urban belonging through emotional connections, making sportsmanship a bridge across generations and cultures. Thus, the team can pursue excellence competitively while embedding the Olympic spirit into urban life through cultural praxis, offering a dynamic model for the local innovation of global sports culture.

5.4 Potential Risks to Team Culture

Lawrence A. Wenner, in *Fallen Sports Heroes, Media, and Celebrity Culture*, argues that modern media constructs athletes as societal "heroes" and moral paragons—an idealised and often hypocritical image.²¹ Athletes are imbued with superhuman qualities, setting unrealistic expectations that frequently lead to public disillusionment. Media amplifies athletes' status, making them focal points, yet rapidly exposes and magnifies their failings, triggering swift public condemnation upon missteps.

Similarly, media amplification of team culture is double-edged. During crises, media can magnify cultural vulnerabilities, targeting individual members. Media's broad reach also risks diluting or distorting team culture. Driven by commercial imperatives, content often trends towards entertainment and superficiality, potentially simplifying or warping core cultural values. "As an observing fan, the most direct impression of the Shanghai team is wealth—having ample capital to 'acquire' top foreign players in the market." (Interviewee YSH). Consequently, performance slumps invite labels like "rich but foolish" or "nouveau riche".²²

We can no longer rely on "a single comprehensive description centred around one core principle gathering all phenomena—principle, meaning, spirit,

worldview, total form". Instead, discontinuity and difference, boundaries, ruptures, and transformations increasingly characterise urban image construction and communication.²³

Thus, while media benefits team culture, it also introduces fragmentation, simplification of content, and homogenisation of emotional identification. Teams must judiciously select communication methods, safeguarding cultural depth and diversity. Emphasising sustained fan interaction and emotional connection is crucial to prevent the loss of cultural coherence and continuity due to fragmented media dissemination.

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THE RISE OF WOMEN'S POWER: EXAMINING THE EVOLUTION OF GENDER EQUALITY IN THE OLYMPIC MOVEMENT THROUGH NEWS MEDIA COVERAGE

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Abstract

This paper focuses on exploring the development of gender equality in the Olympic Movement from the perspective of news media coverage. In the early stages of the modern Olympic Games, women's participation was extremely low, and news reports often marginalised them. At the end of the 19th century, when Pierre de Coubertin revived the Olympic Games, women were viewed as spectators, with applause being their "reward". In the 1900 Paris Olympics, women competed for the first time, but they accounted for only 2.2% of the total participants. For many subsequent years, women's events were limited to sports deemed suitable for them, and news coverage of women's sports was scarce. With societal progress, the strength of women continued to rise, and their participation in the Olympic Movement gradually increased. The 2012 London Olympics marked a significant turning point, as women were able to participate in all events for the first time. By the 2024 Paris Olympics, the number of male and female participants was equal, achieving historic gender equality. News media coverage of women's sports also increased, shifting from focusing on athletes' off-field characteristics to emphasising their athletic abilities and achievements. By analysing news media reports from different periods, this paper outlines the development of gender equality in the Olympic Movement, revealing the process of women's transition from being overlooked to being recognised. It also examines the role and impact of news media coverage in promoting gender equality in

the Olympic Movement, providing theoretical references for further advancing gender equality in the field of sports.

1. 1900–1928: The "Ice-Breaking Period" of Women's Olympic Participation and the "Curiosity-Driven Reporting" by Media

The 1900 Paris Olympics marked the beginning of women's participation in the Olympic Games. At that time, women were only allowed to compete in non-contact sports deemed "suitable for female temperament", such as tennis and golf. Participation criteria were vague, and some competitors were even invited spontaneously as spectators. This period was characterised by a sense of "informality" in women's participation. Media coverage of women's involvement in the Olympics had not yet developed a consistent framework, with a core tone centred around "curiosity", portraying female athletes as "exceptions" rather than equal competitors.

Mainstream Western media of the time, such as *The New York Times*, often described women's participation from an "aesthetic perspective". For instance, in its 1900 coverage of women's tennis events, the paper focused on the athletes' attire and appearance ("the elegant combination of white lace skirts and tennis rackets") and their court demeanour ("ladylike strokes avoiding vigorous movements"), with only scant mentions of their performance and skills. This reporting tendency essentially reinforced the contemporary social notion of "female fragility" – the media did not view women's participation as a breakthrough in sports equality but rather as "entertaining embellishments" on the sports stage. By amplifying women's "non-competitive attributes", such coverage diminished their identities as athletes.

Simultaneously, in the 1928 Amsterdam Olympics, women's athletics events were introduced for the first time. When some female athletes showed signs of exhaustion during the 800-meter race, media like the British *Daily Mail* quickly commented that "high-intensity competition causes irreversible harm to women's bodies", and even called for a "re-evaluation of women's suitability for Olympic track and field events". This type of reporting not only failed to acknowledge the women's attempts to push physical limits but also became a "public opinion driver" that led to a reduction in women's track and field events in subsequent Olympic

Games, significantly restricting the early expansion of women's participation in the Olympics.

2. 1928–1960: The "Expansion Period" of Women's Olympic Participation and the "Contradictory Reporting" by Media

With the gradual increase in women's events (such as the introduction of women's gymnastics in the 1928 Amsterdam Olympics and the full reinstatement of women's track and field events in the 1948 London Olympics), women's participation in the Olympics entered a "slow expansion period". The number of female participants grew from dozens to hundreds, and some events began to feature competitive female athletes. Correspondingly, media coverage exhibited a "contradictory" nature: while starting to recognise the athletic value of women, it still struggled to completely break free from traditional gender stereotypes.

On one hand, media attention to the "athletic performance" of female athletes increased significantly. During the 1948 London Olympics, Dutch sprinter Fanny Blankers-Koen won four gold medals, becoming a focal point of the Games. *Sports Illustrated*, for the first time, featured a female athlete on its cover, offering detailed analysis of her starting technique and training methods, and stating that she "proved the potential of women in sprinting with her speed". Such reporting marked the first instance of positioning female athletes as "professional competitors", breaking away from the previous "entertainment-oriented" narrative and garnering greater social recognition for women's participation in the Olympics.

On the other hand, media still struggled to escape the confines of "gendered narratives". Even when covering high-achieving female athletes, reports often included descriptions of their "domestic roles", such as referring to a female athlete as "both a champion on the field and a good wife at home". Coverage of women's team events tended to emphasise "the gentle power of teamwork" rather than the tactics and fighting spirit inherent in competitive sports. After the women's swimming team won gold at the 1960 Rome Olympics, Italian media headlines like "A Group of Elegant Girls Conquer the Pool" continued to highlight "elegance" as the core attribute of female athletes. This reflected the media's lagging gender perceptions—acknowledging women's athletic abilities while still trying to fit them into traditional gender roles.

3. 1961–1981: The "Rights Advocacy Period" of Women's Olympic Participation and Media's "Equality-Promoting Coverage"

After the 1960s, the global women's rights movement gained momentum, marking the beginning of a "Rights Advocacy Period" for women's participation in the Olympics. Female athletes started actively seeking equal opportunities in competitions and a stronger voice in events. The International Olympic Committee (IOC) gradually relaxed restrictions on female participation, such as adding 10 new women's events in the 1972 Munich Olympics. During this period, the media's core function shifted from "passive recording" to "active promotion", becoming a crucial force in advocating for women's Olympic rights.

Media began to systematically address issues related to the "lack of women's Olympic rights", using in-depth reporting to highlight gender inequalities. In 1971, *The Washington Post* published a series titled "The Gender Gap on the Olympic Field", pointing out that women's events comprised only 60% of men's, with certain sports (like weightlifting and boxing) explicitly prohibiting female participation, and noting the absence of female members in the IOC. These reports were among the first to examine women's Olympic participation from a "rights perspective", linking it to the global women's rights movement and sparking widespread public discussion on Olympic gender equality. This directly influenced the IOC's decision to expand women's events in 1972.

Moreover, media used "data comparisons" to reinforce equality demands. After the 1980 Moscow Olympics, several outlets published reports titled "Olympic Gender Participation Data", visually presenting how the proportion of female participants had increased from 0.01% to 23.8% over 80 years, yet disparities in event numbers, prize money, and media exposure persisted. This rational, data-driven reporting provided crucial public support for the IOC's decision to include female members for the first time in 1981, laying the groundwork for institutionalised protection of women's Olympic rights.

In summary, from 1900 to 1981, the progression of women's participation in the Olympics and media coverage formed a "mutually influential, dynamically evolving" relationship. Early "sensationalist reporting" by media restricted breakthroughs in women's Olympic participation. Mid-period "contradictory reporting" reflected societal shifts in gender perceptions. Later, "equality-promoting coverage" became a significant driver in advocating for women's Olympic rights. This interactive process not only mirrors women's gradual overcoming of gender

barriers in sports but also highlights the media's critical role in transforming societal norms.

4. 1981–2012: Comprehensive Advancement of Women's Participation Rights and Media's "Peripheral Reporting"

After Juan Antonio Samaranch became the President of the International Olympic Committee (IOC) in 1981, he systematically promoted women's rights in the Olympics. This era's core was the "comprehensive equalisation under institutional guarantees", ultimately achieving "gender-neutral qualification for participation". Following the feminist movement of the 1970s, women's involvement in the Olympics saw qualitative changes. The 1976 Montreal Olympics marked a significant milestone with the inclusion of women's basketball and handball as official events, prompting media discussions about the equality of physical intensity between male and female athletes.

The 1984 Los Angeles Olympics saw American gymnast Mary Lou Retton win the all-around gold medal, with the media delving into the career planning of female athletes for the first time, rather than merely emphasising their family roles. The 1992 Barcelona Olympics was a pivotal turning point: the proportion of female participants reached 29%, and the strong performances of the Chinese women's swimming team and the American women's track and field team sparked widespread debate. Media began to focus on issues of "gender equality", such as *The New York Times*' special feature discussing "Why Female Athletes Earn Less Than Their Male Counterparts." This marked a shift in reporting from "recording achievements" to "reflecting on institutional inequities". At this stage, the focus was no longer just on equal participation rights but also on equal treatment of athletes in competitions. Media attention on female athletes became more comprehensive, and the liberation of social thought propelled a broader focus in media coverage, contributing indelibly to gender equality in sports.

At the 1996 Atlanta Olympics, the number of events women could participate in surpassed 20 for the first time. Media coverage of female athletes placed greater emphasis on individual stories. For instance, American track athlete Florence Griffith Joyner's fashionable appearance and athletic prowess at the 1988 Olympic Games received equal attention, breaking the stereotype that female athletes needed to be androgynous. By the 2000 Sydney Olympics,

women's participation had risen to 38%, and media began to focus on "mother athletes". Stories like Australian swimmer Leisel Jones' comeback after childbirth challenged the traditional notion that women had to choose between family and sports. The 2008 Beijing Olympics saw media coverage of female athletes encompassing multiple dimensions, including competition, rights, and personal growth, such as an in-depth interview with Taekwondo athlete Wu Jingyu on "breaking gender biases".

By the 2012 London Olympics, the proportion of female participants reached 44%, and every delegation included female athletes. For the first time, media comprehensively used "gender equality" as a reporting framework. The BBC's special feature on "Women's Historic Breakthroughs in the Olympics" combined individual stories with societal progress, marking the shift from women striving for participation rights to pursuing comprehensive equality.

Throughout this period, media coverage evolved from peripheral reporting to focusing on the athletes themselves. This not only reflected the awakening of women's consciousness in the Olympics but also, through narrative changes, pushed society's recognition of women's value to new heights.

5. 2012–Present: The Awakening of Female Consciousness at the Olympics and Media Witnessing

From 2012 to 2024, the awakening of female consciousness on the Olympic stage has become increasingly prominent, with media coverage vividly documenting this process. At the 2012 London Olympics, women's boxing was included for the first time, marking a significant breakthrough in the development of women's sports. This inclusion represented a more comprehensive recognition of women in competitive sports, breaking away from traditional notions that confined women to specific events. Nicola Adams became the first female boxing champion, hailed as a trailblazer in women's boxing. She furthered the anti-sexualisation movement within Olympic sports, proving to the world that women possess exceptional competitive skills in strength-based events. For the first time, female athletes participated in all sports, with every country sending female representatives, and women constituted 44% of the athletes. This statistic highlighted the trend of women moving from the periphery to the centre of the Olympics. Media outlets paid close attention to these changes, extensively covering the outstanding

performances of female athletes. Ye Shiwen, dubbed the “genius girl”, won a swimming championship, and her determination and achievements became a major media focus, inspiring more women to engage in sports.

At the 2016 Rio Olympics, the awakening of female consciousness took on new dimensions. Forty-nine openly LGBT athletes participated, showcasing the inclusivity and diversity of sports. Female athletes made significant strides in self-expression and identity. Fu Yuanhui, known for her candid personality and breaking taboos, garnered much attention. After the 4x100m medley relay, she openly discussed how her period affected her performance, breaking the long-standing taboo surrounding menstruation for female athletes. International media elevated this to a feminist issue, with CNN stating, “Chinese swimmer Fu Yuanhui breaks menstrual taboo and conquers the internet”. Fu Yuanhui quickly became a feminist hero in the eyes of international media. This reflects how media keenly captured women challenging traditional notions and highlights that female athletes not only pursue competitive success but also challenge societal prejudices about female bodies and menstruation.

The 2024 Paris Olympics took the awakening of female consciousness to new heights. Women constituted 50% of the athletes, achieving gender equality in numbers for the first time in the history of the Olympics, a significant milestone. The opening ceremony became a stage to showcase female power and glory, with the emblem boldly incorporating feminine elements, paying tribute to all female athletes. The ceremony featured female equestrians carrying the Olympic rings, female choirs performing national anthems, and statues of notable women in French history, including a politician who drafted the Declaration of the Rights of Woman, a journalist advocating for racial and gender equality, and the first female circumnavigator, rising along the Seine. These scenes, broadcast worldwide, highlighted women’s crucial contributions across various fields of history, greatly inspiring women’s pursuit of equality and freedom. Media extensively covered these unique designs and profound meanings, sparking global discussions on female power and gender equality.

Throughout the 2012-2024 Olympic journey, female consciousness has continually awakened on the Olympic stage, evolving from equal participation in events to freedom of self-expression and the pursuit of comprehensive gender equality. The media has faithfully recorded and disseminated these changes, promoting the development of women’s sports and the progress of social gender equality.

Currently, IOC President Coventry has announced the establishment of two working groups to enhance the future host selection process and protect women's categories. After a "Pause and Reflect" seminar with IOC members in Lausanne, Switzerland, IOC President Kirsty Coventry announced the formation of two working groups to address key priorities of the Olympic Movement. The first group will review the election process for future Summer and Winter Olympic host countries, while the second will focus on protecting women's categories. President Coventry stated,

All members present, as well as those who shared their views before leaving, strongly support the protection of women's categories. Therefore, we will establish a working group composed of experts and international federations. Members agreed that the IOC should play a leading role in this matter, convening experts and international federations to ensure consensus. We understand that there will be differences based on the sport, but we fully agree that as members and the IOC, we should strive to emphasise the protection of women's categories and ensure this is achieved with consensus among all stakeholders.

WINNING THE RINGS: PREPARING TÜRKİYE FOR A SUCCESSFUL 2036 OLYMPIC BID

Berk BILGIN (TUR)

Executive Summary

This paper investigates how Türkiye can prepare a credible and strategically aligned bid for the 2036 Summer Olympic Games by learning from past failures and adapting to the International Olympic Committee's (IOC) evolving expectations. While the previous bids demonstrated strong technical capability, the weaknesses in credibility, public engagement, and legacy planning have hindered success. This project argues that to become a viable host city candidate, İstanbul and Türkiye must reframe their Olympic ambition from prestige-driven infrastructure projects to a legacy-first, inclusive, and transparent model.

The research for this project includes a qualitative methodology that combines and refines literature review, strategic analysis, and comparative benchmarking. It also includes interviews with sports governing officials, media, athletes, and academic researchers. It takes into account IOC policy reforms such as Agenda 2020 and New Norm, where the focus is on sustainability, cost-efficiency, and long-term impact. Case studies from London 2012, Paris 2024, and Los Angeles 2028 are examined to understand how successful hosts integrated legacy planning, stakeholder participation, and innovative governance structures into their own bids. Strategic tools, including SWOT analysis and a logic model, were used to evaluate the current positioning of Türkiye and map pathways for transforming resources into measurable outcomes.

Türkiye, in order to make a successful bid, must include its existing infrastructure, youth demographic, and strategic geopolitical and cultural position while also addressing weaknesses, such as centralised planning, vague legacy

frameworks, and reputational risks. In addition to these findings, the paper proposes a financial strategy that emphasises the reuse of facilities and sustainable investment, alongside a communication strategy that reframes Türkiye's narrative around inclusion, transparency, and youth empowerment.

Ultimately, the study concludes that Türkiye's Olympic aspirations can only succeed if credibility replaces symbolism as the foundation of the bid. The Olympics should be treated not as an end goal, but as a platform for urban renewal, social cohesion, and international trust-building.

Introduction

Hosting any mega-event on a mega scale is quite prestigious. Within those mega-events, the Summer Olympics is the most prestigious opportunity to showcase a host nation's global standing, cultural identity, and urban capacity. Türkiye and İstanbul have been in pursuit of the Olympics since 2000, with multiple bids submitted in which the unique geopolitical position of the city has been emphasised as a bridge between continents along with the city's desire to join the ranks of Olympic hosts. All the bids have been unsuccessful, despite the technical improvements across successive campaigns. Reports and analysts consistently pointed out weaknesses in credibility, limited public participation, and vague legacy commitments as critical factors undermining Türkiye's efforts.

The IOC has undergone a significant transformation in its approach to selecting host cities. With the launch of Agenda 2020 in 2014 and the New Norm in 2018, the IOC shifted its priorities towards sustainability, legacy, human rights, and cost efficiency. This marks a change from an era defined by spectacle and grand construction projects to an era where the successful bids must now align with broader social and environmental values. In the new bidding ecosystem, credibility and long-term impact carry more weight than prestige alone.

This study therefore examines what Türkiye must do to prepare a viable bid for the 2036 Summer Olympics. It argues that Türkiye can no longer rely solely on its infrastructure or cultural symbolism. Instead, it must take a legacy-first approach that emphasises transparency, civic inclusion, and measurable outcomes. In order to come up with some recommendations, a qualitative methodology will be combined with a literature review; strategic tools such as SWOT analysis and

logic modelling will be used; and comparative case studies of recent hosts and bids like London, Paris, and Los Angeles will be examined.

The central thesis of this paper is that Türkiye's Olympic challenge is not one of technical readiness but of credibility. By embedding Olympic values into governance, communication, and long-term planning, Türkiye can transform its Olympic aspirations into a platform for urban renewal, social cohesion, and international trust-building, positioning itself as a credible contender for 2036.

Methodology

The methodology of this study is designed to assess İstanbul's readiness to host the 2036 Summer Olympic Games and to identify strategies for aligning with the evolving IOC expectations. The overall approach integrates a literature review, comparative case analysis, and strategic modelling tools to create a framework that is both analytical and practical.

The foundation of the research process is the literature review. Academic sources on sport mega-events, governance, and urban planning were analysed alongside IOC policy documents. Reports and bid documents from Türkiye's unsuccessful campaigns, particularly İstanbul's 2000 to 2020 submissions, were included to trace patterns of strengths and weaknesses. Media analysis, policy papers, organisational reports from Spor İstanbul and OECD, and interviews with stakeholders in the Turkish Olympic ecosystem were provided as supplementary sources to provide insights into both national capacity and international benchmarks.

Comparative analysis was used to evaluate how successful host cities have been in navigating the IOC's new priorities. London 2012, Paris 2024, and Los Angeles 2028 were selected as case studies because they reflect different yet complementary approaches to legacy planning, community engagement, and cost management. These examples allowed for the identification of transferable best practices and highlighted where Türkiye's bids historically diverged from modern Olympic standards.

A SWOT analysis was used to assess Türkiye's internal strengths and weaknesses in relation to external opportunities and threats. This analysis provided a snapshot of Türkiye's current positioning within the Olympic bid landscape. The logic model then mapped how resources and activities could

be translated into outputs, outcomes, and long-term impacts, emphasising the importance of transparency, measurable legacy, and public trust. The breadth of sources and triangulation of academic, institutional, and media perspectives ensure that the findings are well-grounded and relevant. This methodology provides a comprehensive lens through which Türkiye's Olympic aspirations can be critically evaluated and strategically reframed.

Literature Review and Background Research

For Türkiye, the Olympic dream has been a recurring ambition since the early 1990s, with İstanbul bidding unsuccessfully for the Summer Games in 2000, 2004, 2008, 2012, and 2020. Each attempt reflected progress in technical capability, yet repeated shortcomings in credibility, legacy planning, and civic engagement ultimately undermined success.¹ A review of past Turkish bids, coupled with analysis of the IOC's evolving priorities, provides critical insights into what must change for 2036.

Bidding History

The previous bids emphasised İstanbul's unique geography, branding the city as a bridge between East and West. While compelling, the narrative often lacked operational clarity and was paired with insufficient environmental and risk management planning.² There have been demonstrations of stronger infrastructure proposals from 2008 and 2012 to 2020. The latest unsuccessful bid, in particular, presented the most advanced technical bid, where venue readiness and transport upgrades were highlighted. However, the bid coincided with political turmoil and rising concerns about democratic freedoms, ultimately weakening its credibility.³ These experiences show a recurring pattern: bids that were technically competent but politically and socially unconvincing.

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1. Baş and Delaplace, "Bidding for Olympic and Paralympic Games, a Tool for Transportation Investments and Tourism? The Case of Istanbul."
 2. Gyulai, "Examining Istanbul's Bid to Host the 2020 Olympic Games."
 3. Cavusoglu et al., "İstanbul and Madrid, Candidates to 2020 Olympic Games Lost Out to Host the Games in Terms of Public Relations."

IOC Reforms and New Standards

The IOC's Agenda 2020, adopted in 2014, and the New Norm, introduced in 2018, marked a fundamental redefinition of what constitutes a successful Olympic bid. The emphasis was not on spectacle and large-scale construction. Instead, it was on sustainability, cost-efficiency, and legacy.^{4,5} Additionally, the introduction of Future Host Commissions and the move towards continuous dialogue further reduce the emphasis on competitive bidding wars, instead prioritising alignment with IOC values. The legacy now has a broader meaning, also including social, educational, and environmental transformation, rather than just the reuse of venues. This challenges Türkiye to move beyond symbolic narratives to concrete, measurable commitments.

Urban Politics and Institutional Shortcomings

Research on İstanbul's urban governance highlights some systematic barriers to inclusive Olympic planning. Scholars describe the city's development model as "authoritarian neoliberalism", characterised by rapid, elite-driven projects that are disconnected from what the community actually needs.⁶ Large-scale infrastructure investments, such as bridges and airports, were leveraged in bid narratives but were also criticised for displacing communities and exacerbating inequality. Others also underscore the paradox of İstanbul having the technical capabilities but the processes lacking transparency and participatory structure.⁷ They add that democratic legitimacy and horizontal coordination are now prerequisites for IOC credibility, making institutional reform a critical prerequisite for any future bid.⁸

4. "Olympic Agenda 2020."

5. "Celebrate the Olympic Games - the World's Biggest Sports Event."

6. Kolluoglu and Candan, "Emerging Spaces of Neoliberalism: A Gated Town and a Public Housing Project in Istanbul."

7. Girginov, "Governance of the London 2012 Olympic Games Legacy."

8. Grix and Lee, "Soft Power, Sports Mega-Events and Emerging States: The Lure of the Politics of Attraction."

Legacy and Public Trust

Legacy is no longer a secondary concern to a central bid evaluation criterion. Academics highlight London 2012 as a benchmark, where the London Legacy Development Corporation ensured long-term control of infrastructure and redirected benefits to underserved communities.⁹ Paris 2024 advanced this approach further with its Social Charter, embedding binding communities to employment equity, sustainability, and accessibility.¹⁰

In contrast, İstanbul's bids were vague in legacy, often mentioning tourism boosts and national pride, without mentioning any governance plans to ensure delivery.¹¹ In that sense, public trust and support remain low due to the lack of civic consultation, open polling, or stakeholder inclusion. Recent successful bids and research have shown that citizen support is crucial and is strongest when communities see tangible benefits and are invited into decision-making.¹²

Strategic Implications for Türkiye

Synthesising this research reveals several implications. First, Türkiye must reframe its bid around measurable legacy, sustainability, and inclusivity, rather than prestige. Second, a reform is much needed in urban governance structures to allow civic participation for planning and transparency. Third, communication strategies must address not only domestic scepticism but also international perception, using credible and trusted voices such as athletes, youth leaders, and diaspora communities to articulate a value-based narrative. Finally, the comparative case studies suggest that Türkiye should adopt enforceable mechanisms, such as a national Legacy Charter, to guarantee that commitments translate into long-term outcomes.

Overall, the literature suggests that Türkiye's Olympic dream lies less in

9. Girginov, "Governance of the London 2012 Olympic Games Legacy."

10. Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, "The Paris 2024 Olympic and Paralympic Games: Boosting Local Jobs and Businesses Through a Social Charter."

11. Baş and Delaplace, "Bidding for Olympic and Paralympic Games, a Tool for Transportation Investments and Tourism? The Case of Istanbul."

12. Hiller and Wanner, "Public Opinion in Olympic Cities: From Bidding to Retrospection."

physical capacity than in institutional credibility. The evolving standards of the IOC demand a fundamental recalibration of how Türkiye approaches its Olympic ambitions. By grounding a strategy in legacy, governance, and trust, Türkiye can shift from a historically overlooked candidate to a serious contender for 2036.

Strategic SWOT Analysis

The main strengths of Türkiye are its infrastructure and demographics. İstanbul already hosts Olympic-standard facilities managed by Spor İstanbul, reducing the need for large-scale new constructions. It will also host the 2027 European Games and UEFA EURO 2032. To add to this, its position as a cultural and geographic bridge between Europe and Asia, coupled with a youthful and sport-oriented population, creates a compelling narrative aligned with Olympic values.¹³

Weaknesses, however, remain significant. The top-down planning process of previous bids, low civic involvement, and vague legacy commitments hindered the chance of a successful bid. Democratic backsliding and press freedom concerns have damaged international perceptions of governance credibility.^{14,15} Without binding frameworks for legacy delivery, Türkiye risks repeating these failures.

Opportunities are substantial with the introduction of new bidding selection, the IOC's Agenda 2020, and New Norm reforms, where sustainability, transparency, and cost efficiency are prioritised.^{16,17} By reusing venues, emphasising ecological logistics, and embedding inclusive planning, Türkiye can align itself with these reforms.

There are a couple of threats, starting with other bids from stronger nations like India, Germany, or Qatar. Economic volatility and democratic turmoil, especially surrounding İstanbul, present additional risks, while global media scepticism may amplify domestic controversies.¹⁸

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13. Baş and Delaplace, "Bidding for Olympic and Paralympic Games, a Tool for Transportation Investments and Tourism? The Case of İstanbul."
 14. Cavusoglu et al., "İstanbul and Madrid, Candidates to 2020 Olympic Games Lost Out to Host the Games in Terms of Public Relations."
 15. Gyulai, "Examining İstanbul's Bid to Host the 2020 Olympic Games."
 16. "Olympic Agenda 2020."
 17. "Celebrate the Olympic Games - the World's Biggest Sports Event."
 18. Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, "The Paris 2024 Olympic and Paralympic Games: Boosting Local Jobs and Businesses Through a Social Charter."

Overall, Türkiye possesses strong assets but must address credibility and governance weaknesses and capitalise on the new opportunities that the IOC provides to create a competitive advantage as well as a strong narrative for its Olympic ambitions.

Logic Model

It is vital to understand and map how Türkiye can transform its resources into a long-term Olympic legacy. In this case, the inputs include existing venues, government agencies, municipal authorities, and civic organisations. Activities would involve drafting a National Legacy Charter, conducting community consultations, piloting sustainable infrastructure projects, and organising regional sport festivals. These activities would generate outputs such as transparent bid dossiers, signed partnership agreements, youth engagement metrics, and international media campaigns.

The outcomes of these inputs and activities would include strengthened public trust, improved global perception, and IOC confidence in Türkiye's governance capability. Most importantly, the long-term impact would be systematic: integrated urban development, institutional reforms, and enhanced global branding of Türkiye as a credible, inclusive, and sustainable Olympic host.

Financial Considerations

Cost-effectiveness is another aspect that Türkiye must consider to enhance its bid's credibility. Unlike past bids, the bid for 2036 must emphasise long-term return on investment. By leveraging existing infrastructure and embedding urban areas for games, Türkiye can minimise construction costs while meeting IOC requirements.¹⁹

Sponsorships and tourism are also major revenue streams. Importantly, all investments should have public needs, such as transport and housing, in mind post-games. "White elephant" projects must be avoided to prevent financial backlash and ensure that Olympic investments generate everlasting civic and economic benefits.

19. Spor İstanbul, "Spor İstanbul."

Communication Strategy

Past Turkish bids relied heavily on prestige and nationalism. Today's IOC values transparency, inclusion, and legacy-focused narratives.²⁰ The communication strategy must therefore shift toward messaging that emphasises sustainability, youth empowerment, and civic participation. Trusted voices, such as Olympians, Paralympians, youth leaders, and diaspora representatives, should serve as ambassadors. Multichannel outreach is essential, combining bilingual digital platforms, social media storytelling, and athlete-driven campaigns with grassroots engagement through town halls and school programmes.²¹

Transparency tools, such as online dashboards and public polling, should be developed to reinforce accountability. Internationally, Türkiye must court journalists and NGOs through regular briefings and data-driven progress updates. Domestically, inclusive campaigns should be managed to build civic ownership and enthusiasm. The shift of narrative from state prestige to people-centred legacy can reposition Türkiye as a credible and modern Olympic candidate.

Key Performance Indicators and Return on Objectives

Establishing clear Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) is essential to measuring Türkiye's progress toward IOC expectations of credibility, sustainability, and inclusivity. Public support is a critical KPI that can be monitored through surveys, youth participation rates, and turnout at Olympic-themed events. Stakeholder engagement can be tracked by the number and diversity of Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs) with sport federations, NGOs, and academic partners, as well as the creation of interagency task forces. Communication-related KPIs include international media sentiment, social media reach, and engagement metrics. Infrastructure readiness indicators involve the percentage of venues that are IOC-compliant and sustainability-certified, while governance KPIs include transparency dashboards, milestone reporting, and independent oversight audits.

Return on Objectives (ROO) evaluates whether these metrics serve the intended purpose and deliver the planned strategic outcomes. Improving Türkiye's international image is one that could be measured through favourable media

20. "Celebrate the Olympic Games - the World's Biggest Sports Event."

21. Gyulai, "Examining Istanbul's Bid to Host the 2020 Olympic Games."

coverage and endorsements from sports institutions. A second is strengthening domestic legitimacy by demonstrating inclusive governance, reflected in stakeholder diversity and civic trust. Another objective is ensuring a long-term legacy, measured through post-Games venue use, integration of Olympic values into education, and youth sport participation. Finally, institutional continuity is vital: the creation of permanent legacy councils and youth sport foundations would reflect sustainable and everlasting structural change.

Together, these KPIs and ROOs ensure that Türkiye's Olympic project is not evaluated solely by hosting success but by its ability to create measurable, lasting transformation.

Conclusion

Türkiye's ambition to host the 2036 Summer Olympic Games represents both a challenge and an opportunity. While previous bids demonstrated strong infrastructure and enthusiasm, they fell short due to limited civic participation, vague legacy commitments, and questions of governance credibility. At the same time, the International Olympic Committee has transformed its expectations, prioritising sustainability, inclusion, and measurable long-term impact over spectacle and prestige.

This study shows that Türkiye's path forward must be grounded in a legacy-first, transparent, and people-centred approach. By leveraging existing infrastructure, engaging diverse stakeholders, and embedding Olympic values into national policy frameworks, Türkiye can align itself with IOC reforms. Clear KPIs and measurable objectives, ranging from public trust to post-Games legacy, are essential to ensuring accountability.

Ultimately, Türkiye's Olympic challenge is not one of technical capacity but of credibility. If reimagined strategically, a 2036 bid could serve as a catalyst for urban renewal, civic inclusion, and international trust, positioning Türkiye not only as a credible contender but also as a model for the modern Olympic Games.

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BRAZILIAN MEDIA COVERAGE, OLYMPIANS, RULE 50.2 AND ACTIVISM

Clarisse SILVA CAETANO (BRA)

Introduction

Over the years, the International Olympic Committee (IOC), to maintain the stability of its governance, has sought to consolidate its philosophical message of peace based on universal values, and the protection of its political neutrality.¹ To protect political neutrality, the IOC created specific rules, one of the most important being Rule 50 of the Olympic Charter which was introduced in the 1970s.^{2,3}

Protests and political manifestations are rare but not new. They are carried out by Olympians from all parts of the world for a wide variety of reasons. But what makes the Olympic Games a particularly interesting venue for such demonstrations? One of the answers is that intense media coverage is an integral part of the largest multi-sport and multicultural event in the world, and so Olympic venues have become a great stage for the visibility of various agendas.⁴

Athletes exist in a political environment and, as citizens, they are connected to local, national, and global issues that impact their own lives and social relationships.⁵ As a collective, Olympians were first represented as an IOC Commission in 1981, formed by IOC members who were former athletes. Later,

1. Seltmann. *Disrupting institutional reproduction? How Olympic athletes challenge the stability of the Olympic Movement*, p. 10.
2. Elsborg. *A Fist of Freedom or a Fist of Iron? Rule 50 and the Olympic Paradox*. p. 44.
3. Rule 50 states that no demonstrations involving political, religious, or racial propaganda are allowed at Olympic areas.
4. Kaufman; Wolff. *Playing and Protesting: Sport as a Vehicle for Social Change*. pp. 154-175.
5. Fisher; Butryn; Roper. *Diversifying (and politicizing) sport psychology through cultural studies*, pp. 391-405.

in 1994, elections were introduced to choose representative participants in the Athletes' Commission. Those athletes integrate a worldwide network, which is an important agency in making their voices heard in the IOC.⁶

In 2020, based on a consultation promoted by the Athletes' Commission, the IOC sought to reconcile the idea of athletes' freedom of expression and the protection of the institution's alleged political neutrality. As a result, Rule 50.2 was presented. It establishes possible expressions when athletes are responding to interviews, using social media, and when being introduced immediately before competitions.^{7,8}

Yet, the guidelines of Rule 50.2 include that "the Rule is also aimed at protecting participants from potential consequences of being placed in a position where they may be forced to take a public position on a particular domestic or international issue regardless of their beliefs."⁹ Thus, at the same time Olympic athletes enjoy symbolic capital empowered by the magnitude of the Olympic Movement, the attention they receive may also represent pressure in terms of social accountability.¹⁰

In this study, activism is understood as a political communicative process, a complex matrix of resistance, articulated with collective identities, power and agencies.¹¹ Thus, the research aims to analyse Brazilian media coverage of athletes' activism during the Tokyo 2020 and Paris 2024 Olympic Games, with particular attention paid to compliance with the IOC's Rule 50.2 guidelines.

Methodology

This qualitative study investigates the phenomenon of athletes' activism within the

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6. Chappelet. *The unstoppable rise of athlete power in the Olympic system*. Sport in Society, pp. 795-809.
 7. The rule also states that athletes may not refer to governments or individuals or create disturbing situations, respecting anthems, ceremonies, etc.
 8. According to this rule, athletes could not protest during ceremonies, on the field of competition, nor on the Olympic Village.
 9. International Olympic Committee, *Rule 50.2 Guidelines*, p. 2.
 10. Hartmann. *Activism, Organizing, and the Symbolic Power of Sport*, pp. 181-194.
 11. Medina. *The epistemology of protest: Silencing, epistemic activism, and the communicative life of resistance*. Oxford University Press.

Olympic scenario by employing netnography as the primary research technique.¹² Data were collected from Brazilian media coverage of the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games, from July 23 to August 8, 2021, and the Paris 2024 Olympic Games, from July 26 to August 11, 2024. To retrieve data, searches were performed on www.google.com using the “News” filter, within the defined period, and using three different combinations of descriptors (Brazilian Portuguese): “athlete AND protest”; “athlete AND activism”; “athlete AND rule 50.2”.

Given the extensive coverage of certain protests, the first five news stories of each protest were selected for analysis (when five were available). By filtering the results, six distinct episodes of athletes’ activisms that violated IOC Rule 50.2 were identified at the Tokyo Games, and five at the Paris 2024 Games. For each Olympic edition, we catalogued news about athletes’ activisms, specifically those flagged as violations of Rule 50.2.¹³

Data analysis was guided by critical sports studies, with a particular focus on cultural approaches to sport and media. These perspectives have established an epistemological legacy grounded in critical inquiry and debate on the multiple cultural processes involved in the global phenomenon of mega sporting events, especially in relation to gender, race, and power.¹⁴

Results and Discussions

Among the protest strategies observed during the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games, a break from traditional sportswear norms was an example. The German women’s gymnastics team wore full-body suits during the qualifying competitions on July 23. Twelve articles covering this event were identified.

According to the athletes’ later interviews, the protest was intended to fight against the sexualisation of women’s bodies in sport. The episode, published by the website G1 emphasised that the sport has faced recurrent cases of sexual and

12. Netnography is a qualitative method that analyses online content as meaningful data to understand social paradigms and cybercultural practices, by systematically collecting and interpreting digital sources (Bartl, et al., 2016).

13. The following information was documented: the description of the protest, the athlete’s name and nationality, the date, photographs, contextual details, and links to the original media vehicle. The link (URL) of each news article was recorded, and the corresponding web pages were saved as PDF files for later analysis.

14. Cleland, Dixon, & Kilvington. *Online research methods in sport studies*. Routledge.

physical abuse in recent years. By performing in full-body suits, these athletes politicised women's bodies and asserted their rights in resisting inequalities and oppression.^{15,16}

Another instance of athlete protest through clothing was carried out by Azerbaijani women gymnasts. They wore all-black uniforms in rhythmic gymnastics, which symbolised mourning. Two news sites reported on the demonstration. Both stated that, by wearing these uniforms, the athletes were protesting violent conflicts in their country and, by extension, opposing governmental actions. According to the news outlet *Lance!* the conflicts stem from territorial disputes between Azerbaijan and Armenia. Although the article does not mention Rule 50.2, this regulation prohibits athletes from making explicit or direct references to governments or political subjects during the Games. The Olympic Games serve as a nexus for global geopolitical issues and struggles.¹⁷

Luciana Alvarado, the first Costa Rican gymnast to compete in the Olympics, knelt and raised a clenched fist at the end of her floor routine in Tokyo, a gesture associated with the Black Lives Matter movement which protests racism. Only two websites published exclusive articles on the subject, both highlighting her gesture as a symbol of support for anti-racist movements, which gained global momentum following the death of George Floyd in 2020. The articles did not address IOC Rule 50.2 or discuss potential sanctions for the athlete, but they did highlight Luciana's statement. She said: "It's important that everyone is treated with respect and dignity, and that everyone has the same rights."¹⁸

Another athlete who violated the rule was 25-year-old Raven Saunders, a shot-put competitor from the USA. During the podium ceremony, she raised her arms and crossed her forearms above her head, forming an "X" shape. She won a silver medal on that occasion. In interviews, Saunders explained that the gesture was meant to represent all oppressed people referencing the various communities

15. G1. July 23, 2021. *Ginastas alemãs marcam posição com uniformes que cobrem todo corpo em Tóquio*, unpagued.

16. Haraway. 'Gênero' para um dicionário marxista: a política sexual de uma palavra", p. 201.

17. LANCE! (news website). *Ginástica rítmica: na disputa por equipes, atletas do Azerbaijão usam preto pelo conflito no país*, unpagued.

18. G1 (news website). July 26 2021. *Ginasta da Costa Rica faz gesto do 'Black Lives Matter' ao competir em Tóquio*, unpagued.

she identifies with: Black, lesbian, and low income. She stated that the “X” symbolised “the intersection of where all people who are oppressed meet”.¹⁹

Over 200 news outlets reported on Raven Saunders’ protest in Brazilian media coverage. While the narratives emphasised the gesture’s significance, they also raised questions about possible penalties. No other protest at Tokyo 2020 received as much attention from the Brazilian media. The protest, which took place during such a solemn moment as the medal ceremony, violated Rule 50.2.

Paulinho, a Brazilian national soccer player, celebrated a goal at the Tokyo Olympics with a gesture mimicking placing an arrow on his back, in reference to an orixá. Orixás are deities in Candomblé and Umbanda, two Afro-Brazilian religions. Rule 50.2 underscores the requirement to comply with the Olympic Charter, which prohibits religious propaganda at Olympic venues.

Ten websites published articles about the meaning and significance of Paulinho’s religious-themed celebration, none of which mentioned Rule 50.2. Media coverage supported the athlete’s religious rights and drew parallels with common Christian celebrations at soccer matches. This is reflected in CNN Brazil’s headline: “Paulinho, an athlete of Exu, uses the ball to pay respect after scoring his first goal.”²⁰

Raven Saunders is not the only athlete to incorporate a political demonstration into the medal ceremony. Chinese cyclists Bao Shanju and Zhong Tianshi wore pins bearing the image of Mao Zedong when they received their gold medals on the podium in Tokyo. Two Brazilian news articles reporting on the episode were found. Mao Zedong led the communist movement in China in the late 1920s and headed the country’s communist government from 1949 until his death in 1976. There was media coverage of the cyclists’ use of Mao Zedong pins on the Olympic podium. The BBC further noted that Mao’s legacy is still deeply embedded in Chinese education, culture, and film. As a result, some people referred to the cyclists as “the national warriors” of today.

Interestingly, among the 1,950 Olympic athletes who responded to an online survey conducted by the IOC Athletes’ Commission in 2020 on the topic of athlete expression, most respondents were from China (14% of 185 participating

19. Morse. CNN Brasil (news website) August 2 2021. *O que significa gesto de norte-americana no pódio e por que o COI investiga*, unpagued.

20. Iamin. CNN Brasil (news website). July 24, 2021. *Paulinho, atleta de Exu, usa bola para plantar respeito depois de gol na estreia*, unpagued.

countries).²¹ Among the Chinese Olympic athletes who participated, only 1% considered the podium an appropriate place to express their opinions, and 2% approved of displaying a political message on a badge or clothing.²² This reflects a conservative approach to the issue. This questionnaire provides little data on the views of Brazilian athletes, and thus it is important to further explore their perceptions.

Brazilian media covered the athletes' activism at the Paris 2024 Games using different approaches depending on each athlete's message. The first athlete demonstration to gain traction in the Brazilian media during the Paris 2024 Olympic Games was carried out by the Algerian delegation, who threw roses into the Seine during the opening ceremony (26 July). The act paid tribute to the Algerian victims of a 1961 massacre in France, whose bodies were thrown into the river. Three news articles covered the demonstration.

In that case, the form of protest involved a break of protocol, as reported by G1, which emphasised that the Algerian athletes "circumvented protocol" to pay tribute to the victims of the massacre. Protocol elements are a central, and often rigid, component of Olympic events.²³ It is important to note that the statement made by the Algerian delegation is linked to issues capable of unsettling both governments and public opinion, thus falling outside the boundaries of what is considered acceptable under Rule 50.2.

Another demonstration with geopolitical tone was carried out by Marcelat Sakobi, an athlete from the Democratic Republic of Congo. Eighteen articles and reports in the Brazilian media highlighted that, after her defeat in the Olympic boxing semifinals, she gestured by covering her mouth with one hand and mimicking a gun to her head with the other.

According to O Antagonista, the motivation behind Sakobi's gesture was: "The movement symbolised her denunciation of the violence and genocide occurring in her homeland."²⁴ Another excerpt stated: "Athletes use their platforms to draw attention to neglected conflicts" (Boxeadora protesta, 2024). By performing this gesture outside the bounds permitted by Rule 50.2, she not

21. International Olympic Committee, *Athlete Expression Consultation*, p. 4.

22. International Olympic Committee, *Athlete Expression Consultation*, p. 43.

23. G1. (2024, July 27). *Flores no Rio Sena: entenda a homenagem feita por argelinos durante cerimônia de abertura das Olimpíadas*. G1 Mundo.

24. O Antagonista. (2024, August 1). *Boxeadora protesta nas Olimpíadas contra genocídio no Congo*.

only expressed a political stance but also challenged the IOC's prescribed limits on athlete expression.

In addition to issues related to geopolitical conflicts, athletes have also spoken out in support of civil rights. Kimia Yousofi, from Afghanistan, was featured in 11 Brazilian news outlets for her demonstration, in which she proclaimed a message that resonated widely in the media as she crossed the finish line in the preliminary round of the 100-meter track and field event: "Education, sports, our rights." The website SBT News²⁵ addressed the tense political situation in the sprinter's home country and emphasised: "Under the Taliban rule, Afghanistan is the most repressive country in the world regarding women's rights, according to the United Nations."²⁶

The news coverage demonstrates that civil rights, which are regarded as universal, are not upheld in all countries. Kimia's protest not only highlights the rights denied to Afghan women but also illustrates broader issues related to multiculturalism and universal values promoted by the Olympic Movement.

In addition to the sprinter, breakdancer Manizha Talash, representing the Refugee Athletes team, also engaged in a civil rights demonstration. During her performance, Talash wore a cape inscribed with "Free Afghan Women" as part of her costume. Her subsequent disqualification sparked discussion in 18 news articles.

The news portal GE reported: "Political slogans and statements are banned in performances and on podiums at the Olympic Games, and the sport's governing body announced after the performance that the 21-year-old athlete had been disqualified."²⁷ Notably, no athletes involved in similar demonstrations faced disqualification, even though the other statements analysed in this study also fell outside the scope of Rule 50.2.

There were also religious expressions at Paris 2024, such as that of Brazilian

25. SBT News. (2024, August 5). *Atleta afegã Kimia Yousofi manda mensagem ao Talibã na Olimpíada de Paris: "nossos direitos"*. SBT News.

26. SBT News. (2024, August 5). *Atleta afegã Kimia Yousofi manda mensagem ao Talibã na Olimpíada de Paris: "nossos direitos"*. SBT News The radical Islamic group has closed girls' schools, banned women from attending universities and working in non-governmental organizations, restricted their travel, and prohibited them from accessing public spaces.

27. GE. (2024, August 10). *Atleta refugiada afegã é desqualificada das Olimpíadas por slogan em capa no breaking* Globo Esporte.

athlete Rayssa Leal. She used Brazilian Sign Language to convey a Christian message during her introduction in the skateboarding final, pointing to the camera and signing: “Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life.” The athlete’s public declaration of faith was the most discussed episode on Brazilian news portals, with a total of 99 publications. The media not only reported on the possibility of IOC sanctions but also expressed support for her gesture and emphasised the importance of Brazilian Sign Language, representing the deaf people community in the country.

The public’s acceptance of Rayssa Leal’s religious demonstration is highlighted in the article from Goal website, which points out that “the gesture was widely recognised as an act of inclusion and faith, increasing the support and admiration of her fans and followers” (Goal, 2024).²⁸ Religious expressions are common in sport in general, whether in a goal celebration where the athlete points to the sky or in making the sign of the cross when entering the field, and such gestures usually do not surprise the public.

The authors Kaufman and Wolff (2010) explored the relationship between sport and activism, arguing that: “The connection between sport and activism is by no means self-evident, obvious or even accepted. Sport does not necessarily enhance a person’s moral or ethical judgement but may even weaken these qualities” (p. 159).²⁹

Thus, societal changes and the relaxation of Rule 50 have set a precedent for athletes to use competition as a space for protest and activism in support of causes they consider important. This aspect has been evident since the Tokyo 2020 Games (held in 2021), which were characterised by numerous athlete-led protests. At this historical moment, the figure of the politically engaged athlete is gaining prominence through acts of protest and contributing to what is referred to as sports activism. Sports activism is amplified by the rise of social media, which has brought athletes closer to public concerns.

Conclusions

Olympians employed different strategies to voice their protest and/or draw

28. Goal. (2024, August 10). *Qual o significado do sinal em Libras de Rayssa Leal nas Olimpíadas de Paris 2024?* Goal Brasil.

29. Kaufman; Wolff. *Playing and Protesting: Sport as a Vehicle for Social Change*. p. 159.

attention to their agendas. They were treated differently by Brazilian media coverage in references to Rule 50.2 and possible sanctions. Brazilian media endorsed Paulinho's religious celebration as a fight for religious tolerance, while Raven Saunders received widespread attention, including calls for punishment; Manizha Talash and Kimia Yousofi highlighted political and human rights issues; Marcelat Sakobi was associated with the conflicts in her country; the Algerian delegation's actions were historically contextualised; and Rayssa Leal's religious expression sparked debate about possible IOC sanctions.

Media plays a structural role in the dissemination and interpretation of mega sporting events such as the Olympic Games (Billings, 2008).³⁰ Most people access elite sports through media rather than in person. This means that media influences people's understanding of sports, of how they conceive athletes as social actors, and how they interpret narratives associated with symbols and values that contribute to constructing a global social imaginary (Maguire, 2011).³¹

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31. Maguire. *The global media sports complex: Key issues and concerns*. *Sport in Society: Cultures, Commerce, Media, Politics*, 14(7–8), 965–977.

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LEVERAGING OLYMPIC VALUES TO PROMOTE PHYSICAL ACTIVITY AND MENTAL WELL-BEING IN YOUTH

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Introduction

Regular physical activity (PA) is universally recognised as a cornerstone of adolescent health and development. During adolescence, when physical, psychological, and social transitions are at their peak, establishing healthy behaviours becomes critical for lifelong well-being. Extensive research highlights the role of PA in promoting cardiometabolic health, musculoskeletal strength, maintaining a healthy body composition, and reducing non-communicable diseases (NCDs) later in life.¹ Beyond physiological benefits, PA is closely linked to improved cognitive function, improved mood, reduced symptoms of anxiety and depression, and better academic performance.^{2,3,4,5}

Current guidelines by The World Health Organization (WHO) recommend

1. WHO. *Global recommendations on physical activity for health*. Geneva: World Health Organization, 2010.
2. Biddle S. J. H., Asare M. Physical activity and mental health in children and adolescents: a review of reviews. *Br J Sports Med*. 2011.
3. Eime R. M., et al. The health benefits of different sport disciplines. *BMC Public Health*. 2013.
4. Lubans D. R., et al. The effects of physical activity on mental health outcomes in youth: review. *Prev Med*. 2016.
5. Spruit A., et al. Sports participation and psychosocial outcomes in children. *J Youth Adolesc*. 2019.

that children and adolescents engage in an average of at least 60 minutes of moderate-to-vigorous physical activity (MVPA) per day, spread across the week, with targeting muscle and bone strengthening activities at least three days per week.⁶ Yet despite the robust evidence supporting these guidelines, global compliance remains low.⁷ In many regions, fewer than 20% of adolescents achieve the recommended daily activity levels. A parallel concern is the rise of sedentary behaviours, particularly prolonged screen time, which has become a defining feature of adolescent lifestyles worldwide. Excessive sedentary behaviour is linked to negative outcomes such as poor metabolic health, lower fitness, reduced sleep quality, and impaired psychosocial well-being.⁸

Within this landscape, the Olympic Values Education Programme (OVEP) offers a structured, school-based, ready framework grounded in the values of excellence, respect, and friendship. OVEP's toolkit provides lesson plans that pair movement with cooperative tasks and guided reflection, aiming to develop life skills and social behaviours alongside physical literacy. This aligns with Positive Youth Development (PYD) evidence indicating that intentionally designed sport experiences cultivate the "4Cs/5Cs" (competence, confidence, connection, character/caring) and transferable life skills linked to well-being.^{9,10}

Saudi Arabia illustrates both the urgency and the opportunity for adopting such a values-based, school-anchored approach. National statistics highlight a concerning trend of low physical activity among children and adolescents. In 2024, only 18.7% of children and adolescents (5–17 years) achieved the recommended 60 minutes of daily MVPA, while 35.3% reported spending more than three hours per day of sedentary time outside school hours. Gender disparities are notable: earlier school-based surveys in major cities found that around half of boys and three-quarters of girls failed to meet the 60-minute

6. WHO. Guidelines on physical activity, sedentary behaviour and sleep for children and adolescents. 2020.
7. Guthold R., et al. Global trends in insufficient physical activity among adolescents. *Lancet Child Adolesc Health*. 2020.
8. Tremblay M.S., et al. Sedentary behaviour research network: terminology consensus. *Appl Physiol Nutr Metab*. 2017
9. International Olympic Committee. Olympic Values Education Programme Toolkit. 2016.
10. Holt N. L., Neely K. C. Positive youth development through sport: a review. *Rev Iberoam Psicol Ejerc Deporte*. 2011.

PA guidelines. Moreover, more than 84% of adolescents reported screen time exceeding two hours per day. In contrast, adult participation in PA has been rising under Vision 2030 initiatives,^{11,12,13} underscoring a generational divide that must be addressed if national health goals are to be met.

At the policy level, Saudi Arabia has set ambitious targets under Vision 2030, aiming to raise overall physical activity participation to approximately 40% of the population by the end of the decade. Schools are central to this mission, with initiatives such as the Saudi Sports for All Federation's "School on the Move" already working to incorporate structured movement into classrooms nationwide. The IOC's delivery of OVEP projects and educator training in the Kingdom in April 2025 demonstrates both feasibility and momentum for embedding Olympic values into Saudi educational practice. Leveraging OVEP aligns with both the best global practice and national strategic goals.

Recognising that this requires a phased approach, this study proposed two initial steps:

- A cross-sectional survey to map adolescents' current physical activity levels, sedentary behaviours, mental well-being, and perceptions of Olympic values.
- A pilot intervention in selected schools to test the feasibility and acceptability of OVEP-inspired activities embedded within regular physical education classes.

Together, these steps will provide foundational evidence for whether a school-based programme integrating Olympic values into active, cooperative sessions can enhance adolescents' physical activity and mental well-being and whether such effects are mediated by psychosocial factors linked to positive youth development, such as belonging, respect, and self-efficacy.¹⁴

11. Vision 2030. Quality of Life Program. Saudi Arabia, 2020.

12. Al-Hazzaa, H. M., Abahussain, N. A., Al-Sobayel, H. I., Qahwaji, D. M., & Musaiger, A. O. (2011). Physical activity, sedentary behaviors and dietary habits among Saudi adolescents relative to age, gender and region. *International Journal of Behavioral Nutrition and Physical Activity*, 8(1), 140. <https://doi.org/10.1186/1479-5868-8-140>

13. Alqahtani, M. A., Alsubaie, A. S., & Alqahtani, A. S. (2021). Physical activity and sedentary behaviors among Saudi adolescents: A cross-sectional study. *BMC Public Health*, 21(1), 1924. <https://doi.org/10.1186/s12889-021-12014-7>

14. Binder D. Teaching Olympism in schools. *Educ Res*. 2005.

Study Rationale and Objectives

The rationale for this study rests on three pillars:

1. Health urgency: Low PA levels and high sedentary time among Saudi adolescents pose significant risks to long-term health and well-being.
2. Policy alignment: Vision 2030 emphasises PA promotion as a national priority, and schools are strategically positioned to contribute to this agenda.
3. Evidence gap: while OVEP has been implemented in various global contexts, there is limited empirical evidence on its feasibility, cultural adaptability, and effectiveness in the Gulf region.

Study Objectives:

1. To assess physical activity levels, sedentary behaviours, and mental well-being among Saudi adolescents in grades 7–10.
2. To explore perceptions of Olympic values (excellence, respect, friendship) and their associations with PA behaviours and psychosocial outcomes.
3. To implement a pilot OVEP-inspired programme in selected schools and evaluate its feasibility, acceptability, and preliminary outcomes.
4. To generate evidence for scaling up values-based PA interventions in alignment with Vision 2030 health and education goals.

Methodology

A mixed-methods, school-based, cross-sectional study will be conducted across selected boys' and girls' schools. To complement the survey, one school from each group will be invited to implement a short pilot programme using adaptive OVEP activities (e.g., cooperative games, guided reflections) during regular physical education classes.

Participants

Eligible participants are students in grades 7–10, reflecting the age group most at risk for declining physical activity and increasing sedentary time. Inclusion criteria

are enrolment in a participating class, medical clearance for regular school-based activity, and provision of informed consent by parents alongside student assent.

Data Collection Procedures

- **Survey:** structured questionnaire will be distributed in class, capturing demographic (age, gender, BMI), Physical activity and sedentary behaviours (using a validated short instrument such as PAQ-A or GPAQ-A), Mental well-being (WHO-5 scale or equivalent), Perceptions of Olympic values (respect, excellence, friendship), and their relation to daily activity.
- **Pilot Classes:** In 1–2 selected schools, the PE teacher will deliver a small set of OVEP-inspired activities. Students in these classes will complete additional short reflection forms and provide feedback on enjoyment, feasibility, and perceived impact.

Ethical Considerations

Approval will be sought from the relevant Institutional Review Board (IRBs) and the Ministry of Education. Informed parental consent and student assent will be mandatory. Confidentiality will be maintained, and data will be anonymised.

Outcome

The survey will provide descriptive statistics on physical activity levels, sedentary time, and well-being indicators, as well as correlations with value-based perceptions. The pilot will yield process outcomes, including acceptability (student engagement, teacher feedback) and feasibility (time demands, cultural fit).

THE POLITICS OF SPORT AND THE SPORT OF POLITICS FACTORS THAT INFLUENCE AUSTRALIAN POLITICIANS TO ENGAGE IN PHYSICAL ACTIVITY POLICY DEVELOPMENT

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Introduction

Physical activity (PA) improves physical and mental health and has significant economic benefits for individuals and communities (Mizdarak et al., 2021). However, mass participation rates remain stubbornly low. PA policy development has been identified as a key mechanism for increasing population levels of PA which has led to over 80% of countries around the world developing some form of national PA strategy (Whiting et al., 2025). Australia remains one of the minority of countries without a national PA action plan despite over 30 years of advocacy to encourage such policy development. Subnational (State Government) efforts to develop PA policies have been instigated across various sectors including sport, with limited success.

PA policy research has traditionally concentrated on recommended components of national PA policies (Bull et al., 2014). Less attention has focused on the PA policy development process to interrogate why recommended evidence-informed policies have (or have not) emerged (Noel-Racine et al., 2020). Bureaucrats translating research evidence to PA policies for consideration by elected leaders and the PA-related policy preferences of politicians require further investigation.

In stark contrast to their usual indifference to PA policy development

priorities, politicians hosting Olympic and Paralympic Games have traditionally become more engaged in potential sport and PA policy development opportunities as part of Olympic Games preparations. Increasing PA, sport and active recreation legacy benefits are often presented by host governments to garner community support to host the games. These benefits have also been the basis for sport development and PA policy more generally in many developed countries including Australia. However, legacy expectations of the community and sport and active recreation sectors are often not met, creating potential community disquiet (Herold et al., 2025).

A significant body of evidence has been compiled regarding sports participation legacies from the Olympic Games. Case studies from Sydney (2000), London (2012) and Rio (2016) demonstrate that sport participation legacies are only achieved if host Governments engage the community, develop long-term strategies and coordinate efforts between Government agencies (Harris and Dowling, 2022). Increased community participation in sport and more recently PA, has been included in all 21st Century Olympic and Paralympic Games legacy packages that government bodies have prepared to garner support for hosting the mega-event (Reis et al., 2017). Hosting the Games however, has not been demonstrated by itself to increase population-wide levels of physical activity (Bauman et al., 2021).

Politicians generally favour hosting mega sports events despite discouraging evidence of limited financial benefits or direct economic gain and even potential community resistance (de Nooij and Van den Berg, 2017). Konecke and de Nooij (2022) highlighted some of the unique characteristics of mega sporting events that may entice politicians to bid for Olympic Games. Among other things, the authors note a politician's involvement in a mega sporting bid will assist them to create and strengthen different types of networks. Supporting and promoting a bid can therefore enable a politician to win fans of sport organisations as voters. Furthermore, the politician obtains access to the networks' sport officials and sport organisations. The established societal networks of sporting organisations thereby elicit potential interest and perceived value from politicians, well beyond those that PA advocates would usually be able to promote.

Sport versus PA

Due to the diverse use of the term “sport participation legacy” in official Olympic and Paralympic Game-related documents, analyses of PA and sport participation legacies have tended to report on use of the two terms collectively (Reis et al., 2017). Such an all-encompassing description for different types of activities along the movement spectrum can be a barrier for more nuanced analysis of PA policy development. For example, within Australia, the Federal Government considers recreational activity the responsibility of subnational (State) Governments. However, Australian PA policy development to date has primarily occurred at the State Government level. Furthermore, analysis of Australian community sentiment directly after the 2024 Paris Games identified differences between the amount of people who were motivated to play sport versus those who wanted to be more active (Australian Sports Commission, 2024). As a result, the current investigation utilised the terms separately.

Political science perspective

Many reports have called for better translation of PA research evidence to policy and practice (Giles-Corti et al., 2015; McLaughlin et al., 2025). The recommended content of PA policies has also been extensively documented (Bull et al., 2014). Yet governments and the public often prefer policies that reflect considerations and concerns other than evidence alone (Carney and Oliver, 2017). Researchers have noted that there has been minimal consideration of policy development processes (Noel-Racine et al., 2020) or the use of different policy instruments (Gelius et al., 2021) to engage political leaders in the PA policy development process. There is a need to apply political science theories to the conundrum to better understand the translation of PA policy recommendations into political prioritisation and subsequent policy implementation (Noel-Racine et al., 2020).

Based on empirical data and the multiple streams (Kingdon and Thurber, 1995), policy cycles (Howlett et al., 2009) and advocacy coalition (Weible and Sabatier, 2007) theories, a conceptual framework for the development of State (subnational) PA policies was developed. This conceptual framework is comprised of five stages describing the development of State (subnational) policy from the beginning of the policy making process to policy evaluation.

The five stages of the proposed policy process are intended to align with previous PA sector specific conceptual frameworks (Pogrmilovic et al., 2019) to incorporate consideration of relevant PA sector specific matters. The proposed PA conceptual framework also aligns with a model proposed by Howell et al. (2016) to unite similar political science theories to gain a better understanding of policy development processes.

The current investigation combined these established political science theories to examine different approaches to leveraging the Olympic and Paralympic Games to encourage sport and PA policy development and their (potential) outcomes. The aim of the investigation was to provide a better understanding of pre-event Brisbane 2032 policies and actions that can impact legacy efforts and associated discourses. Specifically, the current investigation examined if and why key actors, such as political leaders and senior bureaucrats, incorporated PA policy development as part of their 2032 Brisbane Olympic and Paralympic Games legacy preparations.

The investigation was divided into two components, Part A: an analysis of Brisbane 2032 Olympic and Paralympic Games bid documents and Part B: interviews with relevant elected leaders and key decision makers regarding motivations to incorporate PA policy components within Brisbane 2032 submission documents and subsequent policy development. This report is a summary of the results of Part A.

Methods

Brisbane 2032 Bidding Process

The Olympic bidding process prior to the confirmation of the 2024 Games was altered in 2019 to provide greater transparency and reduce unnecessary work related to the preparation for each bid (Tham, 2022). A document analysis was undertaken of six official IOC publications that reflected three different stages of the new selection process in the lead up to the July 2021 IOC announcement of the preferred Brisbane 2032 Games bid. The analysis identified how often PA and sport legacy were specified throughout the documents. The intent was to address how coverage of PA and sport can be utilised as part of a preferred bid to be advantageous in terms of more inclusive legacy outcomes to the IOC, as well as to the destination.

Six key documents were analysed including the IOC 2032 Olympic and Paralympic Future Host Questionnaire (IOC, 2021), three IOC Future Host Commission responses prepared as part of the first Targeted Dialogue Process for electing future Olympic hosts and two IOC contractual specifications used to confirm the terms of the 2032 Games arrangement. The six documents are summarised in Table 1 – 2032 Olympic and Paralympic Games documents reviewed. Each document was reviewed with inductive coding using reflexive thematic analysis (Braun and Clarke, 2006). Coded terms included: legacy, Physic*, activ*, exercise, active transport, participa*, sport. The analysis did not code any occurrences in tables of contents, document headers, etc.

Documents reviewed	Stage of the 2032 Games bid process
1. Future Host Questionnaire (IOC, 2021)	Framework to inform new Targeted Dialogue Process
2. Future Host Commission Questionnaire Response (IOC, 2021)	Future Host Commission Targeted Dialogue Process responses
3. Feasibility Assessment – Olympic Games Brisbane 2032 (IOC, 2021)	Future Host Commission Targeted Dialogue Process responses
4. Report of the Future Host Commission (IOC, 2021)	Future Host Commission Targeted Dialogue Process responses
5. Olympic Host Contract 2032 – Principles (IOC, 2021)	Contractual specifications to inform the terms of 2032 Brisbane Games
6. Host City Contract 2032 – Operational Requirements (IOC, 2018)	Contractual specifications to inform the terms of 2032 Brisbane Games

Table 1: 2032 Olympic and Paralympic Games documents reviewed.

Results

The terms “legacy” and “sport” were used throughout all six documents (particularly related to sport venues). For the two IOC documents used to inform contractual arrangements, Olympic Host Contract 2032 – Principles (IOC,

2021) and Host City Contract 2032 – Operational Requirements (IOC, 2018), “legacy” was most frequently mentioned (n=101) in comparison to a total of only 10 references to any of the other key search terms. The great majority of references to key search terms other than “legacy” related to sport (9 of 10). The term “physical activity” (physic*) was mentioned in the Future Host Commission Report - Brisbane 2032 (IOC, 2021) bid response (n = 3) but not in any other document.

The documents varied in length (number of pages). The relative frequency of references to “legacy” and “sport” differed between the three different stages of the bidding process. For example, “legacy” appeared on average every page (1.0) in the initial Future Host Questionnaire (IOC, 2021) questionnaire, every 1.4 pages in the three Future Host Commission Targeted Dialogue Process responses and every 3.4 pages in the contractual specification documents. The term “legacy” was therefore more frequently promoted in the initial Future Host Questionnaire (IOC, 2021) and Future Host Commission responses than in the contractual obligations. The term “sport” followed a similar pattern. Results of the coded term analysis are presented in Table 2

Document	pages	legacy	sport	Participa*	Physic*	Active Transport	Exercise
Future Host Questionnaire	33	34	6	0	0	0	0
Future Host Questionnaire Response	94	134	31	0	0	0	0
IOC Feasibility Assessment	53	3	3	0	0	0	0
Future Host Commission Report	127	59	19	3	3	3	0
Host City Contract 2032 – Principles	48	19	3	0	0	0	0

Host City Contract 2032 – Operational Requirements	292	82	9	1	0	0	0
Total	662	331	71	4	3	3	0

Table 2: Frequency of coded terms within selected key 2032 Games documents.

Discussion

This initial review of key sport and PA-related terms utilised within key IOC 2032 Brisbane Games documents has identified that “legacy” and “sport” were by far the most frequently utilised of the coded terms assessed. Of all the other coded terms, “participation” was the only one identified within documents used to inform contractual arrangements (one reference within the Host City Contract 2032 – Operational Requirements). The results indicate that the Future Host City Commission Report was the only document that incorporated explicit reference to PA (n=3).

Significantly, the IOC has recently modified the contractual arrangements for Games Host Cities to include PA legacy for the first time as defined by “sports to improve health and wellbeing of the host country” (personal communication, 2024). Such a definition of PA would not be detected as PA using the coding of the current investigation. Of note, PA related legacy actions emerging from the Paris 2024 Summer Olympic and Paralympic Games such as policies to include 30 minutes of daily activity in schools and workplaces, active design in parks and sports clubs training staff to better accommodate people living with disabilities may not have all been identified within the current PA definition (OECD, 2025).

Changes to the Olympic and Paralympic Games bidding rules were also introduced for the Brisbane 2032 Games so that the hosts were already identified in February 2021. This was much earlier than in the past and has provided more power to politicians as Games legacies can now be built over a longer period of time, lowering risks and increasing opportunities they produce (Konecke and de Nooij, 2022). However, there has also been a Queensland

State (subnational) election since the current data was compiled, and a new party has been elected to power from the alternative side of Government. A review of the 2032 Brisbane Games preparations was immediately undertaken and changes subsequently announced. The impact of the changes undertaken by the IOC and the Brisbane 2032 Games organisers upon updated contractual arrangements may help inform subsequent interviews with elected leaders in Part B of the current investigation.

The policy and political space regarding PA is complex, dense, and crowded. Engaging executive-level politicians to consider State (subnational)-level PA policy development is challenging and ever changing. It requires executive political leadership to establish a longer-term policy programme. Contemporary views of the policy process ascertain that it is messy and best described as juggling (Howlett et al., 2009) or weaving (de Leeuw et al., 2017), rather than in a more traditional heuristic (along a line, or cyclical). Since 2007, Olympic Game host cities have explicitly included PA policy and targets as part of a legacy plan in Olympic Game candidature files. Changes to the IOC Games contractual arrangements now indirectly specify PA legacy considerations. Future Olympic and Paralympic Game host cities will need to consider how they intend to address these updated legacy requirements.

Olympic Game legacy case study research to date has focused on interviews with sport sector leaders and delivery agency representatives. The inability to secure interviews with elected representatives has excluded the views of these key decision makers. The purpose of Part B of the current project will be to assess the motivations of subnational (State) elected leaders and key policy decision makers regarding why they incorporated (or did not incorporate) physical activity considerations within their Brisbane 2032 legacy deliberations. The results of Part A of the project will help inform interview guides regarding any opportunities that elected leaders may identify to frame PA policy development and implementation as tangible 2032 Olympic and Paralympic Games legacies.

Conclusions

In conclusion, Part A of the current investigation has identified an opportunity within IOC (and potentially other major event) documentation to strengthen PA

requirements that are incorporated within host city bid proposal and consequent contractual obligations. More explicit demands for the inclusion of PA legacy policies and programmes within both bid proposals and subsequent contractual obligations may provide more inclusive legacy outcomes to the IOC, as well as to host destinations.

Acknowledgements

I would like to acknowledge my collaborators in the current investigation (Danya Hodgetts and Antoine Noel Racine), the IOC Olympic Studies Centre for the scholarship which funded my attendance to the 32nd International Seminar on Olympic Studies for Postgraduate Students, Daryl Adair (Director, Australian Centre for Olympic and Sports Studies, UTS Australia) and my PhD Supervisory Team (Ben Harris-Roxas, Evelyne de Leeuw and Christopher Walker) for their support.

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THE EVOLUTION AND SOCIAL PERCEPTION OF SKATEBOARDING: FROM URBAN STREETS TO THE OLYMPIC GAMES

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Abstract

This study aimed to analyse the historical and cultural evolution of skateboarding and to examine changes in its social perception, from its urban origins to its institutionalisation in the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games. A qualitative approach was adopted, involving 150 participants whose voices were collected through a semi-structured interview with questions on origins, social perception, professionalisation, and Olympic inclusion. The results show that skaters remember skateboarding as a countercultural and resistant practice, while non-skaters associate it with recreation or an emerging sport. Professionalisation and Olympic inclusion are valued as opportunities for legitimisation and visibility, although among skaters there remains criticism regarding the loss of its rebellious essence. In conclusion, skateboarding is configured as a hybrid phenomenon between sport, culture, and counterculture, whose historical tensions are reconfigured within the framework of its institutionalisation.

Keywords: Skateboarding, youth culture, social perception, professionalisation, Olympic Games.

Theoretical Framework

Skateboarding is a cultural and sporting phenomenon that reflects the dynamics

between youth, society, and institutions. More than a physical practice, it constitutes a space for artistic, social, and cultural expression (Beal et al., 2017; Turcott, 2020). In line with Bourdieu (1993), sport is understood as a social construction, and skateboarding has been configured as a form of urban appropriation and generational identity (Marlovits, 2024). Its origins date back to California in the 1950s, when surfers adapted boards with wheels, and in the 1970s the Z-Boys radically transformed the practice in empty pools, consolidating an aesthetic that shaped its contemporary identity (Bäckström & Blackman, 2022; Buchetti, 2025). Later, the discipline expanded globally, intertwining with music, fashion, and media, and achieving increasing professionalisation through international events (Batuev & Robinson, 2018; Büntgen et al., 2023).

Despite this trajectory, the social perception of skateboarding has been marked by ambivalence. In its early stages, it was associated with countercultural attitudes and the unconventional use of urban spaces, leading to stigmatisation (Bäckström & Blackman, 2022). Mitchell (2003) describes how skaters re-signify the city by transforming plazas, stairs, and railings into spaces of creativity. This innovative and transgressive character, although sometimes in conflict with urban norms, reinforced its link with youth and with a notion of individual freedom (Glenney, 2024; Taylor & Khan, 2011).

Institutional recognition reached a new level with the inclusion of skateboarding in the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games. This involved the definition of specific modalities (street and park) and standardised scoring criteria, reflecting how Olympism engages with new forms of sporting expression and contemporary cultural changes (Diewald et al., 2024; Fouillot et al., 2025). For some, this inclusion meant visibility, professionalisation, and social legitimacy; for others, it represented the risk of diluting skateboarding's cultural and creative essence (Beal, 2023; Renfree et al., 2021).

In this sense, institutionalisation does not eliminate the cultural character of skateboarding but rather reconfigures it as a space of encounter between tradition and modernity, between youth identity and global recognition (Batuev et al., 2020; Glenney & Mull, 2018).

Based on this framework, the research aims to understand the trajectory of skateboarding from its urban roots to its Olympic recognition, as well as to identify the changes in social perception that have accompanied this process. Accordingly, the general objective is to analyse the historical and cultural evolution of skateboarding and to examine how its social perception

has changed, from its urban origins to its institutionalisation as an Olympic discipline. From this, the following specific objectives are derived:

- To explore how skaters and non-skaters remember and assign meaning to the origins of skateboarding.
- To understand social perceptions of skateboarding at different stages of its development.
- To interpret the meanings attributed to the professionalisation of skateboarding and its impact on the cultural identity of the discipline.
- To analyse and contrast the perceptions of skaters and non-skaters regarding skateboarding as sport, culture, and identity, including their assessment of its inclusion in the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games.

Methodology

The present research employed a qualitative, exploratory-descriptive approach with the aim of understanding the perceptions and meanings that skaters and non-skaters attribute to the evolution of skateboarding, from its urban origins to its inclusion in the Olympic Games. In addition, the Qualitative Studies Checklist (CASP, 2023) was used as a guide to strengthen methodological rigor and ensure the quality of the research process. In this sense, the study complied favourably with the 10 items included in this assessment tool.

Context and Participants

The sample consisted of 150 participants, of whom 70 identified as skaters and 80 as non-skaters, aged between 18 and 70 years. Sampling was carried out based on convenience and availability, ensuring the heterogeneity necessary to contrast perceptions between both groups. Participation was defined according to the following inclusion criteria: being of legal age, willingness to complete the questionnaire, and having signed informed consent.

Instrument

To address the research objective, a semi-structured interview was designed to explore perceptions of skaters and non-skaters regarding the evolution of skateboarding and its Olympic recognition. The interview was organised into

two blocks, following the methodological recommendations of Ibarra-Sáiz et al. (2023) and Yin (1994) to ensure credibility and validity. The first block collected sociodemographic data (age, gender, level of involvement), fundamental for contextualising responses and detecting patterns, as highlighted by Guerrero-Castañeda and González-Soto (2022). The second block included 11 open-ended questions focused on four aspects: the origins of skateboarding, past and present social perception, professionalisation, and Olympic inclusion.

Procedure

The study was developed in phases consistent with the qualitative approach. First, the semi-structured interview was designed based on the research objectives and validated by two experts in qualitative studies on culture and sport. Next, skaters and non-skaters who met the inclusion criteria were contacted. All participants signed informed consent, in accordance with ethical standards and the Declaration of Helsinki (code UA-2025-02-16).

Data collection took place in January and February 2025 via a Google Forms questionnaire, which ensured uniformity and allowed participants to reflect on their responses. Subsequently, an inductive qualitative analysis was conducted through manual coding, identifying units of meaning and organising them into four axes: origins of skateboarding, social perception, professionalisation, and Olympic inclusion.

Internal triangulation was applied to reduce bias, and the criterion of saturation was respected. Results were presented using absolute and relative frequencies, complemented by anonymous quotations from participants, identified with the letter “S” and a number.

Results

From the qualitative analysis of the interviews, thematic categories were identified that structure the results and provide answers to the research objectives. These are presented below.

Block 1: Memories and Meanings of the Origins of Skateboarding

Perceptions of the origins of skateboarding reveal the coexistence of different

ways of attributing meaning to this practice (Table 1).

Table 1

Memories and Meanings of the Origins of Skateboarding
According to Skaters and Non-Skaters

Category	Skaters (FA)	Skaters (%FA)	Non-Skaters (FA)	Non- Skaters (%FA)	Total (FA)	Total (%FA)
Cultural Expression / Counterculture	50	59.5	23	21.9	73	38.6
Sport / Recreation	20	23.8	53	50.5	73	38.6
Urban Problem / Dangerousness	4	4.8	19	18.1	23	12.2
Others	10	11.9	10	9.5	20	10.6
Total	84	100	105	100	189	100

The most frequently mentioned category was cultural expression/ counterculture (38.6%FA of the total), with 59.5%FA among skaters and only 21.9%FA among non-skaters. For the former, skateboarding is associated with freedom, street authenticity, and rebellion: “it was born as something from the streets, not as a sport. It was pure rebellion” (S9); “pure street without rules” (S17); “freedom” (S30).

In contrast, among non-skaters the predominant category was sport/ recreation (50.5%FA), compared to 23.8%FA among skaters. In this group, skateboarding is remembered as a youth pastime: “a very fun sport, although at the beginning it seemed somewhat marginal” (S3); “a pastime for young people, something to hang out with friends” (S29).

The category urban problem/dangerousness (12.2%FA) appeared mainly in non-skater discourses (18.1%FA), who linked it to risks and urban conflicts: “it was a problem in the streets because they damaged public furniture” (S38); “a dangerous sport practiced in unsuitable places” (S4).

Finally, 10.6%FA of the mentions corresponded to others, which included ambiguous accounts or personal experiences without a common pattern.

Block 2: Social Perception of Skateboarding in the Past and Present

Social perceptions show a significant evolution in the collective imagination, highlighting the differences between how skateboarding was valued one or two decades ago and how it is perceived today.

Social Perception in the Past

Perceptions of how skateboarding was viewed 10 or 20 years ago are presented in Table 2.

Table 2

Social Perception of Skateboarding in the Past

Category	Skaters (FA)	Skaters (%FA)	Non- Skaters (FA)	Non- Skaters (%FA)	Total (FA)	Total (%FA)
Rebellion / Vandalism	35	48.6	18	24.3	53	34.4
Emerging Sport	15	20.8	28	37.8	43	27.7
Social Invisibility	10	13.9	14	18.9	24	15.6
Social Ambivalence	12	16.7	22	29.7	34	22.1
Total	72	100	74	100	154	100

The results indicate that the most prominent category was rebellion/vandalism (34.4%FA), especially among skaters (48.6%FA), who recall the practice as marginal and stigmatised: “like a vandalistic and anarchist rebellion” (S12); “they looked at us like criminals” (S20). In contrast, non-skaters mainly associated skateboarding with an emerging sport (37.8%FA), remembered as a growing discipline: “a sport on the rise, something new with a future” (S26). Other mentions were distributed among social invisibility (15.6%FA), where

“people didn’t talk much about it” (S41), and social ambivalence (22.1%FA), which described it as “fun, but not widely accepted” (S27).

Social Perception in the Present

Currently, skateboarding is perceived differently than it was in the past. The distribution of mentions is presented in Table 3.

Table 3

Current Social Perception of Skateboarding

Category	Skaters (FA)	Skaters (%FA)	Non- Skaters (FA)	Non- Skaters (%FA)	Total (FA)	Total (%FA)
Institutionalisation / Legitimation	25	41.0	28	35.9	53	38.1
Youth Sport / Recreation	5	8.2	8	10.3	13	9.3
Loss of Rebellious Essence	12	19.7	6	7.7	18	12.9
Persistence of Stigma	8	13.1	10	12.8	18	12.9
Social Indifference	11	18.0	26	33.3	37	26.6
Total	61	100	78	100	139	100

The most prominent category was institutionalisation/legitimation (38.1%FA of mentions), cited by both skaters and non-skaters, who acknowledge its greater acceptance following its inclusion in the Olympics: “since it’s institutionalised, it is now seen as more accepted” (S18). However, some point out that critical views still persist: “now they see it as an Olympic sport, but they still look at it with suspicion” (S2).

Among the critical perceptions, the loss of rebellious essence (12.9%FA) stands out, especially among skaters: “it’s positive that it’s Olympic, but it no longer has the same street essence” (S7); along with the persistence of stigma (12.9%FA), which reveals the survival of prejudices: “even though it’s Olympic, there are still those who see us as troublemakers” (S15). Finally,

social indifference (26.6%FA) reflects that skateboarding no longer generates rejection, but neither does it inspire special admiration: “today it’s just one more option among many” (S33).

Block 3: Professionalisation of Skateboarding

When participants talk about the professionalisation of skateboarding, opposing views emerge. Table 4 summarises these differentiated perceptions between skaters and non-skaters.

Table 4

Professionalisation of Skateboarding

Category	Skaters (FA)	Skaters (%FA)	Non- Skaters (FA)	Non- Skaters (%FA)	Total (FA)	Total (%FA)
Positive Acceptance	20	34.5	36	56.3	56	32.4
Loss of Rebellious Essence	22	37.9	9	14.1	31	17.9
Visibility and Opportunities	12	20.7	29	45.3	41	23.7
Indifference / No Clear Opinion	4	6.9	3	4.7	7	4.0
Others	0	0	38	7.7	38	22.0
Total	58	100	77	100	173	100

The most frequent category was positive acceptance (32.4%FA), especially among non-skaters (56.3%FA), who value this process as a path toward legitimisation and development: “thanks to its professionalisation, skaters are now more respected” (S22).

In contrast, among skaters the predominant idea was the loss of rebellious essence (37.9%FA), alluding to the tension between visibility and authenticity: “as it becomes professional, the street essence is being lost” (S14).

The category visibility and opportunities (23.7%FA) brought together perspectives from both groups, with greater emphasis among non-skaters (45.3%FA), who highlighted the possibility of making a living from skateboarding: “now kids can live off skateboarding; before, that was impossible” (S28).

Finally, 4.0%FA of mentions reflected indifference, from participants with no defined opinion or who do not perceive substantial changes in the practice.

Block 4: Inclusion of Skateboarding in the Olympic Games

The incorporation of skateboarding into the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games represented a turning point in the way this practice is socially perceived. Table 5 presents the distribution of mentions between skaters and non-skaters.

Table 5

Skateboarding in the Olympics

Category	Skaters (FA)	Skaters (%FA)	Non- Skaters (FA)	Non- Skaters (%FA)	Total (FA)	Total (%FA)
Global Legitimation	18	28.6	27	40.9	45	27.8
Pride and Opportunities	12	19.0	25	37.9	37	22.8
Loss of Rebellious Essence	20	31.7	8	12.1	28	17.3
Persistence of Cultural Debate	13	20.6	9	13.6	22	13.6
Others	0	0	30	10.9	30	18.5
Total	63	100	69	100	162	100

The most prominent category was global legitimisation (27.8%FA), especially among non-skaters (40.9%FA), who valued its international recognition: “at last it’s given a serious place” (S5).

In second place appeared pride and opportunities (22.8%FA), also more frequent among non-skaters (37.9%FA), focused on visibility and prospects for new generations: “it’s incredible that young people now have a space in the biggest sport in the world” (S21).

In contrast, skaters emphasised the loss of rebellious essence (31.7%FA), expressing concern that the Olympic framework might dilute its street authenticity: “when it’s brought into the Olympic system, it loses its essence of freedom” (S14).

The persistence of cultural debate (13.6%FA) brought together ambivalent narratives that acknowledged the benefits of visibility but also tensions between sport and identity: “it’s positive that it’s recognised, but I have doubts about it being measured by rules” (S12).

Finally, 18.5%FA of mentions reflected neutral opinions, where inclusion was perceived without major repercussions: “it’s fine, but it doesn’t change anything for me” (S27).

Discussion

The purpose of this research was to analyse the historical and cultural evolution of skateboarding and the changes in its social perception, from its urban origins to its Olympic institutionalisation. The findings make it possible to contrast the perceptions of skaters and non-skaters in dialogue with previous literature.

The results show that skateboarding cannot be understood merely as the transition from recreation to sport, but rather as a cultural process shaped by tensions between rebellion, institutionalisation, and social legitimacy, in line with Beal et al. (2017) and Turcott (2020). Regarding its origins, skaters highlight counterculture, urban creativity, and identity freedom, while non-skaters evoke it as leisure or a social problem, which coincides with Bourdieu (1993), Marlovits (2024), Bäckström and Blackman (2022), and Mitchell (2003).

Perceptions of the past reinforce this ambivalence: skaters recall stigma and rebellion, while non-skaters conceived of it as an emerging sport, in line with Glenney (2024) and Taylor and Khan (2011). In the present, professionalisation and inclusion in the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games reinforce its legitimacy (Diewald et al., 2024; Fouillot et al., 2025), although criticisms

regarding the loss of authenticity persist (Beal, 2023; Renfree et al., 2021). For non-skaters it represents recognition and legitimacy, while for skaters it poses the risk of diluting their countercultural identity, a tension that resonates with Batuev and Robinson (2018), Büntgen et al. (2023), and Buchetti (2025).

Olympic inclusion thus emerges as a turning point combining global validation and internal criticism, consistent with Fouillot et al. (2025) and Glenney and Mull (2018). In summary, skateboarding constitutes a hybrid space between sport, culture, and youth identity. Its institutionalisation does not eliminate historical tensions but reconfigures them, as Batuev et al. (2020) argue regarding the dynamic nature of contemporary sport.

Conclusions

The analysis carried out allows us to understand how the perception of skateboarding has shifted from its marginal origins to its recognition as an Olympic discipline, marked by tensions between the perspectives of skaters and non-skaters.

In memories of its beginnings, skaters emphasise its cultural and countercultural character, associated with street freedom, while non-skaters recall it as leisure or even as an urban problem. This divergence persists in perceptions of the past: practitioners remember stigma and labels of rebellion, whereas non-skaters recognised it as an emerging sport.

Today, professionalisation and inclusion in institutional circuits have transformed its image. Non-skaters value it as a consolidated sport, while skaters maintain a critical discourse about the loss of essence and cultural domestication—particularly with its entry into the Olympic Games, perceived as validation for some and as a risk of distortion for others.

In sum, skateboarding is simultaneously perceived as sport, culture, and counterculture. For skaters, it remains a space of identity and resistance, for non-skaters, a legitimised youth practice. The coexistence of these views reflects its social ambivalence, positioned between the streets and the sporting elite.

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**CONCLUSIONS OF
THE WORKING GROUPS**

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22 September, Monday – Berk Bilgin (Türkiye)

Why did the organisers of the Panhellenic Sacred Games symbolically prefer wreaths as prizes for the winners instead of money? (Prof. Albanidis)

The organisers of the four major Panhellenic Sacred Games, the Olympic, Pythian, Isthmian, and Nemean Games, symbolically preferred wreaths instead of money because the contests were categorised as crown games, which offered only foliage prizes to victors. This deliberate choice maintained the "sacred prestige" of the festivals and emphasised that the competition was for "honour" rather than material rewards, distinguishing them from "money" games.

At Olympia, the prize was the *kotinos*, a crown made from the sacred wild olive tree. This prize was viewed as an "immortal symbol of victory", which granted the victor glorious fame and spiritual eminence, making him equal to the gods. The symbolic nature of the reward was intended to communicate that success was based on merit and quality. This ideological stance was publicly affirmed by the Zanes (bronze statues of Zeus erected using fines from cheats), whose inscriptions warned that competition was decided by swiftness of foot or strength of body, not by money.

Despite receiving only a wreath at the sanctuary, victory in these prestigious games was highly valued, as it triggered lavish material rewards and honours, such as large cash payments, free meals for life, and triumphant entries from the victor's ambitious home city. Ultimately, the symbolic nature of the prize enhanced a champion's market-value and guaranteed affluence.

Are modern Olympic Ceremonies rituals that communicate ideals?
(Prof. Mouratidis)

Yes, modern Olympic Ceremonies are centrally designed as rituals intended to communicate ideals, reflecting the philosophical foundation of Olympism.

Pierre de Coubertin, the founder of the modern Games, strongly emphasised the importance of ceremonies, stating that the "question of the ceremonies is one of the most important to settle" to distinguish the Olympics from a mere series of world championships. Coubertin's vision was to imbue these events with educational and moral value, conceiving the Olympic Games as a total work of art that involves and captivates the audience.

The ceremonies function as ritualised activities that reaffirm cultural values and a sense of order. Through their symbolism, they add values such as fraternity and universality. The ceremonies uphold Olympism, which is defined in the Olympic Charter as a philosophy of life seeking to blend sport with culture and education to promote a way of life based on the joy of effort, social responsibility, and respect for universal fundamental ethical principles. The goal of Olympism, communicated through these means, is to foster the harmonious development of humankind and promote a peaceful society.

Several key ceremonial components act as rituals and symbols of these ideals:

- The Olympic Oath is a central tradition intended to hold participants morally accountable for fair and noble competition and to promote moral improvement through the spirit of sincere altruism.
- The Olympic flag features five interlaced rings representing the five parts of the world united in Olympism.
- The ceremonial lighting and relay of the Olympic torch, though an invented tradition in the modern era, symbolises the eternally renewing power of youth and the continuous flame of the Greek spirit enlightening mankind.
- The inclusion of the motto "Citius, Altius, Fortius – Together" communicates the commitment to excellence, spiritual uplift, and solidarity.

Organising Committees for the Olympic Games are officially required to link the content of the opening and closing ceremonies to the humanistic aspects of Olympism.

23 September, Tuesday – Berk Bilgin (Türkiye)

What stories do monuments of athletes tell us?

Monuments of athletes, both ancient and modern, tell a complex story about the intersection of individual achievement, community identity, and cultural values. They serve as physical narratives that chronicle an athlete's success while also reflecting the ideals and priorities of the society that built them.

In ancient Greece, monuments, often statues of nude male bodies, primarily told a story of idealised excellence. They celebrated the victor's physical prowess, divine favour, and the glory they brought to their family and city-state. These monuments, frequently placed in religious sanctuaries, served as votive offerings, cementing the link between athletic victory and the gods. The statues were not always precise portraits but rather idealised forms, emphasising the pursuit of perfect beauty and virtue. The presence of statues like the Zanes at Olympia, funded by fines for cheating, also told a story of communal values and the consequences of corruption.

Today, monuments to athletes have a similar, yet more secular, purpose. Modern monuments, often found in stadiums, public parks, or dedicated halls of fame, tell a story of personal triumph and cultural significance. They celebrate an athlete's career, statistics, and impact on their sport and society. While ancient temples were often the setting for athletic monuments, today's equivalents are more often arenas and stadiums.

The focus has shifted from an overtly spiritual connection to a celebration of an athlete's skill and legacy. These monuments often feature realistic portraits and detailed plaques listing achievements, a testament to our culture's fascination with records and measurable greatness. They still foster a sense of civic pride, with cities honouring hometown heroes and entire nations celebrating the success of their athletes.

What are the most distinctive characteristics of ancient athletic events in comparison to modern ones?

The comparison between ancient athletic events, particularly the Greek Olympics, and modern sports reveals stark differences across several major facets of organisation and ideology.

Religion and spiritualism were central to the ancient games, which were

part of revered religious festivals honouring Zeus. Religious ceremonies, sacrifices, oaths, and prayers were mandatory features. Victors were sometimes regarded as "equal to the gods", reflecting the deeply pious context. The ancient Games ultimately ended due to Christian opposition to this pagan piety. Modern Olympics, conversely, are largely secular events, lacking a religious core.

Regarding participation and physical presentation, ancient athletes in events like the Olympics were exclusively Greek males. They competed nude, a practice that served as an ethnic identifier distinguishing Greeks from foreigners. Gender roles were highly rigid: married women were excluded from attending or competing in the Olympics, although girls competed in separate, non-Olympic races like the Heraea. Modern sports involve female participation and specialised equipment and uniforms, erasing the element of ritual nudity.

The scope of competition differed significantly: the ancient Olympic programme was notably conservative, featuring a small and stable number of events. Critically, there were no team games; competition was strictly between individuals. Modern games include extensive team divisions and numerous events.

On the topic of finance and status, the myth of ancient amateurism has been thoroughly dispelled, just as in the conversations we are having nowadays. Professionalism existed, as victors received massive material rewards, subsidies, and lifelong privileges from their city-states, again similar to the athletes of the 21st century. However, the direct mass commercialisation and financial exploitation, characteristic of the media-driven modern sports industry, were absent from the ancient Games. Furthermore, ancient contests were always hosted at Olympia for over a millennium. Their stadium designs were rectangular with dirt tracks, focusing on simplicity, in contrast to modern oval tracks and frequently changing, grandiose host cities. Ancient technology and focus did not prioritise quantification or record-breaking, favouring victory and prestige over metrics.

25 September, Thursday – Sadeem Aldarwesh (Saudi Arabia)

What do the modern Olympic Games owe to ancient Greece?

The Modern Olympic Games owe a profound debt to ancient Greece, both in structure and spirit. Firstly, the very concept of institutionalised athletic competition—complete with rules, judges, and the celebration of human physical limits—originates from the ancient Greek Olympics. This model of organised sport has been foundational for the modern Games. Secondly, the philosophical underpinnings of the Olympics—values such as fair play, the pursuit of excellence, and the celebration of human achievement—are deeply rooted in ancient Greek thought. The modern Games continue to promote these ideals, fostering not only competition but also mutual respect among athletes. Rituals and symbols, such as the lighting of the Olympic flame, are inspired by ancient Greek ceremonies, even if they are modern inventions. These traditions serve to connect the present with the past, evoking a sense of continuity and shared heritage. Furthermore, the idea of the Olympics as a gathering for international peace and understanding echoes the ancient Olympic Truce, when conflicts were set aside for the duration of the Games. This aspiration remains central to the Olympic Movement today. Finally, Greece's role as the cradle of Western civilisation is acknowledged in the prominence given to Greek symbols and traditions in the modern Olympics, from the order of the parade of nations to the architectural and aesthetic choices. In summary, the Modern Olympic Games inherit from ancient Greece not only their organisational framework and rituals but also their enduring ideals of excellence, peace, and international fellowship.

29 September Monday – Weijie Hu (China)

How has global history affected the ways Olympic hosts depicted the future in their ceremonies?

Beijing Olympics in 2008. 5,000 years of history in China. During the ceremony, China wanted to tell the whole world that it had a history of good development. It is a good opportunity to make an image for a country. The host city showcases new technology and culture. For example, Beijing 2008 showcased technology and traditional culture of many types. They used the ceremony to validate the

cultural story. Opening ceremonies can reinterpret history. London 2012 talked about the industrial revolution, but it was with different words, mentioning the dark side of the industrial revolution like the labour environment. It became a chance to think about human rights, especially in the medical area. Also, we focused on the humanistic side of history with many examples. Those topics will not be discussed in the opening ceremony, because London 2012 did not mention colonialism.

This is the summary of the discussion.

1. The 2008 Beijing opening ceremony used China's 5,000-year history to showcase its development (shaping national image) and integrated technology with diverse traditional cultures.
2. Opening ceremonies validate/strengthen cultural narratives and reinterpret history, e.g., London 2012 addressed the Industrial Revolution's dark side from a new angle, sparking human rights reflections.
3. They should focus on history's humanistic side, combining issues, political topics and future matters—LA 2028 may discuss immigration.
4. Opening ceremony content is selective: hosts decide topics to include/exclude, like London 2012 omitting colonialism.

30 September, Tuesday – Minori Hara (Japan)

How has the Parade of Nations mirrored the evolution of female participation in sports and echoed the historical events that affected different societies' hegemonic archetypes of masculinity and femininity?

Initially, this evolution was marked by exclusion, as the first modern Games in 1896 featured no female competitors. The earliest inclusion of women was in sports deemed socially acceptable, such as tennis and golf, where athletes were often required to compete in restrictive uniforms that upheld conventional standards of femininity. This limited participation reflected a world where the athletic sphere was considered an exclusively male domain.

Significant changes began to accelerate in the post-World War II era, as global conflicts disrupted traditional gender roles and the Cold War created a new political stage for demonstrating national superiority through sport. The increasing presence and success of powerful female athletes from various

nations in the Parade of Nations began to actively challenge and reshape societal archetypes of female physical capabilities. A pivotal moment in this evolution was the implementation of Title IX in the United States, a landmark piece of legislation that mandated equal opportunities in education, including sports. While a national policy, its effects rippled globally, inspiring similar movements and institutionalising the expectation for female inclusion in elite sports organisations (U.S. Department of Education, 2025).

In recent decades, the Parade of Nations has reflected a more explicit and institutional commitment to gender equality. The Tokyo 2020 Olympics achieved near-complete gender parity in athlete numbers, a goal that was fully realised first at the Buenos Aires 2018 Youth Olympic Games, signalling a shift toward a more inclusive standard. However, while the visual representation of athletes in the Parade tells a story of progress, it also masks ongoing disparities. The focus on athlete equality has not been matched in management and leadership positions within the IOC and National Olympic Committees. It is also unclear who is taking the initiative for gender equality. There are cases by local governments, OCOG, and NOCs. There are difficulties in sports management across many sectors. This highlights that while the Parade showcases immense progress in the field of play, the struggle for comprehensive gender equity across the entire landscape of sport continues.

U.S. Department of Education, 2025, Title IX and Sex Discrimination, Retrieved from <https://www.ed.gov/laws-and-policy/civil-rights-laws/title-ix-and-sex-discrimination> on April 11, 2025.

How can we fight against the use of sports for political reasons, as seen in 20th-century socialist countries?

Counteracting the political exploitation of sports, particularly the model seen in 20th-century socialist countries, requires a fundamental shift from a top-down, state-controlled system to one centred on individual athletes and civil society. The socialist model was characterised by a state apparatus that used athletics as a tool for projecting ideological superiority and national prestige. This system manifested in a "gold medal fetishism", where the primary goal was international victory rather than personal development or community engagement. In countries like Hungary, sports clubs were under governmental subdivision, such as the

army or police, effectively eliminating a genuine civil sports sphere and turning athletes into instruments of the government.

A primary strategy to combat this model is to foster the development of independent, grassroots sports clubs. By creating and protecting sporting institutions that are separate from state control, power is decentralised, and the focus returns to local communities and individual participants. This approach builds a sporting culture from the bottom up, driven by personal passion and local identity rather than state directives. Furthermore, upholding the core principles of Olympism is crucial. This philosophy champions the human rights and dignity of the individual. Empowering athletes and ensuring their voices are heard is a powerful antidote to state exploitation.

The role of a free and balanced media is also critical. Instead of amplifying state-driven narratives that create "national heroes" solely based on medal counts, the media should provide fair and diverse coverage that celebrates a wide range of athletic achievements and personal stories. This helps to dismantle the culture of victory-at-all-costs. Finally, demonstrating a positive alternative is essential. Modern democratic societies showcase how sport can be a powerful tool for social inclusion, integrating immigrant communities in countries like Germany and France, and for providing socio-economic mobility for individuals from disadvantaged backgrounds. These examples highlight a healthier, more humane use of sport that prioritises human development over state propaganda.

1 October, Wednesday – Clarisse Silva Caetano (Brazil)

Should universities implement AI tools in teaching and learning? Why, and if so how can they do so responsibly while ensuring that students still learn?

Yes, universities should implement AI in education, since the presence of these tools is already a reality. Thus, the integration of artificial intelligence (AI) tools in higher education is both an inevitable step and a necessary step, considering the rapid advancement of digital technologies and their potential to transform teaching and learning processes—provided that such integration is guided by critical reflection. Universities should indeed consider adopting these tools; however, this implementation must be framed by a clear pedagogical framework that ensures responsible use while safeguarding the quality of student learning. First, AI can

offer valuable support by expanding access to information, diversifying learning resources, and providing immediate feedback. As discussed, AI has the ability to generate abundant content and create opportunities for students who might otherwise feel less confident in contributing. This democratisation of participation has the potential to make learning environments more inclusive and dynamic. Moreover, when instructors mediate the interaction between students and AI, academic rigour is strengthened, ensuring that the responses generated are not accepted uncritically but instead are subjected to careful evaluation.

Nevertheless, there are inherent risks. AI systems may produce inaccurate, incomplete, or even misleading responses. As noted, the technology can “please us” by reflecting what we want to hear, reinforcing misconceptions instead of challenging them. For example, if students were to ask AI about scientifically refuted claims, such as the flat Earth theory, the system could, depending on its training data, present arguments that validate false premises. This underscores the need to cultivate critical thinking skills and to emphasise fact-checking of both historical claims and scientific realities.

Thus, universities must highlight that AI does not replace human judgment but rather functions as a complementary tool that requires careful oversight. Responsible implementation, therefore, involves multiple strategies. Universities should establish guidelines that reinforce the ethical use of AI, promote transparency in its functioning, and encourage students to question the origin and reliability of the responses generated. Teacher training is essential, as educators must be prepared to integrate AI tools into pedagogy in ways that stimulate inquiry and reflection rather than passive consumption. Furthermore, institutions should create spaces for students to experiment with AI use, but in an environment that emphasises responsibility, fact verification, and the development of independent intellectual competencies. In conclusion, universities should adopt AI in teaching and learning, not as a shortcut to knowledge but as a catalyst for engagement that emphasises critical dialogue, fact-checking, and the preservation of human autonomy. When used in this way, AI can enhance the educational process while ensuring that students remain active, reflective, and rigorous learners.

2 October, Thursday – Nelson Morales (Venezuela)

How do your countries reward Olympic and Paralympic medallists in terms of financial bonuses?

Country	Equal Pay?	Gold (Olympic)	Gold (Paralympic)	Notes
Spain	Yes	€94,000 (Individual)	€94,000	Fully equal since Paris 2024; based on event type.
Japan	No	€28,960	€17,376	Clear difference in bonuses.
China	Yes	€80,000 (state) + extras	€80,000 (state)	Equal at national level
Australia	Yes	€12,200	€12,200	Simple flat-rate system; fully equal.
South Africa	Yes	€19,800	€19,800	Equal payment system.
Brazil	No	€55,900	€39,900	Unequal; larger disparity in team events.
Saudi Arabia	Yes	€1.1 million	Similar (claimed)	Past bonuses very high; unclear for future games.
Sri Lanka	Yes	€140,600	€140,600	Very high and equal bonus policy.
Türkiye	Yes	€800,000	€800,000	Based on gold coins; equal for all.
Venezuela	Yes	\$1,200/month stipend	\$1,200/month stipend	It is unclear how long after the games this lasts; in some cases, it is supplemented with the allocation of housing or a car.

Across the world, there's a growing trend toward equal monetary recognition for Olympic and Paralympic athletes, particularly at the national policy level. Countries like Spain, Australia, South Africa, Türkiye, and Sri Lanka have fully equalised bonuses, setting important precedents. However, disparities remain

in nations like Japan and Brazil, where Paralympic athletes still receive less. In countries like China, although the official bonuses are equal, commercial rewards heavily favour Olympic athletes. Meanwhile, non-monetary rewards (like in Venezuela) reflect more symbolic gestures than structured policies. Overall, while financial parity is improving, true equity in recognition and sponsorship remains a challenge, especially in media exposure and corporate support for Paralympians.

3 October, Friday – Natalie (China)

With respect to the mission of the IOC to promote Olympism throughout the world, which sport is most Olympic and which is least Olympic? Explain why with specific reference to the fundamental principles of Olympism. What can be done to better promote the ideal in those sports?

The class was divided into three groups, and their responses were as follows:

Group 1

Non-Olympic sport: Boxing was identified as a sport that contradicts the values of Olympism, particularly the principle of peace.

Olympic sport: High jump was selected as an Olympic sport that best represents Olympism, as athletes primarily compete against themselves to achieve excellence.

Group 2

Non-Olympic sport: Horse riding was considered non-Olympic because it was argued to conflict with animal rights.

Olympic sport: Track running was chosen due to its rich history and strong connection to the origins of the ancient Olympic Games.

Group 3

Non-Olympic sport: Shooting was seen as inconsistent with Olympism because of its association with war, which opposes the spirit of peace.

Olympic sport: The decathlon was highlighted as embodying the diversity of skills and disciplines celebrated in the Olympic Games.

6 October, Monday – Brandy (China)

In your first language, what is the term that best captures the philosophical concepts/moral dispositions of Excellence, Respect, (International) Friendship?

Students' Answers from Various Countries on "Excellence, Respect, Friendship"

1. South Africa (*isiXhosa*)

- Terms: Excellence (*ukugqibelela*, meaning "complete"), Respect (*inhlonipho*), Friendship (*umhlobo*, singular form)
- Connotation: The concepts of Respect and Friendship are rooted in "ubuntu (humanity)". Competition is meant to promote mutual improvement through games, with the core Xhosa philosophy being "*umntu ngumntu ngabantu*" (a person is a person through other people).

2. Japan (*Japanese*)

- Terms:
- Excellence: Official translation is "卓越 (*Takuetsu*)"; alternative proposal is "向上心 (*Kōjōshin*)", which emphasises continuous self-improvement (while "*Takuetsu*" focuses on being superior to others).
- Respect: Two official translations – "敬意 (*Keii*)" (emphasis on 敬意, reflecting commitment to achieving the highest level through hard work and passion for improvement)

3. Arabic countries

- Friendship (علاقات, symbolising unity, trust and cooperation across nations and cultures)
- Respect (معاملة, deeply rooted in Islamic teachings and the Qur'an, emphasising treating others and oneself with dignity and fairness)

4. Spain (*Spanish*)

- Terms: Excellence (EXCELENCIA), Friendship (AMISTAD), Respect (RESPETO), with meanings consistent with their English counterparts.

7 October, Tuesday – Kitty (China)

How do you see the present & future of the “Olympic family” in terms of inclusion and exclusion of social groups?

The history of the Olympic Movement can be understood as a constant tension between inclusion and exclusion, something that is well captured by the “expansion and reduction” model. Throughout its evolution, the “Olympic family” has gone through phases of openness—expanding participation and promoting diversity—and phases of closure, when political, economic, or ideological factors have limited that openness. At present, the Movement seems to be in a predominantly expansionist phase: the Olympic Games have moved toward gender parity, have incorporated athletes with disabilities through the Paralympic Movement, and have opened space for new, more urban and youth-oriented sports such as skateboarding and breaking. There is also a symbolic effort to include groups that have traditionally been excluded, such as the Refugee Olympic Team. These initiatives express a desire for Olympism to reflect global diversity and reinforce its social legitimacy.

However, this inclusive momentum coexists with dynamics of reduction. The enormous economic and logistical demands still exclude many countries from the Global South and athletes without institutional support. Political decisions by the IOC regarding the participation of certain countries or athletes—for example, in contexts of war or gender identity debates—mark the limits of this openness. In addition, the growing influence of commercial and media interests tends to privilege certain sports and narratives, reducing space for less profitable or less visible expressions. In the future, it is likely that the Olympic Movement will continue to oscillate between these poles: on the one hand, incorporating new forms of inclusion (greater cultural diversity, recognition of diverse gender identities, or even digital sports), and on the other, imposing new boundaries derived from political conflicts, technological inequalities, or debates over competitive “fairness”.

Seen through the lens of the “sport as mirror, sport as tool” model, Olympism clearly reflects the tensions of the contemporary world. It mirrors economic and gender inequalities, migratory crises, and ideological conflicts that shape our societies. Yet at the same time, it functions as a tool used to shape reality: a space for diplomacy, for the visibility of social causes, and

for promoting values of peace, sustainability, and diversity. In the future, this dual condition will likely persist. The Games will continue to reflect the contradictions of a globalised world while also serving as a platform for experimenting with more inclusive forms of coexistence and representation. In that sense, the “Olympic family” seems destined to keep expanding—though never without the inevitable moments of reduction that accompany every deep social transformation.

8 October, Tuesday – Zhang Shichao (China)

- a) *Identify different relations between specific actors in the Larry Nassar case (see the HBO Documentary as well as Internet sources).*
- b) *Discuss these relations in terms of interconnected vulnerabilities and responsibilities, making use of the heuristic instrument ‘integrity Matrix’.*
- c) *What can we learn from the case, and how can we make Olympic sports safer and more ethical on micro, meso, and macro levels?*

Let’s begin with the relationships between the different actors in the Larry Nassar case. One of the most critical dynamics was between Larry Nassar, as the physician, and the athletes he abused. Many of these were young girls who trusted him as a medical professional. But what made this trust particularly damaging was how USA Gymnastics (USAG), as an organisational actor, protected him for years.

USAG not only failed to investigate early complaints properly but in some cases actively discouraged victims from speaking up. There was also a significant relationship between USAG and the U.S. Olympic & Paralympic Committee (USOPC)—which creates an organisational hierarchy where ethical failures in one body can influence the inaction of the other. Not to forget Michigan State University (MSU), which also had complaints and chose to silence them. So, there’s a whole web of complicity.

While most were unaware, in some cases, their faith in the system—and in Nassar—created a kind of blind spot. There were relationships of trust that Nassar strategically exploited. He operated within environments where adults deferred to his expertise, allowing him to abuse under the guise of medical treatment.

Now, if we look at this through the Integrity Matrix, which maps responsibility and vulnerability across individual and organisational levels, it's clear we're dealing with interconnected failures. Let me take one specific cell—"High Responsibility, High Vulnerability" at the individual level. That would be the athletes who tried to report what happened. They were doing the right thing, trying to hold someone accountable, but they were incredibly vulnerable—young, powerless, and often disbelieved.

That fits USA Gymnastics and MSU perfectly. These institutions had the power to investigate and act early on, but they failed in their ethical responsibility. Instead of protecting the athletes, they were focused on protecting their reputation and funding streams. This mismatch is where systemic integrity collapses.

While some were unaware, others dismissed or minimised athlete complaints, showing how passive complicity plays a role. The heuristic model helps us see that integrity isn't just about bad individuals—it's also about who has the ability to act, and whether they choose to.

On the meso level, sports organisations like USAG and MSU must reform their internal reporting and investigation systems. They need independent ethics committees, not people internally reviewing their own failures. Staff should be trained in trauma-informed responses, and transparency should be enforced by policy, not just goodwill.

And at the macro level, the U.S. Olympic & Paralympic Committee and global governing bodies need to take structural action—creating universal safeguarding standards, auditing systems, and establishing a global whistleblower framework for athletes. Funding should be tied to ethical compliance, not just performance.

Also, let's be honest: this case shows how celebrity culture in sports can protect abusers. We need to shift the narrative from glorifying institutions or medals to valuing athlete wellbeing and ethical leadership.

Yes, and beyond sports—this is a reminder that systems designed without checks and balances are vulnerable to abuse. Whether in medicine, education, or athletics, ethical cultures must be intentionally built and constantly monitored.

The Larry Nassar case, as shown through the HBO documentary and other sources, reveals a catastrophic breakdown of integrity at multiple levels. By analysing these relationships through the Integrity Matrix, we see how different

actors carried different levels of responsibility, vulnerability, and power—and how many of them failed to act ethically. Preventing future abuse requires change at every level of the system: empowering individuals, reforming institutions, and regulating governing bodies. Only with such multi-level reform can Olympic sports—and other high-performance environments—become safer, more ethical spaces for everyone involved.

Closing Ceremony

9 OCTOBER 2025



ADDRESS
on behalf of the Seminar's Participants
by Minori HARA (JPN)

Good afternoon, everyone,

It is a great honour to stand here today and speak on behalf of the participants of the 32nd International Seminar on Olympic Studies for Postgraduate Students. Another representative, Berk, will speak after me, but first, I would like to share my experience of this wonderful Seminar.

One of the reasons our Seminar was so special is that we are all postgraduate students, working hard in our Master's or Doctoral programmes. The research topics you are all exploring were truly fascinating and greatly stimulated our academic interests. Although we study in different places and in different fields, we discovered that we share so much knowledge and experience, from our interest in Olympism to the challenges we face as students. It was an invaluable opportunity to share a deep sense of mutual understanding.

This intellectual journey was made possible by the special power of this place, Olympia. This place was truly special, both emotionally and in terms of facilities. Being near both the monument where Coubertin's heart is buried and Ancient Olympia, we could always return to the core spirit of Olympism. Furthermore, the excellent library, the precious archives from Athens 2004, and our unique classroom where we could critically reflect on Olympic history with posters on every wall—all of this created the best possible environment for learning. Thanks to this environment, we were able to focus intently on our studies, both during lecture hours and in our free time.

We will continue to be involved in the Olympic Movement as Olympic Ambassadors. I believe that, as participants of this Postgraduate Seminar, we are especially expected to connect our academic research on the Movement

in a concrete way. Our role is to use our research to create real change. To that end, we will remain engaged in both our research and the Movement.

Finally, on behalf of all the participants, I would like to offer our sincere gratitude. To Prof. Kostas, Jan, Heather, and all professors who guided us to the deep academic world of the Olympics. To Gina, and all the staff of the International Olympic Academy who prepared this wonderful environment and supported us with constant smiles. And to all of you, my friends, with whom I have shared this priceless time and built lifelong friendships. I am sure we will see you soon around the world. Thank you very much.

Soon, we will return to our homes. But we carry with us a flame that was lit in our hearts here in Olympia. We promise to keep this flame alive and make it shine even brighter, each in our own place and in our own way.

Thank you so much.

ありがとうございました。 *Efcharistó!*

ADDRESS
on behalf of the Seminar's Participants
by Berk BILGIN (TUR)

Good afternoon, everyone,

It is an honour and a privilege for me to represent 16 beautiful minds for the 32nd International Seminar on Olympic Studies. I would like to start by thanking Prof. Kostas, Jan, Heather, and all the professors who shared their immense knowledge with us during these incredible 20 or so days. I would like to thank Gina, the administrative staff, and the cafeteria staff for their hospitality.

Now I want to take you back to the first day we had. We left the hotel at 07:45, still quiet but with a growing sense of excitement. It would be a little unfair to call this first morning just sightseeing. We were about to understand why we are here and take our first steps into understanding the origins, ideas, and practices that shaped modern sport. It was time to get familiar with Ancient Greek myths, as we were about to hear a lot of them.

Sports is never just about sports. 2,500 years ago, it was a religious festival held in a religious sanctuary about 500–600 meters from here. Greeks gathered around, watched sports, and celebrated Zeus. I argue that it is not much different now. Even in this room. Some things have changed, of course, like we speak different languages, and we don't really make sacrifices for Zeus, I assume. But one thing is still the same. Sports isn't about sports. It is a part of something that is bigger than itself. And that brings us all together here, this day.

I never met that something bigger until I came here. That something bigger is the very essence of the Olympic spirit: excellence, friendship, and respect. We didn't study these in the classroom; we lived them every single day. Excellence wasn't about being the best, but about giving the best, challenging ourselves, and striving to learn more today than we knew yesterday. Friendship, the unofficial language of our Seminar. The awkward

silences we had quickly transformed into discussions and laughs. We may have arrived as 16 individuals from different corners of the globe, but we leave with a connection that transcends borders. Finally, respect. Respect for this ancient ground we walked on. Respect for our professors who guided us. And most importantly, respect for one another, for our different cultures, our unique perspectives, and our shared passion for the Olympic ideal.

So, as we prepare to leave this special place, we don't just leave with new knowledge. We leave as ambassadors of these values. We are living proof that sport is, and always has been, a powerful tool to build a better world.

On behalf of my fellow participants, thank you for an experience that has not only educated our minds but also enriched our souls. Thank you for this incredible Session, and thank you for sharing your knowledge, time, and sometimes even the football and volleyball field with us. Let's take the spirit of Olympia and share it with the world.

Thank you.

ADDRESS
on behalf of the Seminar's Supervising Professors
by Prof. Heather L. REID (USA)

Next month, just a few hundred meters from here, a sacred flame will be captured from rays of the morning sun and the Olympic torch will be set alight. It will begin its journey to the Games by covering the length of the ancient stadium, then thousands of human hands and feet (hopefully mine included) will carry it in the slowest and most inefficient way possible to Milano, where it will kindle the Olympic cauldron and, more importantly, the imaginations of people all around the world.

The official Olympic torch is ignited in Olympia every couple of years, but almost every day at the IOA a metaphorical Olympic flame kindles the minds and souls of students who come here from all around the world to breathe in the Olympic idea. This is more than information, more than knowledge, more than any computer could ever process. It is inspiration that enables the inspired person to, in turn, inspire others. And like so many Olympic torches, you, 2025 Postgraduate Seminar participants, will return to your countries and spark many more metaphorical Olympic flames in the souls of your own students and countrymen.

You will do this partly with the knowledge you have gained here: the history, the philosophy, the critical analysis of the Olympic Movement itself. And you will do this with the beauty you have experienced, which will reflect in your eyes like a sparkle for friends and students to see. But most importantly you will do this with the mutual understanding, friendship, solidarity, and fair play—that is, the Olympic spirit—which you have cultivated within your group. The Olympic spirit lodges itself in our hearts and, if we allow it, directs everything we do toward a higher ideal.

So, what I'm saying is that the Olympic spirit lives in you and is expressed through your actions. What you studied here, truth be told, could have been

studied virtually in another place at another time, but what you learned here, what you absorbed here in Olympia through your very pores cannot be gained anywhere else. And like Muslims return to Mecca, many of you will return here—some as supervising professors, I have no doubt—to rekindle the Olympic flame in your souls.

Hopefully, the International Olympic Academy will be here to welcome you when you return. This is not just a matter of luck, and there is no guarantee. Many people work hard every day so that we, academics, can inspire and be inspired by Olympic ideals. Their work is just as important to those ideals as ours is, and from the cleaning staff to the maintenance crew, to the people who pump up the volleyballs, all of the staff is to be thanked. Special thanks also go to the Dean and unfaltering teacher, Kostas Georgiadis, whose dedication to this place has transformed it over the 20+ years that I have been coming here.

Coming back here.

Again and again.

To breathe in the air.

To rekindle the flame.

To remember what matters for the Olympic Movement.

And to remember that the Olympic Movement, as defined in the Olympic Charter, includes “all individuals and entities who are inspired by the values of Olympism.”

Like the Olympic torch, let us carry the Olympic spirit out from this place and across the world – together.

ADDRESS
on behalf of the Seminar's Supervising Professors
Prof. Dr Em. Jan TOLLENEER (BEL)

Dear students of the 32nd Postgraduate Seminar, dear colleagues and friends,

Allow me to share a few words—words of appreciation and heartfelt thanks.

Your enthusiasm and dedication in exploring Olympic Studies have brought great joy to all of us who have had the privilege of teaching here. Through your presentations and our many discussions, it became clear that we are often on the same wavelength. When we speak about Olympism, sport, and physical activity, we seem to identify similar challenges, risks, and opportunities.

You have demonstrated a strong commitment to learning and—true to the spirit of postgraduate education—have generously shared your experiences and insights with one another and with your lecturers. This exchange enriches us all, and contributes meaningfully to the broader Olympic Movement.

Indeed, this is one of the key objectives of this programme, and of all programmes offered by the truly unique International Olympic Academy, in this equally unique and almost mythical setting in the western Peloponnese.

Throughout our conversations—sometimes in the background, sometimes front and centre—we explored the parallels between the ancient and modern Games, separated by millennia, as well as between the Games envisioned by Pierre de Coubertin and those of today, more than a century later.

Yet you also showed a keen awareness that such comparisons are complex and delicate. The differences are significant, and they demand sharp analysis and thoughtful policy decisions. The world has changed dramatically since Coubertin's time in the late 19th century, and the Olympic Movement has evolved—sometimes slowly, but understandably so.

The inclusion of female athletes around 1928, and professional athletes around 1992, are just two notable examples. Today, we face new transformations. Emerging developments and ideas keep both students and lecturers alert and engaged. What about transgender athletes and other minority groups? And what about artificial intelligence and related technologies?

Will the Olympic Movement succeed in responding in a timely and appropriate way—adapting to the times without compromising its core principles? Or might those principles themselves be open to thoughtful revision?

It is up to the younger generations to seek answers. Each of you can play a role, shaped by your own background, values, culture, country, academic discipline, and professional experience.

This is not always easy. Challenges lie ahead. It reminds us of the stormy weather and heavy rain earlier this week. The path had turned into a river—it seemed almost impossible to reach the classroom. Yet we made it. And after the rain came sunshine. Our shoes and clothes dried, and the obstacles were overcome. That day, I added two songs to my Spotify playlist: *Rain and Tears* by Aphrodite's Child, and *Here Comes the Sun* by The Beatles.

To meet the challenges facing the Olympic Movement, we must strike a balance—between universal ideals and the concrete realities of each country and culture. There are many cross-cultural differences in policy, practice, and language. Respecting these differences and sensitivities is one of the tasks ahead.

These three weeks in Olympia, with their many discussions and working group sessions, have certainly helped us move in that direction. And the highlight of yesterday's closing dinner will stay with us for a long time: a student from China reading a message in Portuguese, someone from South Africa offering a greeting in Turkish, someone from Spain making a toast in Armenian... It felt like you had invented a new party game!

Let me conclude with a word of thanks. We thank the International Olympic Academy for its generous hospitality, and Professor Kostas Georgiadis for his inspiration and friendship.

In truth, we have found nothing but friends in this magical place. Gina and Anastasia, thank you for your tireless efforts.

And to all our colleagues from the administrative and technical staff—

including the photographers, kitchen team, maintenance crew, ICT staff, and, last but not least, the bar—thank you.

Students, you are always welcome here in Olympia, and you are warmly welcome in Leuven and Belgium. Good luck with your studies, your careers, and your lives. Take care—and keep in touch.

CLOSING ADDRESS
by the Dean of the International Olympic Academy
Prof. Dr Konstantinos GEORGIADIS

Dear friends,

As we come to the end of this inspiring seminar, I am full of gratitude and hope.

Over these past three weeks in Ancient Olympia, in the Academy, we have shared ideas, challenged perspectives, and, most importantly, reconnected with the true essence of Olympism—the belief that sport can move the world and humanity forward.

We spoke of athletes—not only as competitors, but as ambassadors of peace and integrity. We explored how the Olympic Games continue to unite nations, even in moments of division.

We reflected on Olympism—a living philosophy that invites us to build bridges, not walls; to embrace technology like AI, not as a threat, but as a tool to serve human progress.

We learned that creating a better world through sport begins with each of us. It begins when we listen to others, when we respect differences, and when we find the courage to act with fairness while playing together. The Olympic flame is not just a symbol—it is a call to responsibility.

As we return home, let us carry with us the lessons of Olympia: that true victory lies in effort, not in numbers; in cooperation, not in competition alone; in the human spirit that refuses to give up on peace.

May each of you continue this journey—as teachers, as leaders, or in another position, as lifelong students of the Olympic ideal.

Finally, I would like to thank every one of you who contributed to the Postgraduate Seminar. I would like to thank all the professors, especially Jan Tolleneer and Heather Reid. The contribution of Gina was great. I also would like to thank Vangelis, Angeliki, Konstantina, and Panos.

Thank you for your participation and have a safe return to your countries.
Thank you.



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ISBN: 978-960-9454-76-6

ISSN: 2654-1343